An optimisation approach for supply chain procurement transport operational planning with 3D full-truck loading constraints and returnable transport items

This paper proposes a mixed integer linear programming model, dubbed 3D-SCPTOP, for procurement transport planning in manufacturing supply chains, integrating the procurement, inventory and transport decisions of an assembly plant and its supplier with three-dimensional full-truckload constraints and the closed-loop management of returnable transport items. Because the placement subproblem is NP-hard and the compact model replicates it once per loading configuration, we reformulate the problem by Dantzig–Wolfe decomposition, taking the complete loaded truck as the unit of decision. The decomposition is derived structurally, and the result is materially simpler than the model it replaces: the trucks of a direction and period are anonymous, so they are aggregated into counts, and the master then couples to the geometry through nothing but the definition of two aggregate flows and one count of trucks per direction and period. No loading configuration appears in the master. Every placement, stack-height, crush, payload and full-truckload constraint lives inside one pricing problem per direction, which is the compact model's own block with the quantifier over trucks removed. A column is a fully specified, geometrically realisable truck load with its layout retained, so the per-stack crush cap is evaluated on the product mix actually loaded rather than on a worst-case bound, and every plan is executable by construction; each dispatched truck is re-verified independently of the solver that produced it. The master is solved by a two-level branch and bound over the fleet vector whose primal heuristic is a relax-and-fix procedure, and because every placeable load is volumetrically feasible, a certified bound of the volumetric relaxation is a valid lower bound for the 3D problem. The method is assessed in two stages. Where the compact formulation is still solvable and so provides a reference — the volumetric problem — it returns a plan 0.0006% above a proved optimum at the same fleet of forty-five trucks, with a certified bound 0.0114% below that optimum, and it beats the compact model's incumbent on four further instances on which that model exhausts its memory budget. On the 3D problem, where the compact model returns no incumbent beyond five periods, it returns verified plans on thirty-one of thirty-six generated instances and on all five rungs of a ladder reaching twenty-four products and twenty periods, with certified gaps under 0.05% and provably minimum fleets through twelve periods. Of the 724 truck loads a volumetric model prescribes over the generated instances, 501 are *proved* impossible to place in a trailer and 174 are left undecided; re-planning the trucks of such a plan while keeping its delivery quantities needs 74 and 212 trucks where the method plans 54 and 160 directly. A volumetric transport capacity, which most of the procurement transport literature assumes, is therefore not a conservative simplification: its error has a direction, and the planner discovers it on the loading dock.

This paper proposes a new mixed integer linear mathematical programming (MILP) model, dubbed 3D-SCPTOP, for procurement transport planning in manufacturing supply chains. The model effectively integrates procurement and transport decisions while accounting for three-dimensional full-truck loading constraints and managing returnable transport items (RTIs). Thus, we optimise the material to procure for an assembly manufacturing site, RTIs closed-loop management, and the involved transport decisions, including the truck loading configuration. Procurement transport decisions are based on the demand of assemblers, the supplier's inventory levels, and the dimensions of the truck / RTIs. The optimisation model aims to minimise transportation and inventory costs. Because the loading subproblem is NP-hard and is replicated once per loading configuration, the compact model is intractable at industrial sizes. We therefore reformulate it by Dantzig–Wolfe

decomposition, taking the complete loaded truck as the unit of decision: a column is a fully specified, geometrically realisable truck load, so every placement, height, crush-limit, payload and full-truckload constraint holds inside it by construction, and the per-stack crush cap is evaluated on the actual product mix rather than on a worst-case bound. Columns are priced on demand by a constraint programming oracle, and the master is solved by a two-level branch and bound over the fleet vector, yielding MATH-3D-SCPTOP: the first level partitions on the total number of trucks, whose cost the relaxation cannot offset, and the second on the per-period dispatch counts inside a fixed total. Its primal heuristic is a flow-first construction that decides shipment quantities and truck counts in an aggregate integer master and then partitions each period's deliveries into exactly that many legal trucks, so the pool receives both the extreme loads that pricing returns and the balanced loads that no dual vector can produce. Because every placeable load is volumetrically feasible, a certified bound of the volumetric relaxation is a valid lower bound for the 3D problem, and it is the bound the method reports. Columns arrive through a pricing ladder: a heuristic rung run under the current duals serves most pairs, the exact oracle the rest, and the certifying sweep is always exact. On the five-period instance the relaxation solves to optimality at exactly the cost of the verified 3D plan, which establishes that plan as optimal for the 3D problem. On the five-period instance where the compact 3D model returns a plan, the reformulation's plan is 0.10% cheaper than the compact model's and lies within 0.0076% of the method's own certified bound; the compact model's plan is the comparator there; from ten periods on the compact model finds no feasible solution within its budget while the reformulation returns verified plans, with gaps of 0.17% and 0.03% to its own certified bound at ten and twelve periods (0.010% to the compact volumetric model's dual bound at ten), a certified bound 7.4% above the compact model's own dual bound at twelve, and truck counts proved minimal through twelve periods by a certificate that the region with one truck fewer is infeasible; at twenty periods, twenty-four products and a fleet of twenty-one it certifies its bound in seconds and returns a verified 160-truck plan in 3 492 s, 13.3% above a bound that is loose exactly where the crush limit binds; the loads a volumetric plan dispatches are put to a placeability proof, and where the crush limit binds 91% and 87% of them are proved impossible to place, against 8% where it does not; re-planning the trucks of such a plan while keeping its delivery quantities – the competent repair, consolidating each period's freight with the same machinery the method uses – needs 74 and 212 trucks where the reformulation plans 54 and 160 directly, so the reformulation uses 27% and 25% fewer trucks and costs 19% and 16% less than a volumetric plan repaired properly, and more again than one repaired load by load; and the comparison yields a mechanism: the volumetric abstraction fails in proportion to how much it over-credits a truck relative to what physically fits, a quantity computable from the catalogue alone; the divergence between height-limited and crush-limited layer counts is one of its two causes, the other being how badly a footprint tiles the trailer floor. Every plan the method returns is re-verified truck by truck, independently of the solver that produced it. The approach is evaluated on a case study in an automotive seating first-tier supplier against the company's spreadsheet-based procedure, and against a benchmark model that represents truck capacity volumetrically, whose plans are cheaper on paper to the extent that the truck loads it prescribes cannot be placed in a trailer.

Keywords— Procurement, inventory, transport planning, full-truckload, 3D container loading

1 Introduction

Optimizing the use of resources in manufacturing supply chains is crucial for boosting economic growth, improving social well-being, and minimizing environmental impact. Integrating transport, inventory, and production processes is a fundamental characteristic of supply chains (Stadtler, Kilger, and Meyr 2015) because joint decisions will improve supply chain performance(Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2017).

Procurement refers to the process of acquiring goods and services in a supply chain (Chopra and Meindl 2015). One of the main goals of procurement is to obtain raw materials, parts or finished goods for a factory or distribution centre from a supplier. As mentioned in (Fleischmann, Kopfer, and Sürie 2015), the responsibility for transport planning usually lies with the supplier. However, sometimes the manufacturer makes transport decisions of its supplies in, for example, the automotive industry. Furthermore, an essential asset in the automotive supply chain is not considered in traditional material requirement planning (MRP): returnable containers or returnable transport items (RTI), which are used as tertiary packaging. RTIs enable

the storage and transportation of RM and FG through the supply chain. Usually, the manufacturing plant supplies empty RTIs to its supplier, while the supplier delivers full RTIs with the FG or RM. Therefore, during the procurement process, transport and inventory decisions should be integrated, including RTI management. Here, we focus on optimising the operational decisions made during procurement transport planning.

According to (Díaz-Madroñero, Peidro, and Mula 2014), using algorithm-based methods for procurement transport planning is more effective than relying on manual approaches based on planners' intuition. Manual planning can be short-sighted and lead to less efficient outcomes. This becomes even more significant when optimizing procurement transport tasks that aim to reduce the number of trucks and inventory levels, especially under 3D loading constraints where the precise placement of containers within trucks must also be determined. Furthermore, the capacity constraints used in the scientific literature on procurement transport planning are based mainly on freight volume or the total number of loaded product units (Hashemi-Amiri, Ghorbani, and Ji 2023) and (Díaz-Madroñero, Peidro, and Mula 2014). The current research seeks to address this gap by introducing a new mixed-integer linear programming (MILP) model. This model uniquely combines procurement transportation with considerations for 3D loading, inventory management, and RTI management. Hereafter, we refer to this model formulation as 3D supply chain procurement transport operational planning (3D-SCPTOP). Additionally, a matheuristic procedure (MATH-3D-SCPTOP) is researched.

In this paper, we present four main contributions, listed in the order of the evidence behind them. (i) We formulate a novel MILP model, 3D-SCPTOP, integrating procurement transport, RTI management and inventory decisions with stack-based full-truck loading constraints. (ii) We reformulate it by Dantzig–Wolfe decomposition over geometrically realisable truck loads, deriving the decomposition structurally and obtaining a master in which *no loading configuration appears at all*: the master couples to the geometry through two aggregate-flow definitions and one truck count per direction and period, and the pricing problem of a direction is the compact model's own block with the quantifier over trucks removed. We solve it by a branch and bound over the fleet vector with column generation, a constraint programming pricing oracle, and a relax-and-fix construction as primal heuristic, giving MATH-3D-SCPTOP, and we show that a certified bound of the volumetric relaxation is a valid lower bound for the 3D problem. (iii) We establish the method's accuracy where a reference optimum exists — on the volumetric problem, against the compact formulation, which it matches to 0.0006% of a proved optimum — and then show that it keeps returning verified, executable plans and certified bounds in the 3D regime beyond which the compact model returns no incumbent at all. (iv) We show by independent placeability proof that a volumetric representation of truck capacity, as used in the procurement transport literature, yields plans that are cheaper on paper but cannot be loaded in practice, and we quantify what repairing them costs. A fifth item is set up but *not* delivered in this revision: the comparison of the method against the company's own spreadsheet procedure on the case-study instances, for the reasons given in Section 6.6.

Readers are referred to the typology by (Wäscher, Haußner, and Schumann 2007) for a global view of container loading problems, where the different dimensions of the loading problem are described. Furthermore, (Silva, Toffolo, and Wauters 2019) summarise the exact methods used in the literature to solve container loading problems, and (X. Zhao et al. 2016) explore other solution approaches in the literature. Readers are also referred to the literature reviews of (Mosca, Vidyarthi, and Satir 2019) and (Díaz-Madroñero, Peidro, and Mula 2015), which focus more on integrating inventory decisions and transport. Here, we jointly address container loading, procurement transport and inventory decisions.

The paper is organised as follows. Section 2 provides a literature review related to the problem under study. Section 3 presents the problem description. Section 4 describes the 3D-SCPTOP MILP formulation. Section 5 develops the branch and price solution approach, MATH-3D-SCPTOP, together with its pricing subproblem and bounding arguments. Section 6 reports the computational experiments and Section 7 the case study. Finally, Section 8 concludes and puts forward further research lines.

2 Literature Review

The goal of this research is to integrate procurement transport operational planning decisions with 3D loading restrictions and RTI packaging. Based on the authors' research, no previous work has been identified that meets this criterion. Therefore, three independent, but sometimes overlapping, knowledge bodies have been reviewed: procurement transport and inventory planning, container loading problems and RTI literature.

2.1 Procurement transport and inventory planning

Models that integrate transport and inventory costs during the procurement process are widely studied in the literature. As noted in (Langley et al. 2020), transportation facilitates the movement of raw materials and finished products between suppliers, warehouses, manufacturers, and retailers. Therefore, transport processes play a crucial role in supply chains. (Fleischmann, Kopfer, and Sürie 2015) distinguish between two main types of transportation within a supply chain: "procurement transport," which involves moving materials from suppliers to manufacturing sites, and the "distribution of goods," which concerns delivering finished products from factories to customers. This article focuses specifically on addressing the challenges related to procurement transportation.

There are two main dimensions of procurement transport problems according to the supply chain configuration and the applied transport method. Regarding supply chain configurations (Mosca, Vidyarthi, and Satir 2019): (i) single source to a single destination (SS); (ii) multiple sources to a single destination (MS); (iii) single source to multiple destinations (SM); (iv) multiple sources to multiple destinations (MM). Source components determine the number of supplier locations that are taken into account, while destination components denote the number of supplied manufacturers. Additionally, different transport methods are identified in (Díaz-Madroñero, Peidro, and Mula 2014):milk run, less-than-truckload (LTL), full-truckload (FTL) . We also analyze the formulation of the transportation capacity constraints in the scientific literature.

(Berman and Wang 2006) address the problem of optimising distribution strategies to deliver products from suppliers to plants, whose aim is to minimise transport, pipeline and plant inventory costs by using cross docks. A mixed integer non-linear programming (MINLP) formulation, a Lagrangian relaxation heuristic, a greedy heuristic, and a branch-and-bound algorithm are proposed to model and solve the problem.

(Sancak and Salman 2011) present a MILP model to optimise procurement transport decisions in a SS supply chain configuration using LTL and FTL transport methods. The objective is to minimise transport and inventory holding costs, while fulfilling production plan requirements on a multiperiod planning horizon. The study explores the possibility of delaying LTL shipments to the subsequent time period, and utilising safety stocks whenever necessary, in a stochastic environment by employing data from a bus manufacturer. The findings demonstrate that delaying shipments leads to reduced holding and transport costs with a minimal stockout risk.

(Schöneberg, Koberstein, and Suhl 2010) examine the concept of delivery profiles, which define the delivery frequency at a fixed rate, offering structured planning, minimizing management effort, and improving coordination in logistics. In this context, FTL transport is used when the goods' volume exceeds a vehicle's capacity, making direct shipment possible. LTL is applied when the volume is insufficient to fill a truck, and the goods are first sent to a consolidation center before reaching the final destination. In (Schöneberg, Koberstein, and Suhl 2013), the proposed model accounts for demand uncertainty.

(Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2014) present a fuzzy multi-objective integer linear programming (FMOILP) model that focuses on operational procurement transport planning in an automotive supply chain, which involves a single source and a single destination while utilising FTL. The developed model aims to minimise the number of trucks employed for procurement transport and the inventory level by considering the uncertainties related to transport capacity levels.

(Hein and Almeder 2016) investigate the benefits of integrated procurement transport and production planning for supply and production processes by comparing a sequential approach, where production is firstly determined, followed by procurement transport decisions, plus an integrated approach in which decisions are jointly made. Numerical experiments reveal that the integrated planning approach leads to substantial cost savings.

(Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2017) present an novel MILP model that integrates procurement, production and transport planning decisions within manufacturing systems. This model extends beyond traditional material requirement planning (MRP) systems by incorporating procurement transport decisions from multiple sources and a single destination into a unified optimization framework. It considers the capacities of both material and production resources, along with procurement transport planning decisions, by employing various shipping modes such as FTL, LTL, and milk-run.

(Chitsaz, Cordeau, and Jans 2019) address integrating production, inventory and procurement transport into a manufacturing context by defining this problem as an assembly routing problem (ARP). It introduces a novel MILP model for the ARP and proposes a three-phase decomposition matheuristic for its solution.

(Baller et al. 2022) examine the optimization of procurement transport in an automotive factory, focusing on first-tier suppliers at an aggregate level across multiple sources (570) to a single destination, using FTL, LTL, and courier express service (CES) as transportation methods. The proposed MILP approach includes a cyclic inventory constraint, truck utilization, and storage limitations.

(Hashemi-Amiri, Ghorbani, and Ji 2023) propose an integrated approach to optimize a perishable food

supply chain. The model combines supplier selection, procurement and distribution transport, production scheduling, and vehicle routing to improve supply chain efficiency and resilience. It handles demand uncertainties through a distributionally robust chance-constrained model. The model is reformulated as MILP by utilizing duality and linearization techniques.

2.2 Procurement Transport with RTIs

Some models further integrate the procurement and delivery of RTIs into the procurement transport literature. In this sense, RTIs are procured to the supplier, who loads the items and sends them to customer. We extend the SC definitions previously defined to contemplate the RTIs management strategies.

Model a food closed-loop supply chain network design problem incorporating returnable transport items (RTIs), product perishability, facility location and demand uncertainty. A two-stage non-linear chance-constrained programming model minimizes fixed facility, production, transport, inventory holding and RTI costs while ensuring a target service level. It's linearized via sample average approximation and distribution-free methods to capture forward RTI-based shipments and reverse flows for reuse. To solve large instances, an improved Lagrangian relaxation algorithm decomposes facility-location and flow decisions, outperforming CPLEX on solution quality and speed.

(Soysal et al. 2023) develop a tactical-level, multi-period closed-loop Vendor-Managed Inventory (VMI) system for RTIs in an agro-food SC. The SM SC integrates forward flows of full RTIs from a single vendor to multiple customers and reverse flows of empties back to the vendor for cleaning . All routing and inventory decisions are made centrally by the vendor under full information sharing. Sustainable plans in terms of amounts of energy spent and empty crates collected are devised and evaluated.

(Guo et al. 2024) model two-tier Container Management Centre (CMC) network . Empty RTIs are dispatched from central CMC hubs to upstream suppliers, loaded with products, carried by truck to downstream customers, then returned empty to regional CMCs for cleaning and storage before being shipped back to central hubs. A neural network is used for demand forecasting. A MILP is proposed that maximises total profit by optimally determining transport costs and the penalties applied to late RTIs returns.

(Y. Zhang et al. 2024) formulate a perishable-food inventory-routing MILP with multiple RTI types in a SM supply chain, integrating procurement of products and pickup of both filled and empty RTIs. Decisions are made on a operational level, optimally determining per period the quantities to pack, deliver, pick up, purchase and lose, as well as the vehicle routes in order to maximise the total profit of the SC that is equal to the total quality-dependent revenue minus the total costs involved, including inventory holding costs, product cost, transportation costs, and RTI purchasing and loss costs. The model is solved exactly via CPLEX solver and approximately via a tailored Kernel Search matheuristic.

2.3 Container loading

Container loading problems encompass a subset of geometric assignment problems known as cutting and packing ($C\&P$) problems. They revolve around the allocation of n-dimensional orthotope items in larger n-dimensional orthotope containers. Here the aim is to optimise an objective function while taking into account two key geometric constraints: complete containment of items inside containers and lack of item overlap. A loading pattern serves as a formal representation of a solution to such an assignment problem. Dyckhoff introduced in (Dyckhoff 1990) a typology that unifies $C\&P$ problems using four different criteria: dimensionality of space, the objective of assignment, containers types and box type. Consequently, (Wäscher, Haußner, and Schumann 2007) develop a new typology that has become the standard in the $C\&P$ literature. We briefly describe the typology used in (Wäscher, Haußner, and Schumann 2007) based on five different criteria: (i) dimensionality of space; (ii) kind of assignment (input minimisation of containers for all small items and loading patterns; output maximisation to pack a subset of small items with limited container availability;) (iii) assortment of small item by distinguishing if they are either a weakly (or strongly) heterogeneous assortment or identical small items ; (iv) assortment of large objects (if it is either several large objects or one large object); (v) shape of small items (circular or of another shape). Table 1 links the standard $C\&P$ nomenclature and the criteria of the typology according to (Wäscher, Haußner, and Schumann 2007).

The first mathematical programming model in a scientific journal to describe the container-loading problem was developed in (C. S. Chen, Lee, and Shen 1995), where the authors introduced an MILP model to address the 3D input minimisation problem by considering rotations and containers of varying dimensions. However, it does not specify the use of weakly or strongly heterogeneous boxes or containers. Additionally, real-world constraints are modelled like, for example, weight distribution.

(Junqueira, Morabito, and Sato Yamashita 2012b) propose an alternative MILP formulation to (C. S. Chen, Lee, and Shen 1995) using binary encoding for box position, which utilises normal patterns to reduce possible box coordinates by considering multiples of boxes dimensions and ensuring optimal solutions. Additionally, loading and cargo constraints are developed to ensure the static and dynamic stability of the cargo. Boxes must be supported by other box top faces or the container floor. The same authors integrate further loading restrictions in (Junqueira, Morabito, and Sato Yamashita 2012a), where they integrate multidrop constraints, which address the challenge of packing a truck with boxes for different customers at various destinations. The goal is to plan the container's loading to minimise the time spent unloading and reloading boxes at each destination.

(W. Zhu and Lim 2012) devise a tree search-based method to solve SLOPP and SKP with 3D constraints. Their approach involves evaluating free spaces by employing a look-ahead tree search and selecting optimal placements based on the best free space-block pairs.

(Gonçalves and Resende 2013) develop a biased random-key genetic algorithm (BRKGA) designed to solve SBSBPP. The algorithm addresses geometric constraints and introduces a maximal-space representation to handle available free spaces in bins. A novel placement procedure is hybridised with the BRKGA, which optimises the order of box packing and the parameters utilised by the placement procedure to offer an effective solution approach to an NP hard problem.

(Bortfeldt and Wäscher 2013) identify constraints for $C\&P$, including item-related constraints (orientation constraints, load bearing, loading priorities), container-related constraints (weight distribution and weight limit), and cargo-related constraints (complete-shipment constraints) and load-related constraints (complexity constraints or stability constraints). The study also highlights the achievements and deficits in container loading research that pertain to these constraints.

(Paquay, Schyns, and Limbourg 2016) propose an MILP model for the MBSBPP. One noteworthy constraint is the assumption that containers are truncated parallelepiped instead of rectangular boxes. They also consider constraints, such as box rotation, container load bearing, weight distribution, stability and fragility of items.

(Mahvash, Awasthi, and Chauhan 2018) introduce a novel resolution procedure for the SBSBPP through the column generation technique, where the columns that are generated are the loading configurations of a single bin. For the pricing develop problem they develop a heuristic to find new columns with a negative reduced cost. This approach not only produces better results than the previous articles on the literature, but also gives new lower bounds.

(Silva, Toffolo, and Wauters 2019) study SSLOP models with 3D constraints. These authors compare the different approaches that exist in the literature for model packing problems based on two fundamental approaches: discretised formulation (Junqueira, Oliveira, et al. 2013) and continuous formulation (C. S. Chen, Lee, and Shen 1995) with subsequent modifications. They also indicate that discretised formulation(Junqueira, Morabito, and Sato Yamashita 2012a) performs the best for instances with similar sized boxes. However, it encounters memory limitations for large instances. For other sets of instances, the adapted formulations of (C. S. Chen, Lee, and Shen 1995) and (Paquay, Schyns, and Limbourg 2016) outperform other adaptations. Further research topics suggest including the design of new formulations by considering the limited approaches in the literature.

(Kurpel et al. 2020) introduce techniques and exact approaches to solve input minimisation and output maximisation problems for container-loading problems. Their methods consider practical constraints, such as orientation, separation of boxes and vertical stability. A set partitioning method is also employed in order to obtain upper bounds in a container-loading input minimisation problems. The authors adapt and evaluate four discretisation methods found in the existing literature and incorporate mathematical formulations to address the aforementioned constraints.

(Alonso, Alvarez-Valdes, and Parreño 2020) develop an algorithm by the greedy randomised adaptive search procedure (GRASP) to tackle a practical container-loading problem with time-sensitive constraints. Their approach addresses dynamic stability constraints while stacking products on pallets and loading them onto trucks during different time periods. Their approach provides high-quality solutions and surpasses an integer programming formulation in efficiency and effectiveness terms.

(Ali et al. 2022) conduct a comprehensive literature review by identifying constraints and solution methods for offline problems with full knowledge of the items to be packed and those tackling the online problems, where items are packed immediately when they arrive, and no prior knowledge of an item is known. The study also identifies and classifies solution approaches for offline packing into six categories: exact methods, constructive heuristics; local search and metaheuristic methods; approximation algorithms; machine learning and hyper-heuristic methods; tree search methods. (Harrath 2022) proposed a thee stage heuristic based on layer generation to find good quality solutions the SBSPP problem for large instance up to 993 bins and 200000 items taking into account load balancing constraints.

(Tresca et al. 2022) develop a matheuristic to solve the SBSBPP that includes items with different IDs and different categories, to be delivered to different clients. The algorithm creates monoitem, monocategory, and mixed layers which then are used to compute the final loading configurations of the bins.

(Li, M. Chen, and Huo 2022) develope a hybrid adaptaive large neighborhood search algoritm to solve the multiple container loading problem, which is tries pack a given set of items with the minimum number of containers while maximazing the space utilization of them. Therfore, it is both a MBSBPP and a MSSCSP. Their approach takes into account some practical applications such as supsension constraints, rotation and weight limit.

(M. Chen, Huo, and Duan 2023) present a new approach to the 3D-BPP, introducing the 3D-BSDPP which focuses on optimizing both the design of bin sizes and the packing process. A novel Hybrid Biogeography-Based Optimization (HBBO) algorithm is proposed, integrating differential evolution and a local search strategy for enhanced performance.

One noteworthy trend in $C\&P$ is integrating loading problems with routing. This is known as capacitated vehicle-routing problem with 3D or 2D loading constraints (3L-CVRP or 2L-CVRP). (Junqueira, Morabito, and Sato Yamashita 2012b) present a MILP model with binary encodings for 3L-CVRP by including loading, cargo and multidrop constraints. The combination of these two NP-hard problems requires using heuristics and metaheuristics for real-world instances, as seen in (Dominguez et al. 2016), (Alonso, Martinez-Sykora, et al. 2022) and (Wei et al. 2015). Another noteworthy trend is to use reinforcement learning techniques to solve $C\&P$, as in (Que, Yang, and D. Zhang 2023) and (H. Zhao, C. Zhu, and Huang 2022).

2.4 Research Gaps & Methodology

Here, we discuss the main differences between the 3D-SCPTOP model proposal and those reviewed by specifically focusing on procurement transport. The key distinction of the 3D-SCPTOP model compared to the existing literature is the incorporation of 3D constraints and vertical stability constraints to model transport capacity with a view to providing more realistic solutions and reducing the likelihood of infeasible outcomes. Table 1 presents a comparison of inventory modelling, transport modelling, and supply chain configuration between the 3D-SCPTOP model proposal and those currently in the literature. Hence, the 3D-SCPTOP approach is based on a SS supply chain configuration, and takes into account the FTL transportation mode.

Article	SC Configuration	Decision level	Transportation Mode	Transportation Capacity Constraint	Transportation Cost	Inventory Capacity Restriction	RTIs	Inventory Costs	Safety Stocks	Modelling Framework
(Guo et al. 2024)	MM	TO	FTL	UH	X	X	S—NF	X		MINLP
(Berman and Wang 2006)	MM	T	FTL—LTL	V	X			X		MINLP
(Sancak and Salman 2011)		O	LTL—FTL	V	X			X	X	MILP
(Schöneberg, Koberstein, and Suhl 2010)	MS	T	FTL—LTL	V	X	X		X		MILP
(Schöneberg, Koberstein, and Suhl 2013)	MS	O	FTL—LTL	V	X	X		X		MILP
(Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2014)	SS	O	FTL	UH	X			X	X	FMOILP
(Hein and Almeder 2016)	MS	O	MR	V	X			X		MILP
(Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2017)	MS	T	FTL—LTL—MR	V	X	X		X	X	MILP
(Meyer and Amberg 2018)	MS	T—O	MR—FTL	V	X	X		X		MILP
(Chitsaz, Cordeau, and Jans 2019)	MS	O—T	MR	V	X	X		X		MILP
(Baller et al. 2022)	MS	O	MR—FTL—LTL—CES	V—W	X	X			X	MILP
(Hashemi-Amiri, Ghorbani, and Ji 2023)	MS	T	MR	V	X					CCP
3D-SCPTOP	SS	O	FTL	3D-Constraints	X	X		X	X	MILP
(Y. Zhang et al. 2024)	MS	TO	MR	UH	X	X	M—NF	X		ILP

Abbreviations. **T** (tactical), **O** Operational; **FTL** (full-truck load), **LTL** (less-than-truck load), **MR** (milk-run), **CES** (courier express service); **V** (volumetric), **W** (weight), **UH** Unit Holding; **CCP** chance-constrained programming

Table 1: Comparison of procurement transport models

On the other hand, the 3D-SCTOP model diverges from those proposed in the packaging literature in several aspects. Firstly, the loading problem takes into account different time periods. Therefore, the specific container (small items or boxes in the $C\&P$ literature) that we utilise are yet to be defined, as the choice of container depends on the inventory levels of each product. Also, the objective function depends on inventory and transport costs, which are inherently connected to the loading problem at hand. Thefore, we simultaneously solve an input minimisation and output maximisation problem. Both of these are a result of transport minimisation and inventory costs. Input minimisation comes because we want to find the minimum number of trucks needed. Meanwhile, output maximization comes from the FTL and the transport costs.

Based on the literature review and the identified research gaps, our proposal is structured according to the steps depicted in Figure 1.

Article	Problem type	Resolution procedure	Orientation	Weight	Load Balance	Stability	Time-Depenent
(W. Zhu and Lim 2012)	SLOP—SKP	TSM	X	X			
(Gonçalves and Resende 2013)	SBSBPP	BRKGA	X	X		X	
(Paquay, Schyns, and Limbourg 2016)	SBSBPP	EM	X	X	X	X	
(Mahvash, Awasthi, and Chauhan 2018)	SBSBPP	CG	X	X			
(Alonso, Alvarez-Valdes, and Parreño 2020)	SSSCSP	GRASP	X	X	X	X	X
(Tresca et al. 2022)	SBSBPP	MH	X	X	X	X	
(Harrath 2022)	SBSBPP	H	X	X	X		
(Li, M. Chen, and Huo 2022)	SBSBPP—MSSCSP	HALNs	X	X		X	
(M. Chen, Huo, and Duan 2023)	BSDPP	HBBO	X	X			
3D-SCPTOP	SSSCSP & MILOPP	MH	X	X	X	X	X

Abbreviations. **T**SM (Tree search method), **BRKGA** Biased Randomized Jey Genetic Algorithm; **EM** (Exact Metods), **MH** (MatHeuristic), **CG** (Column Generation), **H** (Heuristic); **HCLP** (Hybrid Adaptive Large Neighborhood Search), **HBBO** (Hybrid Biogeography-Based Optimization)

Table 2: Comparison of C&P problems

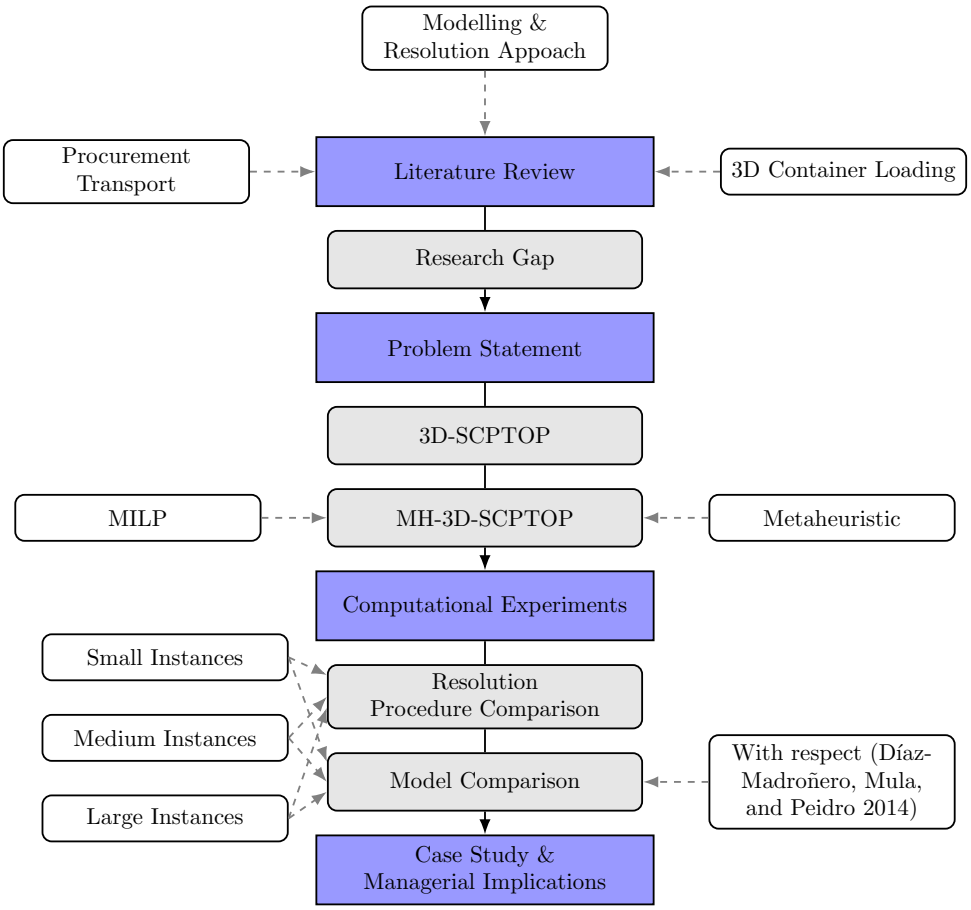


Figure 1: Research Methodology

3 Problem Description

The objective is to minimise the transportation and inventory holding costs of a manufacturing site by integrating procurement transport, RTI management and inventory decisions with full-truckload (FTL) loading constraints expressed in a stack-based form. The supply chain under study has a single source and a single destination. Products are shipped in different RTI types. RTIs are not placed individually in three dimensions but are grouped into vertical *stacks* whose 2D footprints are placed on the truck floor. Each stack type has a fixed footprint and is compatible with a subset of RTI types; each layer of a stack is homogeneous (all RTIs in a layer share a single type), while different layers of the same stack may carry different compatible RTI types. The total stack height is bounded by the truck height and the weight borne by the bottom of each stack is bounded by a crush-limit cap. Trucks carry full RTIs from the supplier to

the plant and return folded empties from the plant to the supplier; folding affects RTI height, and hence the number of layers that fit in a stack, but not the stack footprint.

The assembler's demand drives the procurement process because it determines the optimal quantity of each product to procure from the supplier to the manufacturing site. Raw materials and assembled parts are produced at the supplier, packed in their corresponding RTI, and transported under FTL. Each RTI carries a single product type at any given time, and each product is shipped in a single RTI type. Once full RTIs arrive at the plant, the products are consumed and the RTIs are emptied, folded and returned to the supplier.

Stacks must not overlap and must be contained within the truck's floor; the truck's total weight is bounded; and the per-stack weight cap is respected with *period-exact* knowledge of the products loaded in each slot, so that crush-limit tests reflect the actual period's load rather than a worst-case bound. Stacks may be rotated by 90° on the truck floor. Because stacks are self-supporting by construction, no additional vertical-stability constraints are required. As FTL is the mode of transport, a dispatched truck must be full — but a truck may be full either because it has run out of space or because it has run out of payload, so the requirement is imposed on whichever of the two resources binds. Minimum coverage stock is enforced on future demand.

Initial data.

- **Product data:** initial inventory, periodic demand (in full RTIs) at the plant and at the supplier, product-to-RTI mapping, weight of each full RTI.
- **RTI data:** height when full and when folded, weight of a folded RTI, volume.
- **Stack data:** footprint (p_h, q_h) of each stack type $h \in H$, set of compatible RTI types $R(h)$, and, for each $r \in R(h)$, number of RTIs per layer n_{hr}.
- **Transport data:** number of available trucks, truck length/width/height, truck weight capacity, per-stack weight cap, minimum truck utilisation on the binding resource.

To determine.

- A set of loading configurations (LCs), each specifying the stack-type assignment, 2D placement and orientation of its slots, and the number of layers of each compatible RTI type in each slot.
- The number of trucks used per day and the LC they employ.
- The number of full RTIs of each product loaded in each slot per period (plant-bound trucks) and the number of folded RTIs of each type loaded per truck (supplier-bound trucks).
- The resulting inventory of full and folded RTIs at both nodes.

Subject to.

- 2D non-overlap and containment of stacks on the truck floor, with allowed 90° rotation.
- Per-stack height budget.
- Per-stack crush-limit weight cap, period-exact on plant-bound trucks and deterministic on supplier-bound trucks.
- Per-truck weight capacity.
- Minimum truck utilisation, on volume or on payload, whichever binds.
- Minimum coverage stock.

In order to:

- Minimise total transportation cost.
- Minimise total inventory holding cost.

4 Mathematical Model

The 3D-SCPTOP formulation integrates stack-based truck-loading constraints with procurement transport and inventory decisions. It departs from a standard 3D container-loading formulation in two related ways. First, the 3D placement of individual RTIs inside the truck is replaced by a 2D placement of variable-composition *stacks* on the truck floor, with per-stack height and weight caps. Second, the per-period decision of which product fills each slot is retained, but the crush-limit cap is evaluated slot-by-slot using the period's actual product mix. This yields a tighter per-stack weight bound than a worst-case-per-RTI-type abstraction, while eliminating vertical-stability constraints altogether, since stacks are self-supporting by construction.

Notational conventions. Throughout this section, $g \in G = \{s, p\}$ indexes nodes (supplier and plant), $n \in N$ products, $r \in R$ RTI types, $h \in H$ stack types, $i, j \in I$ stack-slot positions within a loading configuration, $l \in L$ loading configurations, $k \in K$ trucks and $t \in T$ planning periods. Variables whose direction is determined by definition omit the g subscript: V_{klnt} and $V^{\cdot}wslot_{kilnt}$ denote full-RTI loads on plant-bound trucks, and V^{e}_{klrt} denotes folded-RTI loads on supplier-bound trucks. Table 3 collects the complete nomenclature.

Table 3: Nomenclature of 3D-SCPTOP (stack-based reformulation)

Indices and sets	
G	Supplier and plant nodes, $G = \{s, p\}$.
N	Products, $n = 1, \ldots, N$.
R	RTI types, $r = 1, \ldots, R$.
H	Stack types, $h = 1, \ldots, H$.
I	Stack-slot indices within a loading configuration, $i = 1, \ldots, \lvert I \rvert$ (see eq. 4.1).
L	Loading configurations, $l = 1, \ldots, L$.
K	Trucks, $k = 1, \ldots, K$.
T	Planning periods, $t = 1, \ldots, T$.
$M(r)$	Products carried by RTI type r, $M(r) \subseteq N$.
$R(h)$	RTI types compatible with stack type h, $R(h) \subseteq R$.
Parameters	
cK	Cost of using a truck.
lt	Lead transport time between plant and supplier (and vice versa).
i_{gn}	Initial inventory of $n \in N$ at $g \in G$ (full RTIs).
ie_{gr}	Initial inventory of folded RTIs $r \in R$ at $g \in G$.
ic_{gn}	Inventory cost of $n \in N$ at $g \in G$.
d_{gnt}	Production plan for $n \in N$ at $g \in G$ in $t \in T$.
q_{nt}	Initial arrivals of full RTIs of product n at p in $t \in \{1, \ldots, lt\}$.
q_{rt}	Initial arrivals of folded RTIs of type r at s in $t \in \{1, \ldots, lt\}$.
ss_{gnt}	Security stock of n at g in t (full RTIs).
ss_{gtr}	Security stock of folded RTIs r at g in t.
w_n	Weight of a full RTI carrying product n.
w^{f}_r	Weight of a folded RTI of type r.
pK^w	Maximum truck weight capacity.
$W^{\max}$	Per-stack crush-limit weight cap.
pK, qK, rK	Truck length, width, and height.
Γ_K	Truck volume, $\Gamma_K = pK \cdot qK \cdot rK$.
α	Minimum truck utilisation, required on whichever of volume or payload binds ($0 < \alpha \leq 1$).
p_h, q_h	Footprint length and width of stack type h.
r_{gr}	Height of one RTI of type r at node g (full at p, folded at s).
γ_{gr}	Volume of one RTI of type r at node g.
n_{hr}	RTIs of type $r \in R(h)$ per layer of stack type h.
M	A sufficiently large constant.
Decision variables – LC level	
Z_{gl}	$\in \{0, 1\}$. Equals 1 iff LC l is active in direction g.
θ_{gl}	$\in \{0, 1\}$. Selects which resource the utilisation floor is applied to: volume if 1, payload if 0.

X_{gihl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff slot i of LC l is of stack type h in direction g.
L_{gihlr}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Number of layers of RTI type $r \in R(h)$ in slot i of LC l in direction g.
LX_{gihl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff stack h's length is along the x-axis in slot i.
LY_{gihl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff stack h's length is along the y-axis in slot i.
PX_{gil}, PY_{gil}	≥ 0. Bottom-left coordinates of slot i in LC l in direction g.
A_{gijl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff slot i is to the left of slot j in LC l.
B_{gijl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff slot i is to the right of slot j in LC l.
C_{gijl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff slot i is behind slot j in LC l.
D_{gijl}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff slot i is in front of slot j in LC l.
Decision variables – runtime level	
Y_{gkt}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff truck k is used in direction g in period t.
Y_{gklt}	$\in \{0,1\}$. Equals 1 iff truck k uses LC l in direction g in period t.
V_{klnt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Full RTIs of product n on plant-bound truck k using LC l in period t.
V^{slot}_{kilnt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Full RTIs of product n in slot i of plant-bound truck k using LC l in period t.
V^{e}_{klrt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Folded RTIs of type r on supplier-bound truck k using LC l in period t.
I_{gnt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. End-of-period inventory of n at g in t (full RTIs).
Ie_{gtr}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. End-of-period inventory of folded RTIs r at g in t.
Q_{nt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Full RTIs of product n in transit to the plant in t.
Q_{rt}	$\in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. Folded RTIs of type r in transit to the supplier in t.

Objective

$$\text{Min } z = \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{k\in K}\sum_{t\in T} cK \cdot Y_{gkt} + \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{n\in N}\sum_{t\in T} ic_{gn} \cdot I_{gnt} \tag{1}$$

Inventory and flow balance

The inventory balance block is structurally identical to the original formulation. For completeness it is reproduced below.

$$I_{pnt} = I_{p,n,t-lt} - d_{pnt} + Q_{n,t-lt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t \geq lt+1 \tag{2}$$

$$I_{pnt} = I_{p,n,t-1} - d_{pnt} + q_{nt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t \in \{2,\ldots,lt\} \tag{3}$$

$$I_{pnt} = i_{pn} - d_{pnt} + q_{nt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t = 1 \tag{4}$$

$$Ie_{ptr} = Ie_{p,t-1,r} + \sum_{n\in M(r)} d_{pnt} - Q_{rt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t \geq 2 \tag{5}$$

$$Ie_{ptr} = ie_{pr} + \sum_{n\in M(r)} d_{pnt} - Q_{rt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t = 1 \tag{6}$$

$$I_{snt} = I_{s,n,t-1} + d_{snt} - Q_{nt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t \geq 2 \tag{7}$$

$$I_{snt} = i_{sn} + d_{snt} - Q_{nt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t = 1 \tag{8}$$

$$Ie_{str} = Ie_{s,t-lt,r} + Q_{r,t-lt} - \sum_{n\in M(r)} d_{snt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t \geq lt+1 \tag{9}$$

$$Ie_{str} = Ie_{s,t-1,r} + q_{rt} - \sum_{n\in M(r)} d_{snt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t \in \{2,\ldots,lt\} \tag{10}$$

$$Ie_{str} = ie_{sr} + q_{rt} - \sum_{n\in M(r)} d_{snt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t = 1 \tag{11}$$

$$I_{gnt} \geq ss_{gnt}, \qquad Ie_{gtr} \geq ss_{gtr} \qquad \forall g \in G,\ n \in N,\ r \in R,\ t \in T \tag{12}$$

Stack packing constraints

Exactly one stack type can be assigned to a slot, and only if its LC is active:

$$\sum_{h\in H} X_{gihl} \ \leq\ Z_{gl} \qquad \forall g \in G,\ i \in I,\ l \in L. \tag{13}$$

The stack occupying slot i is oriented either with its length along the x-axis or along the y-axis:

$$LX_{gihl} + LY_{gihl} \;=\; X_{gihl} \qquad \forall g \in G,\; h \in H,\; i \in I,\; l \in L. \tag{14}$$

The total stack height cannot exceed the truck height. The following constraint also forces $L_{gihlr} = 0$ whenever $X_{gihl} = 0$, since $r_{gr} > 0$:

$$\sum_{r \in R(h)} r_{gr}\, L_{gihlr} \;\le\; rK \cdot X_{gihl} \qquad \forall g \in G,\; h \in H,\; i \in I,\; l \in L. \tag{15}$$

Slots must not overlap. For each pair $i \neq j$ in LC l:

$$PX_{gil} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(p_h LX_{gihl} + q_h LY_{gihl}\big) \le PX_{gjl} + M(1 - A_{gijl}) \tag{16}$$

$$PX_{gjl} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(p_h LX_{gjhl} + q_h LY_{gjhl}\big) \le PX_{gil} + M(1 - B_{gijl}) \tag{17}$$

$$PY_{gil} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(q_h LX_{gihl} + p_h LY_{gihl}\big) \le PY_{gjl} + M(1 - C_{gijl}) \tag{18}$$

$$PY_{gjl} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(q_h LX_{gjhl} + p_h LY_{gjhl}\big) \le PY_{gil} + M(1 - D_{gijl}) \tag{19}$$

with the cover constraint ensuring that whenever both slots are used at least one relative-position variable is active:

$$A_{gijl} + B_{gijl} + C_{gijl} + D_{gijl} \;\ge\; \sum_h X_{gihl} + \sum_h X_{gjhl} - 1 \qquad \forall g,\, l,\, i \neq j. \tag{20}$$

Containment in the truck floor:

$$PX_{gil} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(p_h LX_{gihl} + q_h LY_{gihl}\big) \le pK + M\big(1 - \textstyle\sum_h X_{gihl}\big) \qquad \forall g, i, l, \tag{21}$$

$$PY_{gil} + \sum_{h \in H} \big(q_h LX_{gihl} + p_h LY_{gihl}\big) \le qK + M\big(1 - \textstyle\sum_h X_{gihl}\big) \qquad \forall g, i, l. \tag{22}$$

Minimum truck utilisation. Full-truckload transport requires a dispatched truck to be full, but a truck can be full in two different ways: it may run out of space or it may run out of payload. Imposing the requirement on volume alone is not a conservative simplification, it is an infeasible one — filling a fraction α of a 97.9 m^3 trailer with RTIs at 590 $\mathrm{kg/m}^3$ weighs 27.4 t against a 24 t cap, so no truck is dispatchable at all and the instance is empty. Summing the two ratios instead is the opposite error: it accepts a truck that is 35% full by volume and 20% by weight, which is full by neither. We therefore require a truck to reach a fraction α of *either* resource, using a binary θ_{gl} to select which one binds:

$$\sum_{i \in I} \sum_{h \in H} \sum_{r \in R(h)} \gamma_{gr}\, n_{hr}\, L_{gihlr} \;\ge\; \alpha\, \Gamma_K \big(Z_{gl} - 1 + \theta_{gl}\big) \tag{23}$$

$$\sum_{i \in I} \sum_{h \in H} \sum_{r \in R(h)} \omega_{gr}\, n_{hr}\, L_{gihlr} \;\ge\; \alpha\, pK^w \big(Z_{gl} - \theta_{gl}\big) \qquad \forall g \in G,\; l \in L, \tag{24}$$

with $\omega_{gr} = w^{\mathrm{f}}_r$ in the supplier direction and $\omega_{pr} = \min_{n \in M(r)} w_n$ in the plant direction, the lightest product being the one that makes the requirement hardest to meet. The same disjunction is imposed on each dispatched truck at runtime, on the loads V_{klnt} and V^{e}_{klrt} rather than on the configuration's designed capacity, since a truck may be loaded to less than the configuration allows.

Truck–LC linking and runtime loading

A truck uses at most one LC in a period, and can only use an active LC:

$$\sum_{l \in L} Y_{gklt} = Y_{gkt} \qquad \forall g, k, t \tag{25}$$

$$Y_{gklt} \le Z_{gl} \qquad \forall g, k, l, t \tag{26}$$

For plant-bound trucks, full RTIs of type r loaded in slot i cannot exceed the layer capacity of the stack placed in that slot; products sharing the same RTI type partition that slot-capacity:

$$\sum_{n \in M(r)} V^{\mathrm{slot}}_{kilnt} \;\le\; \sum_{h\,:\,r \in R(h)} n_{hr}\, L_{p,i,h,l,r} + M(1 - Y_{pklt}) \qquad \forall k, i, l, r, t. \tag{27}$$

Truck-level aggregation of per-slot loads:

$$V_{klnt} = \sum_{i \in I} V^{\text{slot}}_{kilnt} \qquad \forall k, l, n, t. \tag{28}$$

For supplier-bound trucks, folded RTIs of type r are capped by the aggregate layer capacity of the LC in use (no slot-level tracking is needed because folded-RTI weight is deterministic in r):

$$V^{\text{e}}_{klrt} \;\le\; \sum_{i \in I} \sum_{h \,:\, r \in R(h)} n_{hr}\, L_{s,i,h,l,r} + M(1 - Y_{sklt}) \qquad \forall k, l, r, t. \tag{29}$$

Weight constraints

Per-truck weight, plant-bound:

$$\sum_{l \in L} \sum_{n \in N} w_n\, V_{klnt} \;\le\; pK^{w}\, Y_{pkt} \qquad \forall k, t. \tag{30}$$

Per-truck weight, supplier-bound:

$$\sum_{l \in L} \sum_{r \in R} w^{\text{f}}_r\, V^{\text{e}}_{klrt} \;\le\; pK^{w}\, Y_{skt} \qquad \forall k, t. \tag{31}$$

Per-stack crush-limit, period-exact on plant-bound trucks (the cap reflects the actual product mix loaded in each slot):

$$\sum_{n \in N} w_n\, V^{\text{slot}}_{kilnt} \;\le\; W^{\max} \qquad \forall k, i, l, t. \tag{32}$$

Per-stack crush-limit on supplier-bound trucks (deterministic in the LC since folded-RTI weight depends only on r):

$$\sum_{h \in H} \sum_{r \in R(h)} w^{\text{f}}_r\, n_{hr}\, L_{s,i,h,l,r} \;\le\; W^{\max} \qquad \forall i, l. \tag{33}$$

Flow aggregation

$$Q_{nt} = \sum_{k \in K} \sum_{l \in L} V_{klnt} \qquad \forall n, t \tag{34}$$

$$Q_{rt} = \sum_{k \in K} \sum_{l \in L} V^{\text{e}}_{klrt} \qquad \forall r, t \tag{35}$$

4.1 Symmetry breaking and slot-set sizing

The slots $i \in I$ of a given LC are interchangeable, so any solution admits $|I|!$ permutations of the slot index. We break this symmetry by enforcing that slot $i+1$ is used only if slot i is used:

$$\sum_{h \in H} X_{g,i+1,h,l} \;\le\; \sum_{h \in H} X_{g,i,h,l} \qquad \forall g \in G,\; l \in L,\; i \in \{1, \ldots, |I| - 1\}. \tag{36}$$

The cardinality of I is a modelling parameter. An upper bound that eliminates provably unused slot variables without cutting any feasible layout is

$$|I| \;\le\; \left\lfloor \frac{pK \cdot qK}{\min_{h \in H} p_h \cdot q_h} \right\rfloor, \tag{37}$$

corresponding to tiling the truck floor with the smallest-footprint stack type; it serves as a tight preprocessing limit on $|I|$.

The trucks of a given direction and period are interchangeable in the same way: nothing in the data distinguishes one element of K from another. We likewise force them to be used in index order,

$$Y_{g,k+1,t} \;\le\; Y_{gkt} \qquad \forall g \in G,\; t \in T,\; k \in \{1, \ldots, |K| - 1\}. \tag{38}$$

The row is valid because any solution can be re-indexed, but it removes only the choice of *which* subset of trucks is used. The loads remain interchangeable among the used trucks, so a plan dispatching n trucks in a period still appears $n!$ times in the search, which is the difficulty Section 5 removes by aggregation rather than by a row.

Domains

$$Z_{gl},\ \theta_{gl},\ X_{gihl},\ LX_{gihl},\ LY_{gihl},\ A_{gijl},\ B_{gijl},\ C_{gijl},\ D_{gijl},\ Y_{gkt},\ Y_{gklt} \in \{0,1\},$$
$$L_{gihlr},\ V_{klnt},\ V^{\text{slot}}_{kilnt},\ V^{\text{e}}_{klrt},\ I_{gnt},\ Ie_{gtr},\ Q_{nt},\ Q_{rt} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0},$$
$$PX_{gil},\ PY_{gil} \geq 0.$$

5 Dantzig–Wolfe reformulation and branch and price

Three structural difficulties stand between the 3D-SCPTOP model of Section 4 and an industrial instance. The first is that the number of loading configurations needed is not known a priori, so $|L|$ must be overestimated; every configuration that turns out to be unnecessary still carries its full block of placement variables, and every *under*-estimate silently restricts the problem. The second is that the model replicates a complete two-dimensional packing problem $|G| \cdot |L|$ times, and each replica contributes $4\binom{|I|}{2}$ big-M disjunctions (16)–(19) whose linear relaxation is weak. The third is that the model indexes its variables by truck, and trucks are interchangeable: any two used trucks of the same direction and period can swap their entire loads, so every solution appears in the search a factorial number of times.

The third difficulty is the one that scales worst, because it does not depend on the loading geometry at all. It is present in the volumetric benchmark of Appendix A exactly as in 3D-SCPTOP, and Section 6 reports what it costs there. Operational procurement planning lives at horizons of weeks over dozens of trucks, so that is the regime the method has to serve, and it is the regime in which a decomposition earns its place.

The reformulation developed below removes all three at once, and it removes the first by removing the loading configuration from the master *entirely*. The master couples to the geometry through nothing but the definition of two aggregate flows and one count of trucks per direction and period; every slot, orientation, non-overlap, stack-height, crush and full-truckload constraint lives inside a pricing problem. There is no L, no Z_{gl} and no Y_{gklt} in what follows.

5.1 The decomposition

The reformulation is derived structurally rather than by analogy, and the derivation is given first because every property claimed later — that the master is equivalent to 3D-SCPTOP, that λ may be taken integer, that a branching row leaves the pricing problem intact — is a consequence of one of its steps.

Blocks. Take the block index to be $\mathcal{B} = G \times K \times T$. Inspect Section 4: every geometric constraint (13)–(23) carries a single direction and a single configuration, every loading and weight constraint (27)–(33) carries a single direction, a single truck and a single period, and no such row couples two values of g, of k or of t. The remaining rows — the inventory balances (2)–(12) and the flow aggregations (34)–(35) — see the blocks *only* through the aggregate flows Q_{nt} and Q_{rt}. The model is therefore block-angular with one independent block per (direction, truck, period), and a block whose rows never couple two values of an index is the product of its parts over that index.

Identical blocks. Nothing in the data distinguishes one element of K from another: K is anonymous. The blocks of a fixed (g,t) are therefore identical, and identical blocks are aggregated. In place of one copy of the block per truck, the reformulation carries one non-negative integer variable per block *solution*, counting how many of the class's blocks take it, and one row per class bounding that count by $|K|$. This is where the third difficulty disappears: the trucks are never distinguished in the first place, so there is no permutation of them to search.

Classes. The classes are the pairs $(g,t) \in G \times T$. Within a class the block rows are pinned to the class's values of g, so there is one pricing problem per *direction*. The pricing rows read no datum indexed by t: the trailer, the catalogue, the crush limit and the utilisation floor are all time-invariant. The pricing problems of the periods of one direction therefore differ *only in their duals*, and one column set serves every period of that direction. This is what makes a column priced at one period usable at another, and it is the reason the whole horizon costs two pricing problems rather than $2|T|$.

The dropped row. The truck-symmetry row (38) of the compact model orders the trucks of a direction and period so that truck $k+1$ is used only if truck k is. It is a statement about *which* identical block carries which load, and after aggregation there is no such statement to make: counts of identical blocks carry no order. The row is dropped, and the drop is sound precisely because the blocks it orders were established to be identical in the step above.

Discretisation. Every block variable that reaches the master is integer. For the plant-bound block these are the per-slot product loads V_{in}, whose sum over slots is the block's image; for the supplier-bound block they are the folded counts V^{e}_r. A block solution may therefore be taken to be an *integer* point of its pricing problem, completed by a minimum-cost choice of the block's continuous variables — the placement coordinates PX_i, PY_i, which cost nothing. Discretisation then applies: the multipliers λ are integer, not merely non-negative, and a fractional λ in the relaxation is a genuine integrality violation rather than an artefact of the reformulation.

The empty column. The point with every block variable at zero is feasible for both pricing problems, has a zero image and costs nothing. It is the slack of the count rows, which may therefore be written as inequalities and need no explicit slack variable.

5.2 Columns

A column of a direction is the image of a feasible point of that direction's pricing problem, together with the point itself as a witness. Write Ω^p for the set of plant-bound columns and Ω^s for the supplier-bound set, and index a column by ω rather than by p, which already denotes the plant direction and, as p_h, the length of a footprint.

A *plant-bound* column $\omega \in \Omega^p$ is a vector $b_\omega = (b_{\omega n})_{n\in N}$ of full RTIs — the value of the aggregate $\overline{V}_n$ at the point — for which there exist a slot count $m \le |I|$, stack types $h_1, \dots, h_m \in H$, orientations, bottom-left coordinates (x_i, y_i), layer counts ℓ_{ir} and per-slot product loads v_{in} such that

$$\text{the } m \text{ footprints, rotated as chosen, do not overlap and lie inside } pK \times qK, \tag{39}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_{r\in R(h_i)} r_{pr}\ell_{ir} \;\le\; rK \qquad \forall i \le m, \tag{40}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_{n\in M(r)} v_{in} \;=\; n_{h_i r}\ell_{ir} \qquad \forall i \le m,\ r \in R(h_i), \tag{41}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_{n\in N} w_n v_{in} \;\le\; W^{\max} \qquad \forall i \le m, \tag{42}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_{n\in N} w_n b_{\omega n} \;\le\; pK^w, \qquad \max\Big\{ \frac{\sum_n \gamma_{p\rho(n)} b_{\omega n}}{\Gamma_K},\ \frac{\sum_n w_n b_{\omega n}}{pK^w} \Big\} \;\ge\; \alpha, \tag{43}$$

$$b_{\omega n} = \textstyle\sum_{i\le m} v_{in} \qquad \forall n \in N. \tag{44}$$

A *supplier-bound* column is the analogous object $e_\omega = (e_{\omega r})_{r\in R}$ over folded heights r_{sr}, folded weights w^{f}_r and folded volumes γ_{sr}; there no product assignment is needed, because the weight of a folded RTI depends only on its type. Every non-empty column costs $c_\omega = cK$, the value of $cK \cdot Y$ at the point; the empty column costs nothing.

Three features of this definition carry the method.

First, the column carries the *per-slot* assignment v_{in}, so the crush limit (42) is evaluated on the product mix actually riding in that slot. A column therefore reproduces the period-exact cap (32) of the compact model, and not the conservative surrogate $\bar{w}_r = \max_{n\in M(r)} w_n$ that a pool of capacity-only configurations is forced to use.

Second, (43) is the same disjunction as (23)–(24), written on the load a truck actually carries rather than on the capacity its configuration provides. A truck is full when it is full on the *binding* resource — α of volume *or* α of payload, never the sum of the two ratios, which is strictly weaker and would accept a trailer 35% full by volume and 20% by weight. Both regimes occur: coarse containers fill the trailer by volume, dense ones by weight.

Third, a column is a feasibility certificate. The placement $(h_i, x_i, y_i, \text{rotation}, \ell_{ir}, v_{in})$ witnessing $\omega \in \Omega^p$ is retained with the column, so any plan the master assembles can be handed to a loading crew as a drawing and re-verified independently of the solver that produced it. Section 6 does exactly that, truck by truck, on every reported plan.

5.3 The master problem

Let $\lambda^g_{\omega t} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$ be the number of trucks of class (g,t) dispatched carrying column ω, and let $\overline{V}_{nt}$ and $\overline{V^{\mathrm{e}}}_{rt}$ be the aggregate flows the inventory block reads. These aggregates are the compact model's Q_{nt} and Q_{rt} under a name that says where they come from: (46)–(47) below are the flow-aggregation rows (34)–(35) with each truck's load replaced by the image of the column it carries. The master problem (MP) is

$$\min \; cK \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{t\in T}\sum_{\omega\in\Omega^g} \lambda^g_{\omega t} \;+\; \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{n\in N}\sum_{t\in T} ic_{gn} I_{gnt} \tag{45}$$

subject to

$$\overline{V}_{nt} = \sum_{\omega\in\Omega^p} b_{\omega n}\, \lambda^p_{\omega t} \qquad \forall n\in N,\ t\in T \tag{46}$$

$$\overline{V^{\mathrm{e}}}_{rt} = \sum_{\omega\in\Omega^s} e_{\omega r}\, \lambda^s_{\omega t} \qquad \forall r\in R,\ t\in T \tag{47}$$

$$\sum_{\omega\in\Omega^g} \lambda^g_{\omega t} \leq |K| \qquad \forall g\in G,\ t\in T \tag{48}$$

$$(2)\text{–}(12) \qquad \text{verbatim}$$

$$\lambda^g_{\omega t} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}, \quad I_{gnt} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}, \quad Ie_{gtr} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}, \quad \overline{V}_{nt},\, \overline{V^{\mathrm{e}}}_{rt} \text{ free.}$$

That is the whole master. Objective (45) minimises transport plus inventory holding cost. Constraints (46)–(47) *define* the two aggregates as what the dispatched trucks carry; (48) caps the fleet available per direction and period, with the empty column as its slack; and the inventory balances and coverage-stock rows of Section 4 are carried over word for word, for both nodes and both kinds of stock, full and folded (Section 5.11).

Two things are worth saying about what is *not* there. There is no loading-configuration index, and so none of the model's geometric blocks: the master does not know what a slot is. And there is no variable indexed by an individual truck, so the symmetry that (38) was introduced to suppress has no representation to be suppressed in. The entire coupling between the transport–inventory problem and the loading problem is three families of rows: two definitions and one count.

Proposition 1 (equivalence)**.** *If $|L|$ is not restricted a priori, MP and 3D-SCPTOP have the same optimal value.*

Proof. Given a 3D-SCPTOP solution, each used truck (g,k,t) induces a load vector satisfying (39)–(44), obtained by reading the slot data off the configuration it uses and setting $v_{in} = V^{\mathrm{slot}}_{kilnt}$; counting trucks by load vector gives a feasible MP solution, of equal cost because transport cost depends only on the number of used trucks and the inventory rows see only the aggregates, which (46)–(47) reproduce. Conversely, introducing one configuration per distinct column used by an MP solution and assigning trucks to columns arbitrarily — the blocks being identical, any assignment serves — reconstructs a 3D-SCPTOP solution of the same cost, feasible because each column carries a witnessing placement. □

The proposition is what distinguishes this approach from a pool-based method such as the company procedure PLC-SCPTOP of Section 7. A predefined pool is a *restriction* of the problem and can only yield upper bounds of unknown quality, whereas MP is the same problem written differently, so any bound derived from it is a bound on the original. It also locates the one place where the compact model's $|L|$ still matters: Section 6 compares against a compact 3D-SCPTOP run at $|L| = 3$, which is a restriction, and its dual bound accordingly bounds that restriction and not $z^\star$.

5.4 The restricted master problem and the reduced cost

$|\Omega^g|$ is astronomical, so MP is solved over a subset. The restricted master problem (RMP) is MP over $\bar{\Omega}^g \subseteq \Omega^g$ with integrality relaxed to $\lambda^g_{\omega t} \geq 0$; solving it yields duals, the pricing problems use those duals to look for columns of negative reduced cost outside $\bar{\Omega}^g$, the found columns are added, and the RMP is re-solved. If no such column exists the relaxation of MP has been solved over the whole of Ω^g.

Let π_{nt} and π_{rt} be the duals of the definition rows (46)–(47) and $\mu_{gt} \leq 0$ the dual of the count row (48). The reduced cost of a plant-bound column ω dispatched in period t is

$$\bar{c}(\omega,t) \;=\; c_\omega - \sum_{n\in N} \pi_{nt}\, b_{\omega n} - \mu_{pt}, \tag{49}$$

and analogously with $e_{\omega r}$ and π_{rt} in the supplier direction. The pricing problem of class (g,t) minimises $c(x) - \sum \pi \cdot \text{image}(x)$ over the feasible points of the direction's block, so its optimal value $z^\star_{gt}$ gives $\min_\omega \bar{c}(\omega,t) = z^\star_{gt} - \mu_{gt}$, and a column enters when this is negative. In a Phase-I pass $c \equiv 0$ and the same problem minimises the image alone.

The sign convention is worth stating, because it is where a reimplementation goes wrong silently. With the definition row written as $\overline{V}_{nt} - \sum_\omega b_{\omega n} \lambda^p_{\omega t} = 0$ and a solver reporting reduced costs as $c - A^\top \Pi$ (gurobipy's `Pi`), the price that enters the pricing objective is $\pi = -\Pi$ for a definition row and $\mu = +\Pi$ for a count row. The prices π are irrational in general and must be rounded before entering an integer-coefficient subproblem; they are rounded *upwards*, never to nearest, so that the rounded objective dominates the true one and the value the subproblem returns remains an over-estimate of the true maximum, as the certificate of Section 5.5 requires. Rounding to nearest makes it a slight under-estimate, silently invalidates the certificate, and with reduced costs at exactly zero returns a value just above the threshold so that convergence is never declared.

Three further properties of the RMP matter for what follows.

First, it carries *artificial* variables on the definition rows (46)–(47) and on the coverage-stock rows, penalised at a large cost in the objective, so that it is feasible for any pool and always yields duals. A solution with positive artificials is not a plan.

Second, it carries cumulative cover cuts: by period t the plant must have received cumulative demand plus coverage stock, and dividing that requirement by the most a single truck can carry bounds from below the number of trucks dispatched up to $t - lt$. These rows tighten the relaxation considerably. Their duals, like those of every row the search later adds, are folded into μ_{gt} so that (49) remains the exact reduced cost. This is possible because a branching or cutting row $\sum_\omega f(\omega)\lambda_\omega \lessgtr \beta$ is *robust* — it leaves the pricing problem structurally unchanged — exactly when f is constant within a class or affine in the column's image. Every row this paper adds to the master is of one of those two kinds, which is why no branching decision ever has to be communicated to a pricing problem.

Figure 2 places the pieces in the loop they run in.

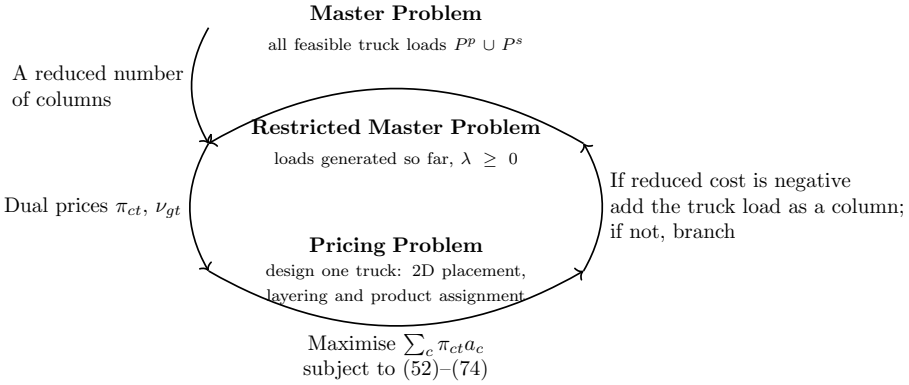


Figure 2: Branch and price scheme for 3D-SCPTOP. Every geometric, height, crush-limit, payload and full-truckload constraint is enforced inside the pricing problem, so each column is a physically loadable truck.

Third, the RMP is *period-scoped*: a column priced against the duals of period t receives a dispatch variable at t alone, and only the shared initial pool is offered to every period. This changes the size of the restricted master, not the master — by the Classes step of Section 5.1 the pricing problem is the same for every period of a direction, and it is still solved per (g,t) over the whole of Ω^g — so a sweep that finds nothing at any pair still proves that the restricted LP equals the master LP.

5.5 Lower bounds

Care is needed here, because the natural candidate is not a bound at all. The RMP is a *restriction* of MP: it optimises over $\bar{\Omega}^g \subseteq \Omega^g$, so its LP value satisfies $z_{\text{RMP}} \geq z_{\text{MP}}$. Until column generation has converged the RMP value is an *upper* bound on the master LP, and reporting it as a lower bound is simply wrong. Four rules decide what may be reported; Figure 3 states them as a decision.

A certificate needs a full sweep. When the pricing problem has *proven* that $\zeta_{gt} := \max_{\omega \in \Omega^g} \sum_c \pi_{ct}\, a_{\omega c} \le cK - \mu_{gt}$ for every g and every t, no column outside $\bar{\Omega}^g$ has negative reduced cost, so the current duals are feasible for the dual of the full MP. Weak duality then gives $z_{\mathrm{RMP}} = z_{\mathrm{MP}} \le z^\star_{\text{3D-SCPTOP}}$. The proof is only as good as the exhaustiveness of the sweep behind it. Two economies that are legitimate while columns are still coming — pricing only the pairs whose aggregates are fractional, and skipping a pair whose duals round to something already priced — forfeit the right to certify, because a pair nobody looked at proves nothing. Certification therefore runs one sweep over *every* (g, t), with no memoisation and no restriction to the pairs a branch has touched, and every call must come back *proved*: an oracle stopped on its time limit reports itself unproven, and a sweep with one such pair proves nothing about the whole. Every branching fix must also be released before the sweep, since a restricted LP sits above the region's own LP and certifying with fixes in place publishes a bound that is too high by construction.

The bound is the raw LP value. The RMP objective includes the penalty on the artificial variables. The cost of a plan is the value *net* of that penalty, and that is the right number to report as a cost; the bound is the *raw* value with the penalty included, because the penalty is part of the LP whose dual the certificate rests on. Positive artificials at convergence mean the region cannot be made feasible by any column of Ω^g, so the region is infeasible in the true problem and is pruned rather than bounded.

A bound without convergence: the Lagrangian bound. A sweep that finds columns still yields a bound, as long as it was complete. With $\bar{z}$ the raw RMP LP value and $\bar{c}^\star_{gt}$ the *proved* minimum reduced cost of class (g, t),

$$\bar{z} + \sum_{g \in G} \sum_{t \in T} |K| \cdot \min\bigl(0,\ \bar{c}^\star_{gt}\bigr) \ \le\ z_{\mathrm{MP}}, \tag{50}$$

the multiplier being the class's own count row (48). The expression is formed only when every pair has an entry; a partial sweep yields nothing, and a pair served by a heuristic rung (Section 5.6) returns no proved minimum and so contributes none. The bound is valid at any iteration and is kept as a running maximum. It is weak when $|K|$ is large relative to the reduced costs — on *I_8_5_2_90*, whose optimum is 18 796.96, it gives 18 778.31, because ten pairs at $|K| = 12$ accumulate 120 units of penalty against a target of 1.42 — so it is reported as a bound and not relied on as the method's bound.

The restricted value is never a bound. At every node the search first solves the LP over the current pool. That value sits *above* the region's true LP value and is used only as a filter: if even the over-estimate lies below the incumbent, the region cannot be pruned and the expensive sweep is not run. It is never entered as a bound, and a search stopped by its deadline reports the last *certified* value it holds, not the last LP it solved. Reduced costs oscillate here — -0.01 at one iteration and -104.54 two iterations later has been measured — so a sweep that finds nothing is not convergence unless every pair was proved.

A bound by inclusion. The certificate above is expensive when the oracle is the geometric pricing problem of Section 5.6; the following observation makes a cheaper one available.

Proposition 2 (bound by inclusion)**.** *Let $\Omega^g_{\mathrm{vol}} \supseteq \Omega^g$ be the set of loads that fit the trailer's volume and the payload and clear the full-truckload floor on the binding resource, and let z_{vol} be the LP value of the master (45)–(48) over Ω^g_{vol}, certified as above. Then $z_{\mathrm{vol}} \le z^\star_{\text{3D-SCPTOP}}$, and the same holds inside any region defined by bounds on the fleet vector.*

Proof. A valid placement satisfying (39)–(44) has total RTI volume at most Γ_K and total weight at most pK^w, and (43) is the same floor in both sets, so $\Omega^g \subseteq \Omega^g_{\mathrm{vol}}$. The rows of the master — the two definitions, the count, the inventory and coverage rows, and any bound on a dispatch total — do not depend on the load model; only the column set does. The 3D master is therefore the volumetric master with columns removed, its LP value is at least z_{vol}, and its optimum is at least its LP value. □

The practical consequence is the part that matters. A geometric pricing sweep costs $2|T|$ calls at the pricing limit and, on the instances of Section 6, certified no region on any run; the volumetric relaxation — a two-constraint knapsack oracle over the same master — returns a sweep in 2.5 to 112 s on every instance in the study and proves it on all but one of the forty-one runs. The method therefore takes its bound from the volumetric relaxation and asks geometric pricing only for columns. The division of labour is principled rather than expedient: the plan comes from the pool, the construction and the tree, the bound comes from a relaxation whose bound is valid for the problem actually being solved, and the gap between them is a genuine optimality gap for the 3D problem.

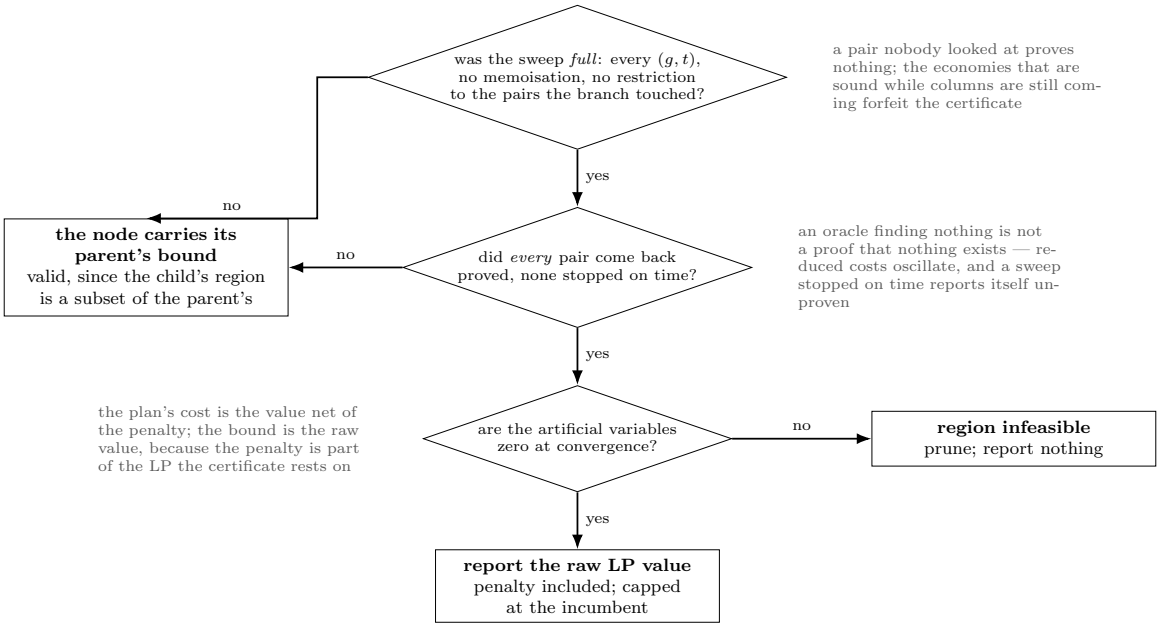


Figure 3: What may be reported as a lower bound. The restricted-master LP value is an *upper* bound on the master LP until pricing has converged, so it is used only as a pruning filter; a node obtains a bound of its own only from a full sweep in which every pair is proved, and otherwise inherits its parent's. A quantity above a solution one can exhibit is not a loose bound but a false statement, and it inflates every optimality gap computed from it, so the reported value is additionally capped at the incumbent.

5.6 The pricing problems

By the Blocks and Classes steps of Section 5.1 the pricing problem of class (g, t) *is* the block of 3D-SCPTOP with the quantifier over $\mathcal{B}$ removed: the same rows, with the direction g supplying the data and the master supplying the duals. Nothing has to be invented for it, and nothing of the geometry is left behind in the master. There is one such problem per direction, written (PP^g); the periods of a direction share it and differ only in π and μ.

Let $\mathcal{I}$ index the slots, bounded by (37), and drop the block index from the compact model's variables. Table 4 lists them. The two directions share the whole of the geometry, which is therefore written once with g as a parameter; they differ only in the rows of Section 5.6.

Table 4: Nomenclature of the pricing problem (PP^g). The variables are those of a single block of Section 4 with the block index dropped; g and the duals π, μ are data.

Decision variables	
Z	Binary. The block's loading configuration is designed
Y	Binary. A truck is dispatched under it; $c(x) = cK \cdot Y$
X_{ih}	Binary. Slot i holds a stack of type h; $\widehat{X}_i := \sum_h X_{ih}$ is slot i used
LX_{ih}, LY_{ih}	Binary. The stack in slot i is oriented with p_h along x, respectively along y
PX_i, PY_i	Bottom-left coordinates of slot i on the trailer floor
L_{ihr}	Integer. Layers of RTI type r in slot i under stack type h; $\overline{L}_{hr} := \sum_i L_{ihr}$
$A_{ij}, B_{ij}, C_{ij}, D_{ij}$	Binary. Which of the four separating half-planes resolves the overlap of slots i and j
θ	Binary. The full-truckload requirement is met on volume ($\theta = 1$) rather than on payload ($\theta = 0$)
V_{in}	Integer, $g =$ p only. RTIs of product n in slot i; $\overline{V}_n := \sum_i V_{in}$ is the column's image
V^{e}_r	Integer, $g =$ s only. Folded RTIs of type r in the truck; the column's image

The shared block: geometry

$$\min\ cK\cdot Y\ -\ \sum_{c}\pi_{ct}\,\mathrm{image}_{c} \qquad \bar{c}=z-\mu_{gt} \tag{51}$$

$$\widehat{X}_i \le Z \qquad \forall i\in\mathcal{I} \tag{52}$$

$$LX_{ih}+LY_{ih}=X_{ih} \qquad \forall h\in H,\ i\in\mathcal{I} \tag{53}$$

$$\sum_{r\in R(h)} r_{gr}\,L_{ihr}\le rK\cdot X_{ih} \qquad \forall h\in H,\ i\in\mathcal{I} \tag{54}$$

$$PX_i+\sum_h(p_hLX_{ih}+q_hLY_{ih})\le PX_j+M^x(1-A_{ij}) \qquad \forall i<j \tag{55}$$

$$PX_j+\sum_h(p_hLX_{jh}+q_hLY_{jh})\le PX_i+M^x(1-B_{ij}) \qquad \forall i<j \tag{56}$$

$$PY_i+\sum_h(q_hLX_{ih}+p_hLY_{ih})\le PY_j+M^y(1-C_{ij}) \qquad \forall i<j \tag{57}$$

$$PY_j+\sum_h(q_hLX_{jh}+p_hLY_{jh})\le PY_i+M^y(1-D_{ij}) \qquad \forall i<j \tag{58}$$

$$A_{ij}+B_{ij}+C_{ij}+D_{ij}\ge \widehat{X}_i+\widehat{X}_j-1 \qquad \forall i<j \tag{59}$$

$$PX_i+\sum_h(p_hLX_{ih}+q_hLY_{ih})\le pK \qquad \forall i\in\mathcal{I} \tag{60}$$

$$PY_i+\sum_h(q_hLX_{ih}+p_hLY_{ih})\le qK \qquad \forall i\in\mathcal{I} \tag{61}$$

$$Y\le Z \tag{62}$$

$$\widehat{X}_{i+1}\le\widehat{X}_i \qquad \forall i\le|\mathcal{I}|-1 \tag{63}$$

The shared block: the full-truckload disjunction

A truck is full on the binding resource. Written on the load the truck actually carries, with Γ_K the trailer volume and α the utilisation floor,

$$\sum_{c}\gamma_{g\rho(c)}\,\mathrm{image}_{c}\ \ge\ \alpha\,\Gamma_K\,(Z-1+\theta) \tag{64}$$

$$\sum_{c}w_c\,\mathrm{image}_{c}\ \ge\ \alpha\,pK^{w}\,(Z-\theta). \tag{65}$$

At $Z=1$ exactly one of the two is active and the other is vacuous, so (64)–(65) is the disjunction (43) and not the sum of the two ratios, which is strictly weaker and would accept a trailer 35% full by volume and 20% by weight. Two redundant rows written on the stack *capacity* rather than on the load,

$$\sum_{h,\,r\in R(h)}\gamma_{gr}\,n_{hr}\,\overline{L}_{hr}\ \ge\ \alpha\,\Gamma_K\,(Z-1+\theta),\qquad \sum_i\sum_h p_hq_hX_{ih}\ \ge\ \alpha\,pK\cdot qK\,(Z-1+\theta), \tag{66}$$

are implied by (64) — the load never exceeds the capacity, and a slot contributes at most its footprint area times rK of volume — and are added because they are what lets a solver find a *first* feasible layout quickly, which on tight instances is harder than optimising once one is known. A bound written on capacity alone would *not* do: it admits a point whose stacks could have been full but whose actual load falls below the floor, and such a point is not a column.

The direction-specific rows

Plant-bound, $g = \mathrm{p}$, with $\text{image}_n = \overline{V}_n$ and $\bar{u}^V_n$ any valid upper bound on a truck's count of product n:

$$\sum_{n \in M(r)} V_{in} \;\le\; \sum_{h\,:\,r \in R(h)} n_{hr}\, L_{ihr} \qquad \forall i \in \mathcal{I},\, r \in R \tag{67}$$

$$V_{in} \;\le\; \bar{u}^V_n\, Y \qquad \forall i \in \mathcal{I},\, n \in N \tag{68}$$

$$\sum_{n \in N} w_n\, \overline{V}_n \;\le\; pK^w\, Y \tag{69}$$

$$\sum_{n \in N} w_n\, V_{in} \;\le\; W^{\max} \qquad \forall i \in \mathcal{I} \tag{70}$$

Supplier-bound, $g = \mathrm{s}$, with $\text{image}_r = V^{\mathrm{e}}_r$:

$$V^{\mathrm{e}}_r \;\le\; \sum_{h\,:\,r \in R(h)} n_{hr}\, \overline{L}_{hr} \qquad \forall r \in R \tag{71}$$

$$V^{\mathrm{e}}_r \;\le\; \bar{u}^{\mathrm{e}}_r\, Y \qquad \forall r \in R \tag{72}$$

$$\sum_{r \in R} w^{\mathrm{f}}_r\, V^{\mathrm{e}}_r \;\le\; pK^w\, Y \tag{73}$$

$$\sum_{h} \sum_{r \in R(h)} w^{\mathrm{f}}_r\, n_{hr}\, L_{ihr} \;\le\; W^{\max} \qquad \forall i \in \mathcal{I} \tag{74}$$

The asymmetry is the one the compact model already has. A plant-bound truck needs the per-slot assignment V_{in} because the crush limit depends on which products ride in the slot (70); a supplier-bound truck does not, because the weight of a folded RTI depends only on its type, so (74) is a statement about the stack and not about its contents.

How it is solved. The formulation above is a mixed integer programme, and the hard core of it is the disjunctive non-overlap relation (55)–(59): four big-M rows per pair of slots, whose linear relaxation is weak for the same reason it is weak in the compact model. The implementation therefore hands the subproblem to a constraint programming solver, which propagates non-overlap natively through a single global constraint over the rectangles $[PX_i, PX_i + \delta^x_i) \times [PY_i, PY_i + \delta^y_i)$, whose side lengths $\delta^x_i = \sum_h (p_h LX_{ih} + q_h LY_{ih})$ and $\delta^y_i = \sum_h (q_h LX_{ih} + p_h LY_{ih})$ are the expressions already appearing in (55)–(61), and needs no disjunctive binaries at all. The two statements are the same problem, and Section 6 reports no comparison between the two technologies: the one on record was made under an oracle that did not implement the composition bounds the method depends on, which makes it a comparison between two different subproblems rather than between two solvers. What matters for the method is only that the oracle solve *this* problem; an earlier variant that imposed the full-truckload requirement as the sum of the two ratios in (43) rather than as their disjunction solved a strictly weaker one and returned a column that failed verification.

The volumetric oracle. The same master — the same two definition rows, the same count row, the same inventory balances and coverage stock — is also solved over the loads of the volumetric benchmark of Appendix A, where a load is a column iff its volume fits the trailer's, its weight the payload, and it clears the full-truckload floor on the binding resource. Pricing is then a two-constraint integer knapsack that closes in milliseconds. Running both oracles through one master and one search is what makes the comparison of Section 6 an experiment about the loading representation rather than about two solution technologies, and it is the setting in which per-node certification is affordable.

What a certificate costs. Figure 4 shows the oracle and what it can and cannot return. A certified node is a full sweep, $2|T|$ calls each closed to proven optimality. On the volumetric oracle that is affordable at every node. On the geometric problem it is not — a single call on the instances of Section 6 takes tens of seconds to minutes, and a sweep is then the whole budget of a node — so with the geometric oracle the certificate is taken from the volumetric relaxation (Proposition 2) and geometric pricing is asked only for columns.

A pricing ladder. Any column of negative reduced cost improves the restricted master; the *most* negative one is needed only for the certificate. Column generation over the geometric problem therefore runs as a ladder. The first rung is a heuristic run *under the current duals* at every iteration — a randomised greedy

construction over enumerated stack fills, placed by a shelf packer, together with a re-fill of the slot geometry of columns already in the pool — whose output is pricing output, never seeding. A heuristic load *qualifies* only if its reduced cost lies below a margin of half a percent of the pair's threshold, so that a marginal heuristic column cannot pre-empt a much better exact one; the best two qualifying loads per pair are kept, and a pair at which nothing qualifies goes to the exact oracle. The oracle itself is run in a stop-early mode that returns its first incumbent beating the threshold by the same margin. The certifying sweep never uses either rung, and neither does the Lagrangian bound (50): a certificate is one uncapped exact sweep, exactly as in Section 5.5, so the ladder changes which columns arrive and how fast, and nothing about what may be claimed.

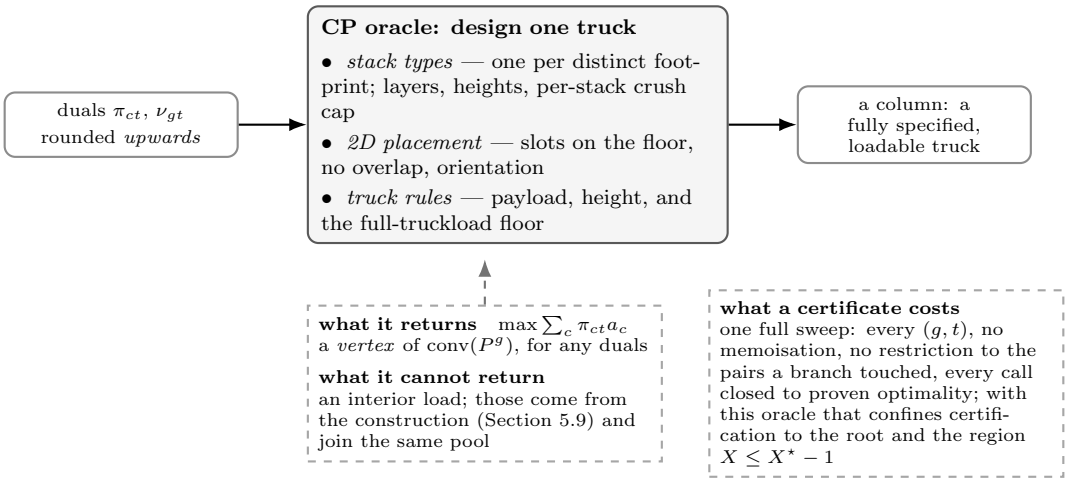


Figure 4: The pricing subproblem. Geometry, height, crush limits, payload and the full-truckload rule are enforced *inside* the oracle, so any column it returns is a physically loadable truck. It maximises the dual-weighted load and therefore returns a vertex of conv(P^g) whatever the duals are; loads in the interior of that hull (Figure 5) are supplied by the construction of Section 5.9, not by pricing. A certificate needs every call of a sweep closed to proven optimality, which on this oracle is the whole budget of a node, and is therefore spent only where a bound changes what the tree can conclude.

5.7 Initial columns

The search starts from the plainest possible pool: one maximally full truck per commodity and direction, obtained in the geometric case by running the pricing problem for that commodity alone to proof — so the pool truck is the placeable maximum of the commodity, and the same number serves as its placeability cap in Section 5.10 — and in the volumetric case by filling to capacity. No demand mixes, no diversification and no reduced variants are seeded, so whatever the search then reaches, it reached by pricing, branching and construction. This is a requirement of the method rather than a convenience: a pool assembled by hand contaminates every claim about what the search finds, and an earlier seeded pool was removed on that ground. The single-commodity pool guarantees that no direction is ever left without columns, and because these columns are shared they are offered to every period.

What such a pool, and any pool grown from it by pricing alone, *cannot* contain is shown in Figure 5 on a real pool. For any dual vector the pricing objective (51) is linear in the image, so it attains its optimum at an extreme point of conv(Ω^g) and pricing returns extreme loads only. A balanced load lying inside the hull is dominated componentwise by a fractional blend of single-commodity trucks; the relaxation buys that blend for the price of one truck, while an integer plan must pay for each truck it mixes. No choice of duals returns the interior load, however the search moves them. Interior loads are precisely what an integer plan needs when a period's demand does not decompose into full trucks, and the method therefore has a second generator for them.

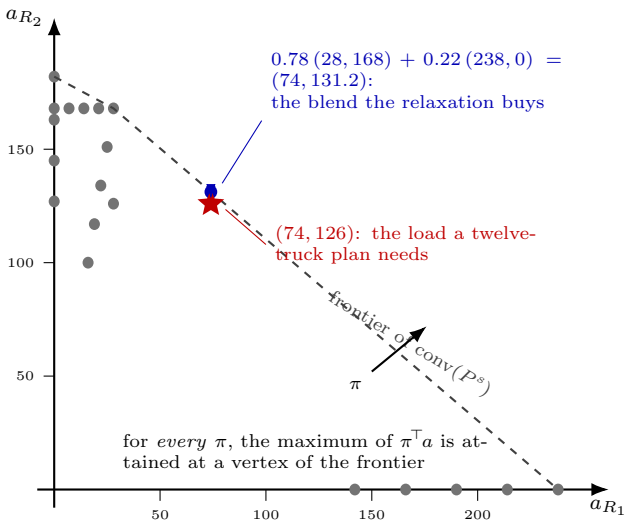


Figure 5: Why the load a cheaper plan needs is never priced. Dots are the supplier-bound loads obtained from a sweep of demand-derived price vectors; the dashed line is the upper-right frontier of their convex hull. The pricing objective is linear, so for *any* dual vector π its optimum is attained at a vertex of that frontier. The load $(74, 126)$ lies strictly below it — it is dominated componentwise by the blend $0.78\,(28, 168) + 0.22\,(238, 0) = (74, 131.2)$ — so no choice of duals returns it. The relaxation buys that blend for one truck, while an integer plan must pay for both of the trucks it mixes. The construction of Section 5.9 reaches the interior directly: it partitions a delivery vector into exact loads instead of asking a linear objective for them.

5.8 Relax and fix

The second generator, and the procedure that produced every plan reported in Section 6, is a relax-and-fix heuristic on the restricted master. Two such procedures appear in this work and they are not variants of one another; they relax and fix different things, they are run in different places, and each is stated in full below so that neither is mistaken for the other.

- The **flow-first** relax and fix of Section 5.8.1 fixes the *aggregates* — the delivery vectors and the dispatch totals — while leaving the column variables continuous, and then realises the fixed aggregates as trucks. It runs at every node of the fleet tree of Section 5.9 and is the primal heuristic of MATH-3D-SCPTOP.
- The **horizon-walk** relax and fix of Section 5.8.2 fixes the *column variables of one period at a time*, with a sliding window of integer periods and a continuous tail. It was used in the earlier period-scope experiments on the volumetric master and is reported as such; no 3D result in this paper comes from it.

5.8.1 Flow-first relax and fix

The procedure decides first how much moves and how many trucks carry it, and builds the trucks afterwards. It is run inside a region $\mathcal{R}$ of the fleet tree — a set of bounds on the dispatch totals $n_{gt} := \sum_\omega \lambda^g_{\omega t}$ — and must stay inside it, or the children the node induces would partition around a point the node excludes. It runs on a *fresh copy* of the restricted master, because step 2 changes variable types and doing that to the node's own LP would leave it a mixed integer programme with no duals for whatever runs next.

1. *Restricted master.* The LP over the pool, inside $\mathcal{R}$, gives the duals and the fractional point the node stands on.
2. *Aggregate integer master.* Introduce the dispatch totals n_{gt} as explicit integer variables, make the aggregates $\overline{V}_{nt}$ and $\overline{V^e}_{rt}$ integer, and leave the column variables $\lambda^g_{\omega t}$ *continuous*; impose $\mathcal{R}$ on the n_{gt} as well as on the columns. Under 3D loading add the stack-count rows of Section 5.10. Solve to a relative gap ε_2, with the solver set to find feasible solutions early.

   This is where the objective is actually decided, and it is decided *without a single call to a pricing problem*: the row set is the master's own, and what it chooses is the flows and the fleet. Three

outcomes are distinguished. No solution within the limit abandons the node. Artificial slack above a tolerance means the region is infeasible over this pool, so its delivery vectors are meaningless and the node is abandoned — partitioning them would waste the node and could return a "plan" that does not meet demand. Slack below the tolerance means the integer solve ran out of time short of a clean solution; the partitions built from it are still legal loads, and step 4 decides. Write $Q^\star$ for the integer delivery vectors and $n^\star$ for the integer fleet it returns.

3. *Partition, as a cover.* For each direction and period, realise $Q^\star_{gt}$ as $n^\star_{gt}$ legal trucks by a small integer programme over per-truck commodity counts a_{kc}, $k \le n^\star_{gt}$:

$$\min \quad \sum_c \gamma_{gc}\Big(\sum_k a_{kc} - Q^\star_{gtc}\Big) \tag{75}$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad \sum_k a_{kc} \;\ge\; Q^\star_{gtc} \qquad \forall c \tag{76}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_c \gamma_{gc} a_{kc} \le \Gamma_K, \qquad \sum_c w_c a_{kc} \le pK^w \qquad \forall k \tag{77}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_c \gamma_{gc} a_{kc} \ge \alpha\Gamma_K z_k, \qquad \sum_c w_c a_{kc} \ge \alpha pK^w(1 - z_k) \qquad \forall k \tag{78}$$

$$\textstyle\sum_c w_c a_{kc} \;\ge\; \sum_c w_c a_{k+1,c} \qquad \forall k < n^\star_{gt} \tag{79}$$

$$a_{kc} \in \{0, \dots, \bar{u}_{gc}\}, \qquad z_k \in \{0, 1\}.$$

Constraint (76) is a *cover*, not an exact split: the parts must sum to *at least* the delivery vector in every commodity, and (75) minimises the excess. (77)–(78) make each part a legal truck, with z_k selecting the resource on which part k meets the floor; (79) orders the parts by weight to break the symmetry among them, and $\bar{u}_{gc}$ is the placeability cap of Section 5.10. If $n^\star_{gt}$ parts cannot be formed, $n^\star_{gt} + 1$ and then $n^\star_{gt} + 2$ are tried, provided $\mathcal{R}$ allows it. A timeout is not a proof: only a model that comes back infeasible says the cover is impossible.

4. *Integer master over pool plus parts.* The parts are added to the pool as columns and the integer master is solved over the enlarged pool, warm-started with the partition itself. Its solution is the node's plan and its value the candidate incumbent.

Why the partition must be a cover. This is the step at which the procedure could quietly become wrong, and the reason is worth stating exactly. In the compact model and in the integer master the packing is a decision variable, so $\overline{V}_{nt} = \sum_\omega b_{\omega n}\lambda^p_{\omega t}$ with integer λ is a sum of placeable loads by construction and an unrealisable delivery vector can never be requested. Step 2 breaks that link: it fixes the aggregates over *continuous* λ, so $Q^\star$ is a fractional blend of legal loads — and a fractional blend of legal loads need not be realisable as legal loads at all, for *any* number of trucks.

The mechanism is that floor area is consumed in whole footprints while the utilisation floor is measured in volume. A partial stack occupies the same footprint as a full one, so splitting a delivery vector into more trucks consumes more floor without adding volume, while splitting it into fewer violates the trailer. On $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ the vector $\{R_1 : 200, R_2 : 30\}$ holds 1.83 full-truckload floors of volume — so one truck cannot carry it and two cannot both be full — and needs $35.5\,\mathrm{m}^2$ of stacks on a $32.64\,\mathrm{m}^2$ floor, so it is realisable by no number of full trucks whatever. Under a cover the same vector is two trucks of $\{R_1{:}100,\ R_2{:}15\}$ plus a few units. An exact split would therefore fail on vectors the model has every right to choose, and failing is not a neutral outcome: it costs the node its plan.

The cover is sound for the same reason the step exists. Every part is still a legal, full truck and hence a legal column, and the parts enter step 4 *as columns with a warm start*, not as fixed dispatches, so the integer master is free to dispatch fewer of them than were built. A plan that over-delivers is feasible in the master: the inventory rows are balances with no upper bound on the plant's stock, so the surplus is priced as holding cost, and the supplier's own stock balance stops a column that would ship more than the supplier has from being dispatched at all. The excess in (75) is measured in volume rather than in units, because volume is the resource the floor and the trailer are measured in, so a surplus folded empty and a surplus full pallet are weighed by what they displace rather than counted alike.

What step 2 must know, and what it need not. Step 2 sees the master's rows and the pool, not the geometry, so it can choose aggregates that no partition can realise. The aggregate stack-count rows of Section 5.10 are what keep that in check, and the failure they fix is concrete: on $I_8_5_2_90$ over the pure pool, step 2 under a *linear* stack-area row chose the right flow — the twelve-truck optimum — and then asked the partition for $\{R_1{:}85,\ R_2{:}117\}$ in one supplier truck, which is $13 + 17 = 30$ stacks of seven layers, $32.88\,\mathrm{m}^2$ on a $32.64\,\mathrm{m}^2$ floor. The linear row admits it ($11.66 + 20.06 = 31.7\,\mathrm{m}^2$); the partition refused it;

the pair went to two trucks and the plan to thirteen at 19 682.36 instead of twelve at 18 796.96. With integer stack counts per footprint step 2 sees the difference. The rows remain a relaxation of the per-truck split — an aggregate that fits n floors need not divide into n — which is why the $n + 1$ fallback of step 3 stays in the procedure by design.

5.8.2 Horizon-walk relax and fix

The second procedure attacks a different obstruction: the integer master over the whole horizon. At twenty periods that monolith is what fails. In the eight recorded runs reported below, over final pools of between 551 and 3 435 columns, the closing integer master over the whole horizon produced no incumbent on *any* run, while the walk produced one on six of the eight.

So commit period by period. Let w be a window width. At step i of the walk the dispatch variables $\lambda^g_{\omega t}$ are *integer* for t in the window $\{t_i, \dots, t_{i+w-1}\}$ and *continuous* for every other period, which leaves the tail free to absorb whatever the committed prefix leaves. The window's own mixed integer programme has $|\bar{\Omega}| \times w$ integer variables instead of $|\bar{\Omega}| \times |T|$. Solve it, fix the variables of its *first* period at the counts it chose, slide the window forward by one, and repeat. The walk runs on a copy of the master, for the same reason step 2 above does.

Inventory is what couples the periods, and it is forgiving in one direction: shipping earlier only carries stock, so a committed prefix rarely strands the tail. That is why the walk is cheap where the monolith is intractable. When a window does come back with positive artificials, the committed prefix cannot be completed out of the columns that window may use — under period scoping, the loads priced at the window's own periods — and two recoveries are available. A *repair* asks the pricing problem for a load covering the shortfall the artificials name and retries the same window; a *backtrack* releases the last commitment, widens the window by one and lets the two periods be decided together rather than one after the other. If neither applies the walk abandons, and records which period and which shortfall, since a walk that returns nothing silently is indistinguishable from one that was never run.

This is the procedure the period-scope experiments used, on the volumetric master. In the eight recorded runs on *I_24_20_2_90_k*50 at a 600 s budget, *every* incumbent was produced by the walk and none by the closing integer master over the final pool; the best was 206 492.17 with 137 trucks against a certified bound of 200 013.36, a gap of 3.14%. Without the repair, the two runs under period scoping returned no plan at all. These are volumetric results at a budget of their own and the two procedures have never been run against each other under a common budget, so no comparison between them is offered here; the walk is described because it is a distinct procedure with its own recorded results, and because the aggregate-first alternative above is a response to the same obstruction.

5.9 The fleet tree

Branching on the master's own variables is the obvious rule and the wrong one here. Bounding one $\lambda^g_{\omega t}$ removes one load from the relaxation, but a Dantzig–Wolfe master of this kind holds many columns that differ only in detail, so the relaxation answers by shifting the same fractional weight onto a near-identical column. Run to exhaustion on a benchmark instance with the pool frozen, that rule branched thousands of times without ever producing an integral relaxation. Branching on a per-period dispatch total has no symmetric twin, but it has an escape of its own: the relaxation answers a bound on one period by moving a truckload into a neighbouring period, at the price of one period's holding cost, so the bound barely moves.

We therefore branch on the *fleet*. With n_{gt} the dispatch total of direction g in period t, let $\mathbf{n} = (n_{gt})_{g,t}$ be the fleet vector and $X := \sum_{g,t} n_{gt}$ the total fleet. Both are integer in every plan, and every bound placed on them is a row of the master of the robust kind identified in Section 5.4 — f constant within a class — so the pricing problems are untouched. Given an incumbent plan with fleet vector $\mathbf{n}^\star$ and total $X^\star$, the tree has two levels that ask different questions; Figure 6 draws them.

Level 1: the total fleet. Transport cost is exactly $cK \cdot X$, so a bound on the total has nothing to compensate it. Three regions partition the space:

- $X \geq X^\star + 1$ costs a whole truck with no offset. A plan in it improves on the incumbent only if the extra truck saves more than cK minus the incumbent's gap in inventory, and the region's relaxation says at once whether that is possible; it is usually pruned by bound.
- $X = X^\star$ fixes transport. Everything inside is inventory allocation, and this is where the second level goes.

- $X \leq X^\star - 1$ is the only region that can beat the incumbent outright — "is there a plan with fewer trucks?" — and is therefore worth a certificate of its own. It is also the region the tree constructs in *first*: with the equality region on top of the stack its Murty subtree can take the whole budget while a smaller fleet is never asked for, which is what happened on a pure pool before the order was changed (Table 9).

A plan found *inside* an inequality region, with total X_2, splits that region on its total exactly as the root was split — $[\cdot, X_2 - 1]$, $\{X_2\}$ and $[X_2 + 1, \cdot]$ cover it — and the equality piece starts a Murty chain of its own; level 1 is recursive. A construction that fails inside a region says only that the *pool* cannot support that fleet, since step 2 is exact over the pool; the region is therefore priced under its own duals with a small share of the budget and constructed once more before it is given up, and a bound proved by that pricing prunes it.

Level 2: the fleet vector, inside $X = X^\star$. Fix an order on the pairs (g, t) — periods first, then direction. The fleet vector of any plan in the region differs from $\mathbf{n}^\star$ at a first index j, or nowhere. Branching at the first pair where a solution may differ gives three children, $n_j \leq n_j^\star - 1$, $n_j \geq n_j^\star + 1$ and $n_j = n_j^\star$, and the equality child is partitioned again at index $j + 1$ (Murty's scheme). The regions are disjoint and exhaustive, and the equality child is expanded first so that the neighbourhood of the incumbent is searched before its complement. The partition is taken around the plan *constructed at that node*, not around the global incumbent, so a node that improves the incumbent is immediately re-partitioned around the better plan and nothing has to be restarted. The chain is cut at a depth that rises by two whenever the stack empties with budget left.

Processing a node. A node is a region imposed on the RMP as fleet rows. The LP over the current pool is solved first; being an over-estimate of the region's LP it is a filter and never a bound (Section 5.5). If the filter allows pruning and the certification policy admits the node, column generation is run to a certificate; a certified value at or above the incumbent prunes the node, an infeasible region is discarded, and a certified value below the incumbent is recorded as that region's bound. In every other case the node carries its parent's bound, which remains valid for the child because the child's region is a subset of the parent's. The flow-first relax and fix of Section 5.8.1 is then run inside the region, and if it returns a plan cheaper than the incumbent the incumbent is replaced. Finally, if the region fixes X, the Murty children are generated around the constructed plan.

Two generators, one pool. Pricing returns extreme points of $\text{conv}(\Omega^g)$; the relax and fix returns covers of a delivery vector, which are interior points that no dual vector reaches (Figure 5). A column is a feasible load, and a node's constraints bound the multipliers λ, not the load, so a column found anywhere is valid everywhere: every column from either generator goes into the one shared pool, and a node that is pruned still leaves its columns behind. That is the mechanism by which the tree improves on the root. It is not that the tree reaches an integral relaxation — it essentially never does — but that each region it visits asks the construction for a plan under constraints the root never saw, and the loads that plan needs are added for every later node to use.

What the tree reports. The incumbent is the cheapest verified plan found by any construction. The root bound is the certificate obtained before any branching — under 3D loading, that of the volumetric relaxation (Proposition 2). The global bound of a branch and bound is the minimum over its *frontier*, not its root: a region nobody expanded contributes nothing, which is why a dive reports its root value however far it has gone. At the end of the budget the regions still open are therefore swept — filtered by their pool LP and certified where the filter allows — and the global bound is the minimum over the certified bounds of the open regions, floored at the root bound and capped at the incumbent. Under 3D loading a region's certificate is taken, like the root's, from the volumetric relaxation with the region's fleet rows applied, which Proposition 2 covers: the rows bound the fleet vector, not the load model, so the volumetric master over the region bounds the 3D master over it. Optimality is claimed *only* when the root is certified, no region remains open, no restart has broken the partition, and the incumbent meets the global bound. No run reported in Section 6 meets these conditions, so the method certifies no optimum anywhere in this paper; the one optimum the paper does report is established by inclusion from an exactly solved relaxation and not by the method (Section 6.4).

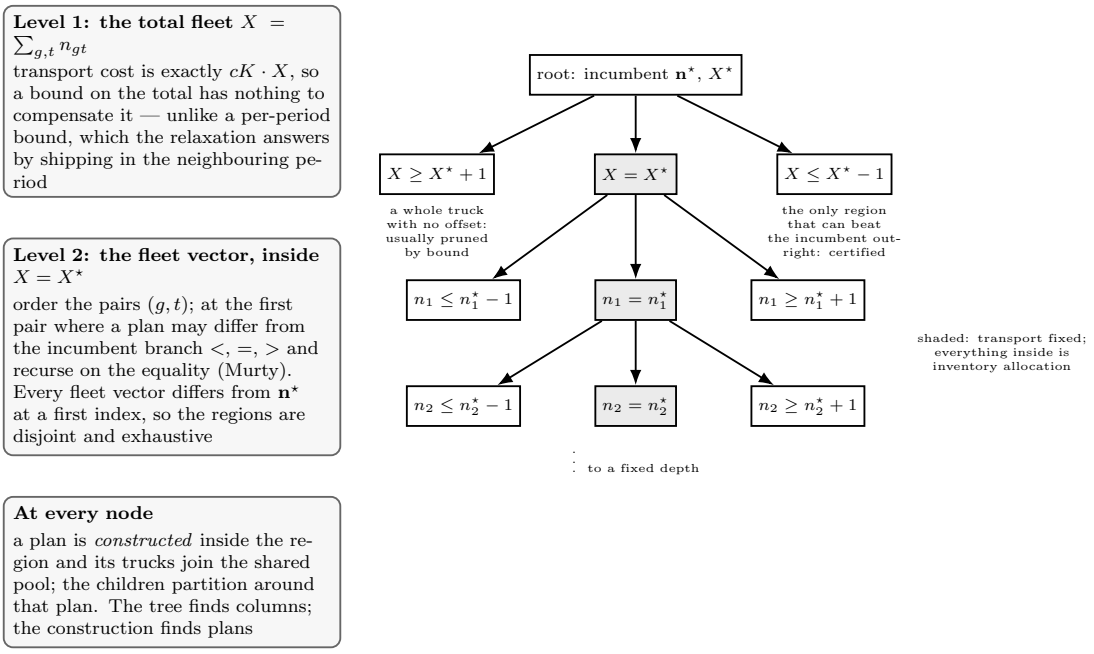


Figure 6: The two levels of the fleet tree. Level 1 partitions on the total fleet X, whose cost $cK \cdot X$ the relaxation cannot offset; level 2 partitions the region $X = X^\star$ on the fleet vector itself, one pair at a time around the plan constructed at each node. Bounds on X and on n_{gt} are rows of the master that already carry duals, so the pricing subproblem is untouched, and a column found in any region is valid in every other.

5.10 The construction under 3D loading

Step 3 of Section 5.8.1 builds trucks from a delivery vector with a volumetric notion of a legal load: (77)–(78) are exactly the volumetric column conditions. Over the volumetric oracle that notion *is* the definition of a column, and every part the partition proposes is a column by construction. Under 3D loading a load must also satisfy (39)–(44). The volumetric conditions are nevertheless *necessary* for geometric feasibility (Proposition 2), so the partition programme is kept as a *relaxation* of the geometric partition and each part it proposes is then tested for placeability. Step 2 makes no oracle call and is unchanged, so the objective is still decided before any geometry is examined; what changes is only whether the trucks that objective implies can be built.

Deciding placeability. A part is submitted to a placeability oracle that returns one of three answers. A constructive *shelf design* — a small integer programme that lays the part's stacks in shelves along the trailer length, one integer count per shelf, footprint and orientation — supplies essentially every positive answer, and its layout is passed through the independent verifier of Section 6 before it counts; a witness the verifier rejects is not a witness. The pricing problem of Section 5.6, run in feasibility mode with the true slot bound (37), supplies the *infeasibility* proofs; the true bound is what makes an infeasible verdict a proof, since a model with fewer slots than a layout needs can report infeasible while the load is placeable. A part left undecided within the limit is neither accepted nor refuted. A placeable part becomes a column with its layout as witness, exactly as a priced column does.

Two kinds of cut, and they are different claims. A part *proved* unplaceable yields a *dominance cut* forbidding every load that dominates it componentwise. The cut is valid because placeability is downward closed: removing an RTI from a placeable layout leaves every position unchanged and every stack no taller and no heavier, so a load dominating an unplaceable one is itself unplaceable, and the cut removes the whole up-set of the refuted load rather than a single point. The full-truckload floor is not part of the placeability test, so it does not break the closure. A part left *undecided* is instead excluded as a single point, so that the partition proposes something else. That is a restriction of a primal heuristic and never a validity claim: it cannot make the method report an invalid plan, only fail to find one. The two constraints are kept separate

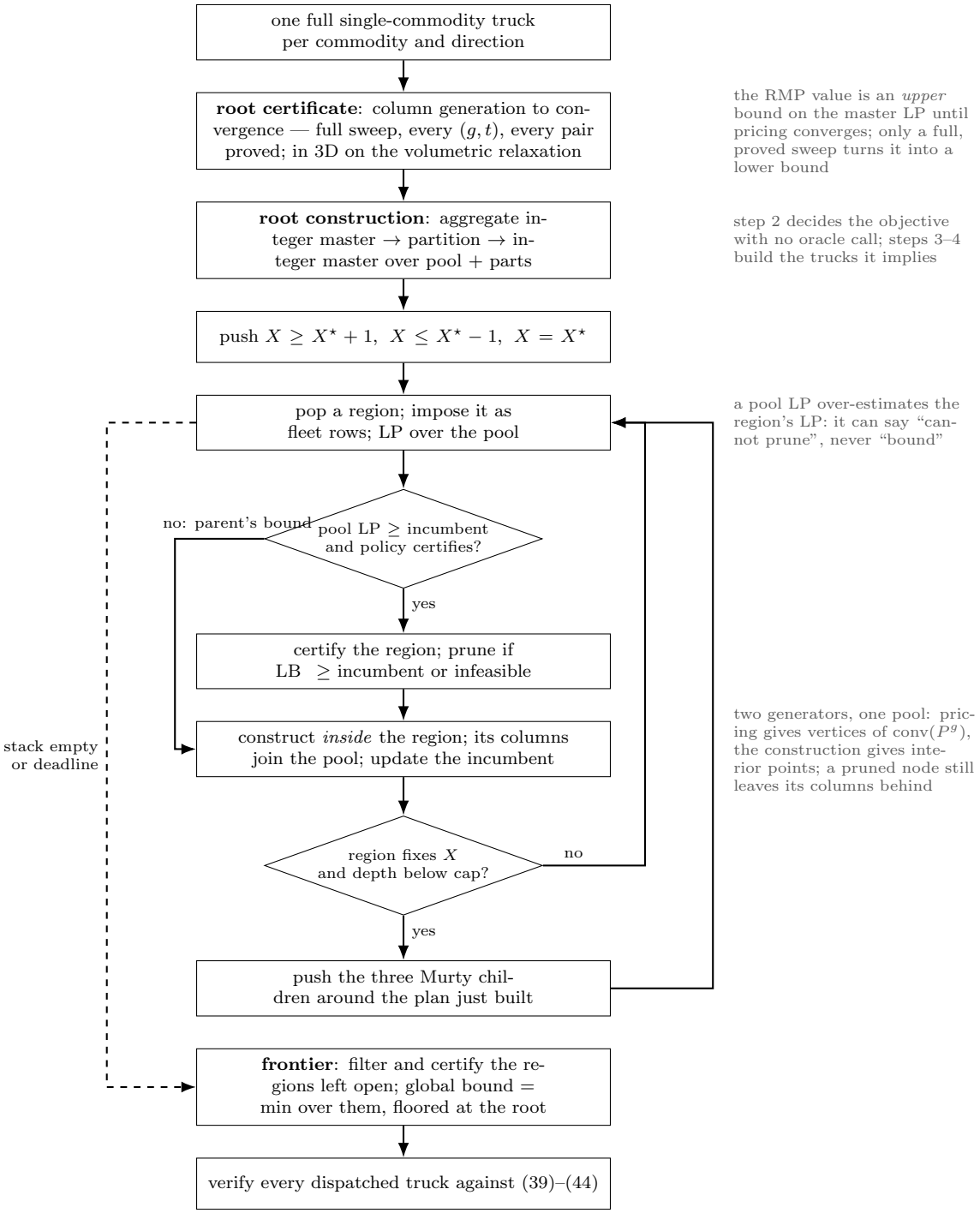


Figure 7: The fleet tree end to end. The search's value is not that it reaches an integral relaxation — it essentially never does — but that each region asks the construction for a plan under constraints the root never saw, and the loads that plan needs are added to a pool every later node can use. The bound is decided by certification alone: a region that was not swept in full, with every pair proved, carries its parent's bound, and the global bound is the minimum over the frontier rather than the root value.

because they rest on different grounds, and only the first may ever be read as knowledge about the instance.

Algorithm 1 The fleet tree for 3D-SCPTOP: branch and bound over the fleet vector with the flow-first construction as primal

$\bar{P} \leftarrow$ one full single-commodity truck per commodity and direction ▷ Section 5.7
$\mathrm{LB}_0 \leftarrow \textsc{Certify}(\bar{P},\ \text{root})$ ▷ full sweep, every (g,t), every pair proved; else no bound. In 3D: on the volumetric relaxation, Prop. 2
$(\bar{z}, \mathbf{n}^\star, \bar{P}) \leftarrow \textsc{Construct}(\bar{P},\ \text{root})$; $X^\star \leftarrow \sum_{g,t} n^\star_{gt}$ ▷ steps 1–4, Section 5.8.1
$\mathcal{S} \leftarrow \left[\, X \geq X^\star + 1,\ \ X = X^\star,\ \ X \leq X^\star - 1 \,\right]$ ▷ a stack; the region that can beat the incumbent is expanded first
while $\mathcal{S} \neq \emptyset$ and time remains **do**
    $\mathcal{R} \leftarrow$ pop $\mathcal{S}$; impose $\mathcal{R}$ on the RMP as fleet rows
    $\tilde{z} \leftarrow$ LP over $\bar{P}$ inside $\mathcal{R}$ ▷ over-estimates the region's LP: a filter, never a bound
    if LP infeasible **then**
        continue ▷ discarded
    end if
    if $\tilde{z} \geq \bar{z}$ and the policy certifies $\mathcal{R}$ **then**
        $(\mathrm{LB}_{\mathcal{R}}, \text{proved}) \leftarrow \textsc{Certify}(\bar{P}, \mathcal{R})$
        if region infeasible or $\mathrm{LB}_{\mathcal{R}} \geq \bar{z}$ **then**
            continue ▷ pruned
        end if
        record $\mathrm{LB}_{\mathcal{R}}$ as an open bound
    else
        $\mathcal{R}$ carries its parent's bound
    end if
    $(z, \mathbf{n}, \bar{P}) \leftarrow \textsc{Construct}(\bar{P},\ \mathcal{R})$ ▷ inside the region; its columns join the shared pool
    if no plan **then**
        price under the region's duals; Construct once more; **continue** if still none
    end if
    if $z < \bar{z}$ **then**
        $(\bar{z}, \mathbf{n}^\star) \leftarrow (z, \mathbf{n})$ ▷ new incumbent
    end if
    if $\mathcal{R}$ does not fix X **then**
        push $\mathcal{R} \cap \{X \geq X_2 + 1\}$, $\mathcal{R} \cap \{X = X_2\}$, $\mathcal{R} \cap \{X \leq X_2 - 1\}$ with $X_2 = \sum_{g,t} n_{gt}$ ▷ level 1 recurses
    end if
    if $\mathcal{R}$ fixes X and its depth j is below the cap **then**
        $(g,t) \leftarrow$ the j-th pair in the fixed order
        push $\mathcal{R} \cap \{n_{gt} \geq n_{gt} + 1\}$, $\mathcal{R} \cap \{n_{gt} \leq n_{gt} - 1\}$, $\mathcal{R} \cap \{n_{gt} = n_{gt}\}$ onto $\mathcal{S}$ ▷ Murty, around the plan just constructed
    end if
    release $\mathcal{R}$
end while
for all $\mathcal{R}$ still on $\mathcal{S}$, while a reserve of time remains **do**
    filter by the pool LP; certify the survivors; record their bounds ▷ the frontier
end for
$\mathrm{LB} \leftarrow \max\{\mathrm{LB}_0,\ \min \text{ over open and frontier bounds}\}$, capped at $\bar{z}$
verify every dispatched truck of the incumbent against (39)–(44)
return $(\bar{z}, \mathrm{LB})$; optimality is claimed only if LB_0 was proved, $\mathcal{S} = \emptyset$, no restart occurred and $\bar{z} = \mathrm{LB}$

Placeability caps. The maximum count of a single commodity in one truck is a scalar, and by the same closure it is monotone, so it is bisected once per direction and commodity at the start of a run — a proved pricing optimum tightens it, an undecided probe leaves the analytic cap in force — and handed to the partition as the bound $\bar{u}_{gc}$ before it solves. Without it a single-commodity dominance cut advances one unit

per round, from the volumetric fill down towards the placeable count, at a placeability call and a partition re-solve each. The caps also measure the volumetric relaxation's optimism directly: on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ the payload admits 57 full RTIs of product P_1 in one truck and 32 can be placed, because its 650 mm container stacks four high under the roof and two high under the crush limit.

A stack relaxation inside the partition. The partition additionally carries, per truck and footprint, an integer number of stacks, with the crush limit and the height budget imposed per stack and the stacks' floor areas summed against the trailer floor; summed over the n_{gt} trucks of a period the same rows sit inside the aggregate master of step 2, with one integer count per footprint and period. The rows are necessary — every truck of the period has its own integer stack counts satisfying the per-truck rows, and summing them over the period's trucks gives exactly the aggregate rows — and they are precisely what the volumetric relaxation omits: a family whose RTIs are short enough for four layers by height but heavy enough for only two by the crush limit is credited by volume with twice its placeable count. The layer coefficient must be the *binding* one, the smaller of the height-limited and crush-limited counts; written with the height count alone the row is not a necessary condition and cuts off feasible fleets. The relaxation says nothing about the two-dimensional arrangement of the stacks, which the placeability test and the dominance cuts cover.

The pool and the bound. The starting pool is the placeable single-commodity trucks of Section 5.7 and nothing else; every other column comes from the pricing ladder or from the relax and fix. On a catalogue where the crush limit binds, the restricted master over that pool is not even feasible — no combination of pure trucks covers demand within the fleet — and reaching feasibility is the heuristic rung's job (Table 10). The root bound is the certified value of the volumetric relaxation (Proposition 2); geometric pricing, given a share of the root budget, supplies columns and nothing else. Section 6 reports what it supplies.

5.11 Two corrections to the compact model

Implementing 3D-SCPTOP surfaced two points worth recording, both invisible at $lt = 1$.

Inventory recursion under a lead time. Constraints (2) and (9) as originally written carry inventory forward from period $t-lt$, whereas inventory accumulates one period at a time and only the *arrival* is delayed. They must read

$$I_{pnt} = I_{p,n,t-1} - d_{pnt} + Q_{n,t-lt} \qquad \forall n \in N,\ t \geq lt+1, \tag{80}$$

$$Ie_{str} = Ie_{s,t-1,r} + Q_{r,t-lt} - \textstyle\sum_{n \in M(r)} d_{snt} \qquad \forall r \in R,\ t \geq lt+1. \tag{81}$$

With $lt = 1$ the two versions coincide, which is why the defect survived; with $lt \geq 2$ the original silently discards $lt - 1$ periods of stock. Every model in this paper is run at $lt = 1$, so no reported number changes either way; the correction is recorded because the formulation is the contribution.

Coverage stock on folded RTIs. Constraint (12) requires $Ie_{gtr} \geq ss_{gtr}$ at *both* nodes, and every model in this paper enforces it that way: the master of Section 5.3, the volumetric benchmark of Appendix A, the company procedure PLC-SCPTOP and the compact model itself. An earlier implementation imposed the folded bound at the supplier only, on the argument that the plant has no operational use for a stock of empties and that the extra row could render an instance with a tight RTI fleet infeasible. The row is what the model states, so it was reinstated, and the concern did not materialise: on the largest instances of Section 6 the root LP value is identical with and without it, no coverage row carries artificial slack, and the row is tight in a minority of periods without moving the optimum. Enforcing it everywhere also removes an asymmetry: had the master enforced the plant side and the comparison models not, the comparison would have been unfair in the master's favour.

6 Computational Experiments

The experiments answer three questions, and the order matters because the first is what licenses the other two.

1. **Does the reformulation find good plans where the truth is known?** The volumetric problem of Appendix A is the same transport and inventory problem with a volumetric truck capacity, and the compact formulation of it is solvable on instances of the size this study reaches. It is therefore a genuine yardstick, and Section 6.4 sets the reformulation against it.

2. **Does the method keep working on the 3D problem, where no reference optimum is available?** The compact 3D model returns no incumbent beyond five periods, so it cannot serve as a yardstick; Section 6.5 reports what the method returns and what it can certify, and Section 6.6 states what remains to be measured against the procedure the company uses today.
3. **Does it matter?** Section 6.7 puts the loads a volumetric model prescribes to an independent placeability proof, which is the test of whether the 3D representation buys anything at all.

6.1 Protocol and declared budgets

All calculations use Python. The restricted master, the aggregate integer master and the partitions of Section 5.8.1, the volumetric benchmark and the compact models are solved with Gurobi 12; the pricing problems (51)–(74) and the placeability tests with CP-SAT from OR-Tools 9.12. Every run reported in Tables 6–11 is read from a recorded run file, named in a comment beside the row in the source of the table.

Every row carries its configuration, or says that it does not. Five parameters can change the answer a solver returns: the wall-clock *time limit*; the relative *MIP gap* at which an integer solve may stop; the *thread count*; the *memory cap* per model; and the random *seed*. Table 5 states them per stage. They are read from each run's own record and not from the script that launched it — with one exception, which is marked wherever it appears. The volumetric fleet-tree runs of Table 6 recorded no configuration, and theirs is *recovered* after the fact from their launcher scripts and the system journal; one of those five runs has no recoverable time limit at all. A recovered configuration is weaker evidence than a recorded one and is never silently mixed with it.

Memory is a budget, not an accident. Gurobi holds its branch-and-bound tree in memory and imposes no limit of its own, so a compact model whose dual bound has stalled simply grows its list of unexplored nodes until the machine intervenes. Every model is therefore given an explicit per-model soft memory limit, at which the solver stops and returns its incumbent and its dual bound with the status MEM_LIMIT, exactly as a time limit would. Two consequences follow. A solve that stopped on memory is a solve that stopped, and its dual bound is a valid lower bound on the model's optimum regardless of why it stopped. And reaching a *fixed* per-model cap sooner on a larger model is a statement about the cap and not about tractability: no inference is drawn here from *when* the cap was reached, and the cap is reported as a parameter of the experiment like the time limit.

Table 5: Declared budgets, per stage. The memory cap is Gurobi's per-model soft limit, at which a solve stops and keeps its incumbent and dual bound. Values marked ~ are recovered from a launcher script rather than recorded by the run (`results/hp/provenance.json`); the recovered memory cap is the implementation's 4 GB default, which applied because no launcher set the environment variable that overrides it and `systemd-run` does not inherit a terminal's environment. The fleet tree divides its time limit between phases as described in Section 5.9: in 3D, 15% of the budget to root column generation, 3% reserved for the frontier sweep, placeability calls limited to 5 s and pricing calls to 20 s at eight CP-SAT workers each, the heuristic rung on with a 0.5% qualifying margin and the stop-early oracle, an initial Murty depth of 6 raised by two whenever the stack empties with budget left, at most two cut-and-repack rounds per partition attempt, and at most 15% of the budget on region certificates. The 900 s budget applies to the thirty-six generated instances and to the first two rungs of the size ladder, 1 800 s to the third and fourth rungs and 3 600 s to the fifth.

stage	time limit (s)	MIP gap	threads	memory cap (GB)	seed
MATH-3D-SCPTOP, 36 generated instances (Table 12)	900	$5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ (step 2), 0 (step 4)	10	20	0
MATH-3D-SCPTOP, size ladder (Tables 7–10)	900 / 1 800 / 3 600	$5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ (step 2), 0 (step 4)	10	20	0
fleet tree, volumetric oracle (Table 6)	1 800~	10^{-4}	10~	4~	not established
compact SCPTOP, volumetric reference (Table 6)	1 800 / 3 600	0	10	20	0
compact 3D-SCPTOP, $\|L\| = 3$ (Table 8)	1 800	0	10	20	0
SCPTOP, volumetric benchmark (Tables 12–13)	900	0.02	4	20	0
placeability recheck of SCPTOP loads	120 per load	—	4	20	0

What each reported quantity means.

- z is the cost (45) of the plan returned, net of any artificial penalty; a plan is reported only if it carries no artificial slack. For the fleet tree it is the incumbent of Algorithm 1; for the compact models it is the solver's incumbent at its stop. It is an upper bound on the optimum in every case.
- *trucks* is $\sum_{g,t} n_{gt}$ for that plan.
- LB is a lower bound on the optimum of the model the method solves. For the fleet tree it is the *certified* bound of Section 5.5: the root certificate, or the minimum over the certified bounds of the open frontier when that is higher. A bound is printed only where the sweep behind it came back with every pair proved; where it did not, the row says *unproved* and no gap is computed. For a compact model it is the solver's dual bound at its stop. A sentinel recorded by a run that obtained no bound is never printed, never averaged and never rounded to a side.
- *gap* is $(z - \mathrm{LB})/z$ against the method's own bound. It is an optimality gap only to the extent that the bound is tight, and Section 6.7 identifies exactly where it is not. It is never a gap to a proven optimum unless the row says so.
- *stop* names the condition under which a solve ended: OPTIMAL, TIME_LIMIT or MEM_LIMIT. A time or memory stop makes the row's time the budget rather than a solve time.
- *nodes* is the tree nodes opened and *open* the regions left unexpanded when time ran out; a run with open regions has not searched the space, whatever its gap.
- *verified* is the outcome of re-deriving every dispatched truck of a plan from the column's own fill and checking it against (39)–(44) — placement, stack height, crush limit, payload and the utilisation floor — by a routine that shares no code with the solver that produced it. *unplaceable* counts, among the loads a *volumetric* plan dispatches, those a constraint programme has *proved* cannot be stacked and placed in a trailer; loads it could not decide within its limit are reported as *undecided* alongside, and are counted neither way.
- Δz is the cost of one method relative to another on the same instance. The denominator is stated wherever it appears, and Δz is meaningful only between plans both of which are executable.

6.2 Instance generation

Thirty-six benchmark instances are generated as a full factorial over the four explanatory variables of the study: the number of products $|N| \in \{4, 8\}$, the horizon $|T| \in \{5, 10\}$, the number of RTI types $|R| \in \{2, 3, 4\}$ and the volumetric granularity $v \in \{60, 90, 120\}$. Instances are named $I_|N|_|T|_|R|_v$.

- **Container dimensions**: footprints are drawn from the industrial catalogue $\{1200 \times 800,\ 1200 \times 1000,\ 800 \times 600,\ 1200 \times 1600,\ 2400 \times 1200\}$ mm. Heights are quantised to 50 mm and a footprint is admissible for a given v only if the implied erected height lies in $[400, 1500]$ mm, so that an RTI is worth stacking and at least two layers fit under the trailer roof. Whenever $|R| \geq 3$ several RTI types share a footprint, reproducing a real catalogue in which container families sit on a common pallet base; this is what allows a stack to mix types across layers.
- **Container volume**: v is the number of erected RTIs that fill one truck by volume, and every RTI type is generated with volume at least Γ_K / v. Larger v means smaller RTIs and a harder placement subproblem; smaller v means a single container is a larger fraction of a trailer.
- **Demand**: generated per product and period by deviating $\pm 10\%$ from a mean calibrated so that roughly 2.5 truckloads are consumed per period. Calibrating the mean keeps difficulty comparable across the factorial instead of letting it drift with the RTI size.
- **Weights**: the content weight of a full RTI scales with its volume and varies by $\pm 25\%$ between products sharing an RTI type, which is what makes the per-stack crush limit depend on the period's product mix rather than on the RTI type alone.

The truck is a standard semi-trailer, $pK \times qK \times rK = 13600 \times 2400 \times 3000$ mm, payload $pK^w = 24$ t, per-stack crush limit $W^{\max} = 1200$ kg, minimum utilisation $\alpha = 0.55$ and cost $cK = 1000$ per dispatch. Lead time is $lt = 1$ and coverage stock one period of demand.

A size ladder. The benchmark tops out at $|N| = 8$ and $|T| = 10$. To find where, if anywhere, the decomposition pays against the compact model, a second set of instances is generated with the same rules along two axes: $(|N|, |T|) \in \{(8, 10), (12, 12), (16, 15), (24, 20)\}$, and the number of truckloads consumed per period, 2.5, 5 or 8, which scales the fleet K and with it the number of interchangeable trucks the compact

model indexes. The suffix is that figure times ten and is *not* K: $I_8_10_2_90_k25$, $I_12_12_2_90_k25$ and $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ have $K = 12$, and $I_24_20_2_90_k50$ has $K = 21$. These instances have $|R| = 2$ and $v = 90$. They stress different things: $|N|$ and $|T|$ grow the master and the number of pricing calls, while the fleet grows the compact model's per-truck variables and its symmetry.

Sizing the RTI fleet. One generation parameter deserves comment because it is easy to get wrong and the symptom is misleading. Empties return by the truckload, and a return truck leaves only once the plant has accumulated enough folded RTIs to clear the full-truckload floor. Since folded RTIs pack very densely, that takes several periods, during which the supplier must live off its own folded stock. If the fleet is sized only for the lead time, the linear relaxation remains feasible by dispatching fractional trucks while the integer problem has no solution at all. We therefore size the supplier's initial folded stock of each type to cover $lt + SC$ periods plus the number of periods, capped at six, needed to accumulate $\lceil \alpha\Gamma_K/\gamma_{sr} \rceil$ folded RTIs at the plant's rate of emptying them, which is the standard closed-loop argument that an RTI fleet must cover the cycle time.

6.3 Methods compared, and which procedure produced which table

Three solution procedures appear in the recorded results of this study, and only the first is the method of Section 5. They are listed with the tables they produced, because a table labelled with the method's name but produced by another procedure is the single easiest way for a study like this one to mislead.

- **MATH-3D-SCPTOP** — Algorithm 1 exactly as Section 5 states it: the master of Section 5.3 over a starting pool of the placeable single-commodity trucks and nothing else, columns from the pricing ladder of Section 5.6, the flow-first relax and fix of Section 5.8.1 as primal heuristic with the partition run as a cover, every part proved placeable before it becomes a column, dominance cuts on the parts proved unplaceable, integer stack counts in the aggregate master, the region $X \leq X^\star - 1$ constructed first, and the bound from the volumetric relaxation (Proposition 2). Every dispatched truck is verified. *This produced Tables 12, 13 and 7–11, and every MATH-3D-SCPTOP number quoted in this paper.*
- **The same method over the volumetric oracle** — the same master, the same search and the same construction, with the pricing problem replaced by the two-constraint knapsack of Section 5.6, so that a column is a volumetrically feasible full truck. *This produced the fleet-tree columns of Table 6.*
- **An earlier branch-and-price configuration**, in which the primal heuristic is the integer master over a pool seeded with the volumetric benchmark's placeable loads rather than the flow-first construction. It is a different procedure — a different pool, a different primal, and no placeability cuts — and on $I_8_5_2_90$ it returns 20 767.81 with fourteen trucks where MATH-3D-SCPTOP returns 18 796.96 with twelve. *No table in this paper reports it.* Its recorded output, `results/benchmark.csv` and `results/case_study.csv`, is not used for any method column here; the volumetric half of the first of those files, which involves no branch and price at all, is used for the placeability census of Section 6.7 and for nothing else.

The comparators are:

- **Compact SCPTOP** — the volumetric model of Appendix A solved directly by Gurobi. It solves the same problem as the fleet tree over the volumetric oracle, so the two bracket a common optimum, and it is the one comparator in this study that produces a *proved* optimum.
- **Compact 3D-SCPTOP** — the model of Section 4 solved directly at $|L| = 3$ loading configurations per direction, warm-started with the matheuristic's plan. $|L| = 3$ is a restriction chosen a priori: nothing here computes an over-estimate of $|L|$, and Proposition 1 states the equivalence only for an unrestricted $|L|$. Its *plan* is therefore a legitimate comparator and its dual bound is not an end of any interval.
- **SCPTOP** — the volumetric benchmark, identical to the master in every respect *except* that truck capacity is volumetric. It is not used as a yardstick for the 3D method; its role is Section 6.7, where the loads it dispatches are put to a placeability proof.
- **Company procedure (PLC-SCPTOP)** — the master over a fixed pool of manually derived loading configurations, as produced today by a spreadsheet. This is the intended comparator for the 3D rows, and Section 6.6 states why no number is reported against it here.

Table 6: The reformulation against the compact SCPTOP formulation, both solving the *volumetric* problem of Appendix A, so that the two bracket one common optimum. This is the comparison in which a reference optimum exists: the compact model closes two of the six instances. z is the incumbent at the stop; OPT marks a proved optimum, ^{m} a stop on the memory cap and ^{t} a stop on time. "bound" is Gurobi's dual bound for the compact model and the certified master-LP bound of Section 5.5 for the fleet tree. Δz is $(z_{\mathrm{tree}} - z_{\mathrm{compact}})/z_{\mathrm{compact}}$; negative means the fleet tree's plan is cheaper. **The budgets are not equal.** The compact runs record their own configuration and had 3 600 s and a 20 GB per-model cap; the fleet-tree runs recorded none, and their configuration is *recovered* after the fact from their launchers (marked ~) as 1 800 s with the 4 GB default cap, with no seed or commit established and, on the last row, no time limit established either (marked $^{!}$). The asymmetry runs against the fleet tree on every row where its budget is known, so a row on which it is cheaper is not a budget artefact; a row on which it is dearer may be.

	compact SCPTOP				fleet tree (volumetric oracle)					
Instance	z	bound	trucks	t (s)	z	bound (cert.)	trucks	t (s)	Δz (%)	tighter bound
*I*_8_5_2_90	18 796.96 OPT	18 796.96	12	0	*not run*	—	—	—	—	—
*I*_8_10_2_90_*k*25	38 855.65^{m}	38 851.93	26	3243	38 853.39^{t}	38 791.14	26	1817	−0.0058	38 851.93 (compact)
*I*_16_15_2_90_*k*25	68 139.17 OPT	68 139.17	45	1349	68 139.59^{t}	68 131.43	45	1897	+0.0006	68 139.17 (compact)
*I*_16_15_2_90_*k*50	134 346.91^{m}	133 417.47	89	1113	133 503.74^{t}	133 484.32	88	1827	−0.6276	133 484.32 (DW)
*I*_24_20_2_90_*k*50	200 266.21^{m}	199 518.04	137	2088	200 047.54^{t}	200 013.41	137	1854	−0.1092	200 013.41 (DW)
*I*_24_20_2_90_*k*80	282 101.77^{m}	280 823.53	189	2399	281 023.77^{t}	280 910.02	188	868$^{!}$	−0.3821	280 910.02 (DW)

6.4 The volumetric model against the compact SCPTOP formulation

Table 6 is the comparison in which the truth is sometimes known. On the volumetric problem the compact formulation is tractable at the sizes this study reaches — it closes two of the six instances to proved optimality — so the reformulation can be measured against a reference rather than against itself.

Against a proved optimum. On *I*_16_15_2_90_*k*25 the compact model proves the optimum, 68 139.17 with forty-five trucks, in 1 349 s of a 3 600 s budget at a 20 GB cap. The fleet tree over the volumetric oracle returns 68 139.59, also with forty-five trucks: 0.0006% above a *proved* optimum, and at the same fleet. Its own certified bound on the same instance, 68 131.43, lies 0.0114% below that optimum, so both ends of the reformulation's interval are within about a hundredth of a percent of the truth. This is the strongest credibility datum in the paper, and the reason for reporting it first is that nothing elsewhere in the study can be checked this way.

Three qualifications belong with it rather than after it, and the third is the one that limits what it proves.

The budgets are *not* equal, and the inequality runs against the fleet tree: the compact model had twice the time and five times the memory. The fleet-tree run recorded no configuration of its own, so the 1 800 s and the 4 GB in the table are recovered from its launcher and the system journal, with no seed and no commit established; a recovered configuration is weaker than a recorded one, and what it supports is the objective comparison — two numbers on one instance — and not a timing claim. And the five volumetric runs are five days older than the 3D campaign: they ran the same *scheme* — the master of Section 5.3, the pure single-commodity pool, the flow-first relax and fix, the two-level fleet branch and bound — but an earlier revision of it, in which step 3 solved an exact split rather than the cover of Section 5.8.1, step 2 carried no integer stack counts, and level 1 did not recurse. They are therefore evidence about the scheme and not a measurement of the code that produced Table 7. Re-running them on the current code is a cheap and obvious next step, and until it is done this row is the weakest-provenanced of the paper's strong claims.

One thing the volumetric rows do measure cleanly is the tree, because there it certifies per node. On *I*_16_15_2_90_*k*25 its root construction returns 68 151.00 at 332 s and four node improvements take that to 68 139.59, a gain of 0.0167% that lands within 0.0006% of the proved optimum. The pattern repeats on the three larger rows: root plans of 133 506.22, 200 053.56 and 281 024.98 improved by three, five and two node improvements to 133 503.74, 200 047.54 and 281 023.77 — gains of 0.0019%, 0.0030% and 0.0004%. The tree earns little here and much on the 3D rows, which is consistent with what the root leaves it: where the relaxation is nearly exact the construction is already there.

Where the compact model stops on memory. On the other four instances the compact model exhausts its 20 GB cap with its dual bound still short of its incumbent. The fleet tree's plan is cheaper on

all four — by 0.0058%, 0.6276%, 0.1092% and 0.3821% of the compact incumbent — and uses one truck fewer on two of them. Its certified bound is the tighter of the two on three of the four; on *I*_8_10_2_90_*k*25 the compact model's dual bound, 38 851.93, is tighter than the reformulation's 38 791.14 by 0.157%. The budget asymmetry means a row on which the fleet tree is cheaper is not a budget artefact, while the one row on which its bound is looser may be.

The bound, tighter and sooner. The clearest statement about the bound does not need the recovered runs. On *I*_12_12_2_90_*k*25 the reformulation certifies 52 105.25 after 26.3 s of its 1 800 s 3D run — a full sweep in which every (g, t) pair priced optimal and nothing priced out, over the volumetric relaxation and so valid for the 3D problem by Proposition 2. The compact volumetric model on the same instance, given 600 s, ten threads and a 20 GB cap, stops at a dual bound of 51 944.22 with an incumbent of 52 116.69. The decomposition's bound is 0.310% tighter and arrives in a twenty-third of the time. The two budgets differ and are stated for that reason; both bounds are valid bounds on the same relaxation.

6.5 The 3D problem

Table 7: MATH-3D-SCPTOP on the size ladder, **every row on one commit** (`73411b9`; the optimality proof of footnote [b] is a separate run of the *compact volumetric* model, named in the source), ten threads, a 20 GB per-model cap and seed 0, run sequentially. *nodes* is the tree nodes opened, *dropped* the regions left with no bound covering them, *open* those still on the stack at the deadline; a region counted *closed* carries a certified bound, which is not the same as being refuted (see Section 6). *root* is the plan the construction returns before any node is popped and *tree* the improvement the search then makes on it, both read from the same run's trace: this is the controlled measurement of what branching contributes, and it replaces a cross-commit comparison of two verified upper bounds, which is not one. All plans are verified truck by truck by code sharing nothing with the solver. The bound is the certified volumetric relaxation, valid for 3D by Proposition 2; it is loose wherever the crush limit binds, so the gap on the last two rows is not an optimality gap. *I*_8_5_2_90 is the exception and is the paper's only proved optimum: there the volumetric relaxation itself solves to optimality at exactly the 3D plan's cost (footnote [b]).

Instance	z	trucks	verified	LB (cert.)	gap	root (t)	tree	nodes	dropped	open	wall / budget (s)
*I*_8_5_2_90	18 796.96[b]	12	12 / 12	18 796.96[b]	**0 (optimal)**	18 796.96 (140 s)	0.00%	67	0	0	873 / 900
*I*_8_10_2_90_*k*25	38 855.34	26	26 / 26	38 791.14[c]	0.165%	38 865.30 (136 s)	0.03%	68	0	35	883 / 900
*I*_12_12_2_90_*k*25	52 129.45	34	34 / 34	52 105.2	0.046%	53 195.84 (459 s)	**2.00%**[d]	11	0	10	1 761 / 1 800
*I*_16_15_2_90_*k*25	78 549.14	54	54 / 54	68 131.43[c]	13.3%[e]	78 549.14 (1 181 s)	0.00%	1	0	2	1 746 / 1 800
*I*_24_20_2_90_*k*50	230 594.36	160	160 / 160	200 013.4	13.3%[e]	230 594.36 (1 418 s)	0.00%	2	0	4	3 492 / 3 600

[b] The volumetric relaxation of this instance solves to proved optimality at 18 796.96 in 0.18 s, and the verified 3D plan costs the same to machine precision. Every placeable load is volumetrically feasible, so $z^\star_{\text{3D}} \geq z^\star_{\text{vol}}$ and a feasible 3D plan attaining it is optimal. *This proof does not come from the method*: no tree, no pricing, no geometric certification. It is available because on this catalogue the height-limited and crush-limited layer counts coincide, which is precisely the condition under which Section 6 argues a volumetric capacity is adequate. The method's own attempt at the same proof — certifying, under their own duals, the three regions its search could not refute — failed, at 237 s per region. [c] The method's own certified bound. On these two instances the compact volumetric model's dual bound is tighter and is also valid for 3D by inclusion — 38 851.93 at a memory stop and 68 139.17 proved optimal — which narrows the gaps to 0.009% and 13.25%; it is reported in Table 6 and used as the interval end in Table 8, and the gap column here is to one bound throughout so that one row never carries two. [d] This is where branching does the most work in the paper: the construction returns 53 195.84 at 459 s and five node improvements take it to 52 129.45, a 2.00% gain that reproduces under a second certification policy (53 248.76 → 52 127.89). A run on an earlier revision reached 52 123.03, 0.012% below this row; that is a comparison of two verified upper bounds across commits and we report it here rather than in the table, because it is not a controlled experiment. [e] Not an optimality gap. The volumetric bound is loose exactly where the crush limit halves the layer count, which is the regime these two instances were generated to expose.

The compact 3D model cannot serve as a yardstick. Table 8 sets the compact 3D-SCPTOP model against the method on four rungs of the ladder, and the finding is a negative one that the rest of this section depends on. On *I*_8_5_2_90 — the one instance on which the compact model returns a plan — it has three configurations per direction, 67 674 variables and 92 092 constraints, and stops on its 1 800 s time limit at 18 816.13 with a dual bound of 18 795.76, no phantom freight, twelve loads that pass the independent

Table 8: The compact 3D-SCPTOP model ($|L| = 3$ configurations per direction, Gurobi, 1 800 s) against MATH-3D-SCPTOP on the size ladder, the method's rows being those of Table 7. All runs used ten threads, a 20 GB per-model cap and seed 0. **The budgets differ on three rows**: the compact model had 1 800 s throughout, the method 900 s on the first two rows, 1 800 s on the next two — which are therefore the equal-budget pairs — and 3 600 s on the last. *stop* is how the compact solve ended and LB its dual bound there; *none* means no feasible solution was found inside the budget. The method's LB is its certified volumetric bound (Proposition 2), *gap* is to that bound, *first hit* the time at which the reported plan was found, and *verified* the independent truck-by-truck check. No row is an optimum except where footnote [b] applies. The last column is the interval in which $z^\star$ lies, taking the method's plan as the upper end and, as the lower end, the tighter bound *that is a bound on the problem*: the compact 3D model's dual bound bounds its own $|L| = 3$ restriction and not $z^\star$ (Proposition 1), so it appears in its column and never as an interval end, and where a compact *volumetric* solve exists its dual bound is used instead, being valid for 3D by inclusion.

	compact 3D-SCPTOP, 1 800 s						MATH-3D-SCPTOP							
Instance	z	trucks	LB	stop	RSS (GB)	verified	z	trucks	LB (cert.)	gap	budget (s)	first hit (s)	nodes / open	$z^\star$ in
I_8_5_2_90	18 816.13	12	18 795.76	TIME_LIMIT	3.8	12 / 12[a]	18 796.96	12	18 795.54	0.0076%	900	140.2	67 / 0	[18 796.96, 18 796.96][b]
I_8_10_2_90_k25	*none*	—	36 458.75	TIME_LIMIT	6.1	—	38 855.34	26	38 791.14	0.165%	900	590.7	68 / 35	[38 851.93, 38 855.34][c]
I_12_12_2_90_k25	*none*	—	48 516.86	TIME_LIMIT	2.7	—	52 129.45	34	52 105.25	0.046%	1 800	1 648.5	11 / 10	[52 105.25, 52 129.45]
I_16_15_2_90_k25	*none*	—	64 053.23	TIME_LIMIT	4.5	—	78 549.14	54	68 131.43[d]	13.3%[d]	1 800	1 180.9	1 / 2	[68 139.17, 78 549.14][c]
I_24_20_2_90_k50	not run						230 594.36	160	200 013.41[d]	13.3%[d]	3 600	1 418.2	2 / 4	[200 013.41, 230 594.36]

[a] From the re-run of the compact model after a defect in the layout extraction was fixed; the first run returned the same objective, bound and stop condition, with no phantom freight, but its extracted layouts stated under-filled slots against the designed layer count and failed the verifier. The re-run's twelve loads pass it. [b] The only optimum this paper reports, and it is not the method's: the compact volumetric model solves this instance to proved optimality at 18 796.96 in 0.18 s, every placeable load is volumetrically feasible, and the verified 3D plan attains that value (Section 6.5). [c] Lower end from the compact volumetric model's bound on the same instance, valid for 3D by Proposition 2 and tighter than the method's own: 38 851.93 at a memory stop, and 68 139.17 proved optimal (Table 6). [d] Not an optimality gap. The volumetric bound is loose exactly where the crush limit halves a family's layer count, which is the regime these two instances were generated to expose (Section 6.7).

Table 9: What the starting pool, the search order and the frontier reserve cost (ten threads, seed 0). The first row seeded the pool by hand with demand-mix and pair fills and is *not* the method; it is the reference the pure-pool rows are measured against, and it ran at a 4 GB cap on an earlier commit, so it is not a controlled comparison with them. The pure rows start from the single-commodity trucks and nothing else. *integer stacks* is whether step 2 counts stacks per footprint in integers; *order* is which level-1 region the tree constructs in first; *reserve* is the share of the budget held back for the frontier sweep. Rows marked *final* are the final code, in which a region's certificate comes from the volumetric relaxation; on it the sweep takes seconds, so a 15% reserve is unused time, and 3% is the value the campaign of Tables 7 and 8 ran at. No row of this table *is* a row of that campaign: these are earlier commits, kept because they isolate one decision each, and they are not compared with it on time. Every plan is verified truck by truck; the bound is the certified volumetric relaxation in every row.

Instance	pool	rung	integer stacks	order	reserve	cap (GB)	z	trucks	first hit (s)	budget (s)	nodes / open	LB (cert.)
I_8_5_2_90	seeded by hand (reference)	no	no	$X = X^\star$ first	15%	4	18 796.96	12	48.5	900	219 / 0	18 795.54
I_8_5_2_90	pure	no	no	$X = X^\star$ first	15%	4	19 682.36	13	172.2	900	170 / 10	18 795.54
I_8_5_2_90	pure	yes	no	$X = X^\star$ first	15%	20	19 682.36	13	140.3	900	180 / 9	18 795.54
I_8_5_2_90	pure	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	15%	20	18 796.96	12	139.9	900	170 / 5	18 795.54
I_8_5_2_90	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	15%	20	18 796.96	12	140.2	900	135 / 4	18 795.54
I_8_5_2_90	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	3%	20	18 796.96	12	185.4	900	147 / 7	18 795.54
I_8_10_2_90_k25	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	15%	20	38 859.44	26	420.8	900	18 / 7	38 791.14
I_8_10_2_90_k25	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	3%	20	38 855.70	26	481.9	900	30 / 5	38 791.14
I_12_12_2_90_k25	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	15%	20	52 129.91	34	1 515.3	1 800	12 / 9	52 105.25
I_12_12_2_90_k25	pure, final	yes	yes	$X \le X^\star - 1$ first	3%	20	52 123.03	34	1 691.9	1 800	17 / 11	52 105.25

Table 10: The pricing ladder. Top: the heuristic rung measured against the exact oracle under the *same duals* over the pure pool, in a stand-alone column-generation loop with two threads, two CP-SAT workers and a 5 s exact oracle — a measurement of which columns each finds, not of production speed. *LP* is the restricted-master value after the stated number of iterations; on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ the pure-pool master is infeasible and the value is dominated by the big-M artificials until the pool can cover demand. Bottom: the rung inside the one-commit production runs of Table 7: pricing calls, calls the rung served without the exact oracle, columns it kept, exact-oracle calls, and the dispatched trucks of the reported plan (weighted by dispatch count) that are the rung's columns. The last column is where the rung matters: it contributes no truck to the three plans whose certified gap is under 0.05%, and 44 of 54 and 122 of 160 trucks to the two plans on the crush-binding catalogue, where the pure pool cannot even make the master feasible.

Measurement (results/fleet_tree_3d/ladder_measure_*.json)

Instance	mode	iterations	LP	columns	wall (s)
$I_8_5_2_90$	exact oracle only	5	18 796.66	30	119.3
$I_8_5_2_90$	rung, then oracle	5	18 798.56	48	126.4
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	exact oracle only	3	$3.40 \cdot 10^7$ (infeasible)	60	231.5
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	rung, then oracle	1	79 400.38	47	78.9
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	rung, then oracle	3	76 810.49	104	237.9

In the production runs (`stats.ladder` of the Table 7 files)

Instance	calls	served by rung	kept	exact calls	rung trucks in plan
$I_8_5_2_90$	215	13	22	202	0 / 12
$I_8_10_2_90_k25$	69	15	27	54	0 / 26
$I_12_12_2_90_k25$	227	66	118	161	0 / 34
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	585	206	355	379	44 / 54
$I_24_20_2_90_k50$	873	318	541	555	122 / 160

Table 11: Fleet floors certified offline. The volumetric relaxation's master, restricted to $\sum_{g,t} n_{gt} \leq X$, is priced to convergence with one thread (commit dd5f039); INFEASIBLE means no plan with at most X trucks exists, in 3D as well, since every placeable load is volumetrically feasible and the fleet row does not depend on the load model (Proposition 2). A bound instead of a refutation means the relaxation admits plans with X trucks, so nothing about the truck count is proved. *time* is the region certification alone; the root certificate it rests on took 4 to 32 s. The two $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ rows were certified against an earlier fifty-three-truck plan; the plan reported in Table 7 has fifty-four trucks and $X \leq 53$ was not tested, so no claim is made about that instance's minimum fleet either way.

Instance	plan's trucks	X tested	verdict	bound over region	time (s)
$I_8_5_2_90$	12	≤ 11	INFEASIBLE: 12 is the minimum fleet	—	1.5
$I_8_10_2_90_k25$	26	≤ 25	INFEASIBLE: 26 is the minimum fleet	—	3.9
$I_12_12_2_90_k25$	34	≤ 33	INFEASIBLE: 34 is the minimum fleet	—	16.3
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	54	≤ 52	not refuted	68 131.43	1.3
$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	54	≤ 45	not refuted	68 131.43	1.2

Table 12: The thirty-six generated instances through MATH-3D-SCPTOP (Section 5.8.1 inside the fleet tree of Section 5.9), every row on one commit (`0c0c16c`), a 900 s budget, ten threads, a 20 GB per-model cap and seed 0, run sequentially so that no two rows shared the cores. Every wall time is at or inside the budget. *ver* is the number of dispatched trucks that an independent verifier re-derives from the column's own fill and finds legal — placement, stack height, crush limit, payload and the utilisation floor — out of the number dispatched; no plan in this table carries a complaint. LB is the certified volumetric relaxation, valid for the 3D problem by Proposition 2, and is printed only where the sweep came back with every pair proved; *gap* is to that bound and is an optimality gap only to the extent the bound is tight, which Section 6.7 shows it is not where the crush limit binds. *parts* is the number of distinct truck compositions the partition proposed, of which *unpl.* were *proved* unplaceable and *und.* left undecided; an undecided composition is counted on neither side. The last two columns are the volumetric benchmark SCPTOP on the same instance: the loads it dispatches, and how many of them a constraint programme proves cannot be placed in a trailer at all.

				MATH-3D-SCPTOP						partition			SCPTOP loads	
Instance	$\|N\|$	$\|T\|$	$\|R\|$	z	trucks	ver	LB (cert.)	gap	nodes	parts	unpl.	und.	loads	unpl.
I_4_10_2_120	4	10	2	62 505.08	45	45 / 45	53 425.21	14.53%	0	214	64	9	36	30
I_4_10_2_60	4	10	2	*no plan*	—	—	31 847.48	—	0	64	32	0	22	20
I_4_10_2_90	4	10	2	45 230.80	29	29 / 29	42 208.62	6.68%	3	282	82	4	26	22
I_4_10_3_120	4	10	3	57 953.00	42	42 / 42	47 690.39	17.71%	1	203	59	8	32	26
I_4_10_3_60	4	10	3	34 236.78	23	23 / 23	30 862.57	9.86%	2	127	42	13	20	18
I_4_10_3_90	4	10	3	44 485.13	30	30 / 30	44 456.13	0.07%	16	543	88	25	31	6
I_4_10_4_120	4	10	4	50 734.95	35	35 / 35	50 555.71	0.35%	4	450	133	18	35	12
I_4_10_4_60	4	10	4	*no plan*	—	—	35 872.62	—	0	51	32	0	24	23
I_4_10_4_90	4	10	4	43 698.86	29	29 / 29	40 487.62	7.35%	1	224	68	10	26	17
I_4_5_2_120	4	5	2	27 226.24	18	18 / 18	25 172.69	7.54%	10	490	242	22	16	16
I_4_5_2_60	4	5	2	14 715.58	9	9 / 9	13 768.49	6.44%	76	376	25	56	8	6
I_4_5_2_90	4	5	2	19 740.03	13	13 / 13	17 763.70	10.01%	126	2430	1193	12	11	9
I_4_5_3_120	4	5	3	25 925.74	16	16 / 16	25 787.76	0.53%	11	463	191	45	16	6
I_4_5_3_60	4	5	3	19 669.36	15	15 / 15	13 626.60	30.72%	1	75	30	0	9	9
I_4_5_3_90	4	5	3	21 502.06	14	14 / 14	21 498.70	0.02%	51	138	0	18	14	0
I_4_5_4_120	4	5	4	28 229.12	17	17 / 17	26 289.27	6.87%	19	937	426	38	15	9
I_4_5_4_60	4	5	4	16 166.20	12	12 / 12	12 969.54	19.77%	8	228	126	12	9	8
I_4_5_4_90	4	5	4	21 531.74	14	14 / 14	20 525.49	4.67%	19	534	273	10	13	7
I_8_10_2_120	8	10	2	63 265.31	44	44 / 44	55 483.16	12.30%	1	462	122	2	37	30
I_8_10_2_60	8	10	2	*no plan*	—	—	30 630.70	—	0	88	48	0	22	21
I_8_10_2_90	8	10	2	50 008.13	36	36 / 36	43 242.73	13.53%	1	210	56	4	30	27
I_8_10_3_120	8	10	3	58 632.27	40	40 / 40	52 387.71	10.65%	1	409	102	11	35	24
I_8_10_3_60	8	10	3	33 286.65	24	24 / 24	*unproved*	—	1	170	45	5	20	17
I_8_10_3_90	8	10	3	41 501.25	27	27 / 27	37 630.17	9.33%	1	112	44	9	24	21
I_8_10_4_120	8	10	4	66 209.55	44	44 / 44	58 184.10	12.12%	1	276	83	5	37	30
I_8_10_4_60	8	10	4	*no plan*	—	—	30 093.95	—	0	51	28	1	21	19
I_8_10_4_90	8	10	4	46 474.74	29	29 / 29	43 174.67	7.10%	1	285	84	4	27	15
I_8_5_2_120	8	5	2	26 181.24	16	16 / 16	26 066.68	0.44%	12	501	168	0	16	5
I_8_5_2_60	8	5	2	20 422.01	15	15 / 15	15 159.80	25.77%	3	211	89	0	10	9
I_8_5_2_90	8	5	2	18 796.96	12	12 / 12	18 795.54	0.01%	68	35	0	1	12	0
I_8_5_3_120	8	5	3	22 162.16	14	14 / 14	21 045.66	5.04%	2	258	70	24	13	9
I_8_5_3_60	8	5	3	*no plan*	—	—	14 101.19	—	0	53	35	1	9	9
I_8_5_3_90	8	5	3	18 649.29	12	12 / 12	18 648.12	0.01%	80	98	5	9	12	0
I_8_5_4_120	8	5	4	24 423.97	15	15 / 15	24 338.21	0.35%	8	361	85	18	15	5
I_8_5_4_60	8	5	4	17 693.47	12	12 / 12	13 578.09	23.26%	2	62	26	1	8	8
I_8_5_4_90	8	5	4	21 192.52	13	13 / 13	20 993.24	0.94%	6	395	131	2	13	8

Table 13: Table 12 by instance factor. *plans* counts the instances on which MATH-3D-SCPTOP returned a verified plan inside the 900 s budget; the mean gap is over those instances only and over the rows whose bound was proved, and the count of each is given so that the denominator is never in doubt. The last three columns are the volumetric benchmark's dispatched loads: the share a constraint programme *proves* unplaceable, the share it leaves *undecided*, and the share it places. The undecided share must be read with the other two: a low count of proven infeasibilities means nothing where most loads were undecided.

factor	value	plans	mean gap (rows)	loads	unpl.	und.	placed
$\|N\|$	4	16 / 18	8.9% (16)	363	67.2%	26.4%	6.3%
	8	15 / 18	8.6% (14)	361	71.2%	21.6%	7.2%
$\|T\|$	5	17 / 18	8.4% (17)	219	56.2%	33.8%	10.0%
	10	14 / 18	9.4% (13)	505	74.9%	19.8%	5.3%
$\|R\|$	2	10 / 12	9.7% (10)	246	79.3%	15.4%	5.3%
	3	11 / 12	8.4% (10)	235	61.7%	29.4%	8.9%
	4	10 / 12	8.3% (10)	243	66.3%	27.6%	6.2%
v	60	7 / 12	19.3% (6)	182	91.8%	2.7%	5.5%
	90	12 / 12	5.0% (12)	239	55.2%	36.4%	8.4%
	120	12 / 12	7.4% (12)	303	66.7%	27.1%	6.3%
all		31 / 36	8.8% (30)	724	69.2%	24.0%	6.8%

verifier, and a peak resident set of 3.8 GB against the 20 GB cap. The method reaches 18 796.96 with twelve verified trucks at 140.2 s, a plan 0.102% cheaper, which the 67 nodes the tree then opens do not improve.

From ten periods on the compact model returns *no feasible solution at all.* On $I_8_10_2_90_k25$ (119 424 variables, 164 692 constraints at $|L| = 3$), on $I_12_12_2_90_k25$ (200 748 and 256 180) and on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ (322 734 and 393 412) it finds none in 1 800 s. All three stopped on time, not on memory: their peak resident sets were 6.1, 2.7 and 4.5 GB against the declared 20 GB cap, so the runs had their memory budget and did not use it, and the honest statement is that the model could not reach a first incumbent in the time it was given. Nor is this a guard rejecting a corrupt solution: the leak counter is zero because there was no solution to leak. Four rungs are four rungs and we do not generalise beyond the sizes they cover; what they establish is that beyond five periods the compact 3D model supplies neither a plan to compare against nor a bound that bounds the problem — its dual bound bounds the $|L| = 3$ restriction — which is why the comparator for the 3D rows has to be the procedure in use rather than the exact model.

One proved optimum, and it is not the method's. On $I_8_5_2_90$ the volumetric relaxation solves to proved optimality at 18 796.96 in 0.18 s, and the verified 3D plan costs the same to machine precision. Every placeable load is volumetrically feasible, so $z^\star_{\mathrm{3D}} \geq z^\star_{\mathrm{vol}}$, and a feasible 3D plan attaining the latter is optimal. That is the only optimum this paper reports, and it is established by inclusion from an exactly solved relaxation — no tree, no pricing, no geometric certification. The method's own attempt at the same proof failed: certifying, under their own duals, the three regions its search could not refute returned 18 795.57, 18 795.54 and 18 795.54 against an incumbent of 18 796.96, none of them proved, at 237 s per region. The reason is arithmetic rather than accidental — with the fleet fixed at twelve trucks, refuting a leaf needs a maximum reduced cost below roughly 0.12 per column, while pricing on the same instance was still returning columns an order of magnitude below that. The proof is available on this instance because its two container families have coinciding height-limited and crush-limited layer counts, which is precisely the condition under which Section 6.7 finds a volumetric capacity adequate.

The size ladder. Table 7 reports the method on five rungs, every row on one commit and verified truck by truck. Read as a progression it says three things. The certified gap is under 0.05% through twelve periods — 0.0076%, 0.009% and 0.046% — and the truck counts there are the minimum possible, because the region with one truck fewer is certified infeasible (Table 11): $X \leq 11$, $X \leq 25$ and $X \leq 33$ are infeasible in 1.5, 3.9 and 16.3 s, and the reported plans use twelve, twenty-six and thirty-four trucks. What remains of those gaps is inventory cost. At fifteen and twenty periods the method still returns verified plans — fifty-four trucks at 78 549.14 and one hundred and sixty at 230 594.36 — but the gap jumps to 13.3%, and Section 6.7

attributes that to the bound rather than to the plan. On $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ neither $X \leq 52$ nor $X \leq 45$ is refuted, so nothing about the truck count is proved there, for the same reason the bound is loose: the volumetric relaxation admits forty-five-truck plans — its own optimum has forty-five — and cannot separate the fifty-four-truck 3D plan from fifty-three.

Twenty periods: the round cap is what made the plan possible. The twenty-period row deserves a note because an earlier revision of this work reported that instance as unsolved, and the difference is one parameter. Under an uncapped cut-and-repack walk the construction spent 2 224 s of a 3 065 s run inside the partition — 387 cut rounds over the first fourteen of forty (direction, period) pairs, 8 709 placeability calls — and reached the deadline with no plan at all. Step 3's deliverable is columns and not the partition, which the cover of Section 5.8.1 already conceded, so a pair whose parts will not place need not be pursued round after round: with the rounds capped at two, the parts that did place kept as columns and the failing pairs left to step 4, the same instance returns a verified one-hundred-and-sixty-truck plan at 230 594.36, the root construction finding it at 1 418 s. Forty-four of the eighty-seven (direction, period) pairs the construction attempted were left to step 4 in that run. The cap is a parameter of a primal heuristic, so this is a statement about the heuristic and not about the problem.

The full factorial. Tables 12 and 13 run the same method over the thirty-six generated instances at a uniform 900 s, one commit, sequentially. It returns a verified plan on thirty-one of thirty-six and a proved bound on thirty-five; no plan carries a verification complaint, and every wall time is at or inside the budget. The mean certified gap over the thirty rows that have both a plan and a proved bound is 8.8%.

The five failures are the informative part, and they are not spread across the factorial: all five have $v = 60$, the coarsest granularity, where RTIs are largest and a single container is the largest fraction of a trailer. At $v = 60$ the method returns a plan on seven of twelve instances and its mean gap on those is 19.3%; at $v = 90$ and $v = 120$ it returns a plan on twelve of twelve with mean gaps of 5.0% and 7.4%. The same granularity is where the volumetric benchmark's loads are least placeable (91.8% proved unplaceable, against 55.2% and 66.7%), so the two difficulties have a common cause: when one container is a large fraction of the trailer, the integer structure of the loading problem is coarse, the volumetric relaxation is at its least informative, and the construction has the least room to cover a delivery vector with full trucks. A plan is not returned rather than an invalid one being returned, which is a consequence of the formulation: a column that the verifier would reject never enters the pool.

What the tree contributes, and where. The contribution is uneven across the ladder and is not averaged away. At five periods the tree opens 67 nodes and improves nothing: the root construction returns 18 796.96 at 140.2 s and that is the plan. At ten periods it opens 68 and seven incumbent improvements take 38 865.30 at 135.9 s to 38 855.34 at 590.7 s, a gain of 0.026%. At twelve periods it opens 11 and five improvements take 53 195.84 at 459.0 s to 52 129.45 at 1 648.5 s, a gain of 2.005% — this is where branching does the most work in the paper. At fifteen and twenty it opens 1 and 2 nodes and the reported plan is the root construction's. Over the thirty-six generated instances the node counts range from 0 to 126; they are not a predictor of the gap, which $I_4_5_2_90$ makes plain at 126 nodes and 10.0%.

Repeat runs matter at these margins, and the exclusion is stated rather than applied. On $I_12_12_2_90_k25$ two runs of the same knob set on two commits returned 52 129.45 and 52 127.89, both with thirty-four trucks, a spread of 0.003%; two further runs under a delivery-branching variant since withdrawn for a diagnosed defect returned 53 005.78 and 53 425.07, both with thirty-five trucks. The method is deadline-driven at every phase, so a step-2 solve landing at 299 s rather than 301 s takes a different branch; no objective delta below a few hundredths of a percent on an instance of this kind is reported here without its measured spread beside it.

Where the time goes. It depends on whether the crush limit binds, and the split is read from each run's own clock. On $I_8_5_2_90$ column generation takes 864 s of an 873 s run and everything else 8 s: the geometry is free and the budget goes into pricing columns that do not improve the plan. On $I_8_10_2_90_k25$ the aggregate master of step 2 takes 573 s of 883, column generation 181 s, the partitions 79 s of which 65 s are placeability calls, and the integer master 35 s. On $I_12_12_2_90_k25$ the integer master of step 4 takes 1 024 s of 1 761 and the partitions 325 s. On the two crush-binding rungs the partition dominates: 934 s of 1 746 on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ and 1 677 s of 3 492 on $I_24_20_2_90_k50$, of which 369 s and 1 246 s are placeability calls. The aggregate and integer masters are the scaling limit where the crush limit does not bind, and they are shared with the volumetric method; where it does bind, proving parts unplaceable is. Within placeability, the constructive shelf design answers essentially every positive verdict and the constraint

programme supplies the proofs of impossibility: over the thirty-six generated instances the shelf design placed 24 686 loads and the constraint programme 246, while the programme proved 4 327 of the 11 866 distinct compositions proposed unplaceable and left 397 undecided.

The pool and the pricing ladder. Tables 9 and 10 isolate two decisions. The pure single-commodity pool costs nothing on $I_8_5_2_90$ once step 2 counts stacks in integers and the region $X \leq X^\star - 1$ is constructed first: the method returns the twelve-truck plan at 18 796.96, to the cent the value of the hand-seeded reference that was removed from the method. Without those two decisions it returned thirteen trucks at 19 682.36, for the reason given in Section 5.8.1. The heuristic rung's contribution depends on the instance in a way the qualifying rule predicts: where the volumetric relaxation is nearly exact it is neutral to slightly negative — on $I_8_5_2_90$ the stand-alone measurement reaches an LP of 18 798.56 after five iterations with the rung against 18 796.66 without it, on a pool sixty percent larger — and on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ it is the difference between a feasible restricted master and none: over the seventeen single-commodity trucks the master carries $1.55 \cdot 10^8$ of artificials, three sweeps of a 5 s exact oracle leave it at $3.4 \cdot 10^7$, and the rung reaches a feasible 79 400 after one iteration and 76 810 after three. In the one-commit runs it served 13, 15, 66, 206 and 318 of the 215, 69, 227, 585 and 873 pricing calls, and the trucks it contributed to the reported plan are none, none, none, 44 of 54 and 122 of 160: nothing on the three instances whose certified gap is under 0.05%, and most of the fleet on the two where the pure pool cannot make the master feasible at all (Table 10). The certificate is never the rung's: the bound of every row is one uncapped exact sweep of the volumetric oracle.

6.6 Against the procedure in use

The comparator for the 3D rows is the company procedure, because Section 6.5 established that the compact 3D model cannot serve as one. **That comparison is not reported in this revision.** The reason is stated here rather than deferred, because the file that would fill the table exists and must not be read as filling it.

> Not available in this revision. The case study comparing MATH-3D-SCPTOP against PLC-SCPTOP on the nine company instances requires a run of the method of Section 5 against baselines solved to the gap the comparison claims. Neither condition is met by the recorded run on disk, for two independent reasons given below, so no cost, truck count or percentage saving is quoted against the company procedure anywhere in this paper.

First, the method column of that run was produced by the earlier branch-and-price configuration of Section 6.3 and not by the method of Section 5 — a pool seeded with the company's own configurations, and the integer master rather than the flow-first relax and fix as the primal. Labelling it with the method's name would be the error this section is organised to avoid.

Second, and independently, all nine company baselines stopped on their 315 s time limit rather than at the requested MIP gap of zero. A saving measured over a baseline that was not solved is a saving over whatever the baseline's solver happened to hold when the clock ran out; it bounds the true saving from one side only, and in the wrong direction for the claim, since a better-solved baseline can only reduce it. The same run makes the point against itself: its nine savings over the company procedure span -1.25% to $+18.47\%$ and are *negative* on two instances, which is not a result that survives either defect being repaired in an unknown direction.

Two observations from the same run do *not* depend on the solution procedure and are reported, because they are properties of the company's configuration set rather than of anything the method did. Reconstructing that set from the planner's average mixes yields very few distinct configurations when demand is stable, and on three of the nine instances the reconstruction had to be extended by 77, 66 and 73 configurations before the programme could be served at all; on the other six it needed none. And on eight of the nine instances the *dedicated* reading of a configuration — one per product, rather than shared across an RTI family — served the programme better than the shared one. Both say the same thing about the practical cost of a fixed configuration set: it is not that the procedure fails, since the plant plainly operates, but that keeping it feasible as the programme moves requires a planner to maintain a large and growing catalogue by hand, every entry of which was found by trial rather than by design.

The nine instances also carry the one piece of evidence about real containers that does not depend on the method at all. The volumetric benchmark, run on them under the same budgets, dispatches 392 truck loads of which 189 — 48.2% — are *proved* unplaceable by the same constraint programme used throughout. That run did not record how many of the remainder were left undecided, so 48.2% is a lower bound on the share that cannot be placed and not an estimate of it.

6.7 Is a volumetric capacity adequate?

This is the question that decides whether the 3D representation buys anything, and it is answered by proof rather than by argument: every truck load the volumetric benchmark dispatches is submitted to a constraint programme asking whether that exact set of RTIs can be stacked and placed in a trailer at all, with the true slot bound (37) in force so that an infeasibility verdict is a proof and not a modelling artefact.

The census. Over the thirty-six generated instances the volumetric benchmark dispatches 724 truck loads. Of those, 501 (69.2%) are *proved* unplaceable, 49 (6.8%) are proved placeable, and 174 (24.0%) are left undecided within the limit. The undecided share must be read with the other two, and it is not noise: a constraint programme cannot decide easy loads quickly either, and the undecided counts of Table 12 are where that shows. What the census supports is therefore a statement about the loads it *decided*: of the 550 loads decided either way, 91.1% cannot be placed.

The error has a direction, and the direction is what matters operationally. A volumetric capacity ignores the remainders that footprints and layer heights leave unusable, so where it errs it errs by dispatching loads that do not fit. A planner handed such a plan discovers the shortfall on the loading dock, not in the model. By granularity the shares are 91.8% proved unplaceable at $v = 60$ (with only 2.7% undecided, so that row is nearly fully decided), 55.2% at $v = 90$ and 66.7% at $v = 120$.

The mechanism. The error of a volumetric capacity is governed by how much it over-credits a truck relative to what physically fits, and the clearest single case is measured directly. On $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ the payload admits 57 full RTIs of product P_1 in one truck, and 32 is the largest number that can be placed — a proved bound, obtained by running the pricing problem for that commodity alone to optimality. The cause is that the family's container is 650 mm tall, so four layers fit under the 3 000 mm roof, while at 378 to 484 kg full only two fit under the 1 200 kg crush limit. A volumetric fill therefore credits a truck with roughly twice the placeable count of that family. The same divergence is why the certified bound on the two crush-binding rungs of Table 7 sits 13.3% below the best verified plan: the bound credits every such stack with four layers where two can be carried, and we attribute the gap to the bound rather than to the plan on that evidence — noting that nothing in this paper proves it, and that the fifty-four- and one-hundred-and-sixty-truck plans are reported as what they are, verified upper bounds under a stated budget.

The layer ratio alone does not predict it, and we say so. It is tempting to turn the mechanism into a one-number test, and the obvious candidate fails. Over eighteen generated instances — the benchmark generator's, with product weights scaled to move the dose and nothing else altered, so footprints, heights, demands and seeds are held fixed — the share of a volumetric plan's own dispatched loads that a placeability proof rejects correlates at only 0.42 with the ratio of height-limited to crush-limited layer counts. The sweep contains three instances at 0% with that ratio between 0.98 and 1.25, and one at 90.9% with the ratio at 1.08. The ratio is part of the mechanism and is not a predictor of the share, and a predictor validated across instances is not established here. What *is* established, and is enough for the modelling conclusion, is that the condition is common in a real catalogue: over the fifteen container types of the industrial catalogue the ratio of volumetric credit to placeable count has median 0.923 and ranges from 0.316 to 2.00, with four of the fifteen types credited more than 20% above what fits. A planner can compute that number from the catalogue and the trailer alone, with no model solved, which is the practical value of the mechanism even without a validated predictor of the share.

What volumetric planning costs, constructed rather than estimated. The census says a volumetric plan's loads frequently cannot be placed; it does not say what that costs. To answer that, each volumetric plan is repaired into an executable one on the two instances where the crush limit binds. The *competent* repair keeps the volumetric plan's delivery quantities unchanged and re-packs each period's freight with the same partition-and-pack machinery the method itself uses; every resulting truck is verified. A weaker, load-local repair — splitting each unplaceable load where it stands, with no consolidation — is reported for contrast and is *not* used as the comparison, because consolidation is worth twelve and forty-four trucks and a planner would do it.

	$I_16_15_2_90_k25$	$I_24_20_2_90_k50$
volumetric plan (not executable)	45	137
repaired load by load	86	256
re-packed, quantities kept	**74**	**212**
MATH-3D-SCPTOP (which also chooses the quantities)	**54**	**160**

Against the re-packed baseline the method uses 27.0% and 24.5% fewer trucks and costs 19.1% and 16.2% less, with no pair left unpacked and no truck failing verification in either case; the denominator of every one of those four percentages is the re-packed baseline. The difference between 74 and 54 is what optimising the delivery quantities against the geometry buys, over and above packing the same quantities well. Two qualifications. The re-pack solves a cover, so it ships 80 and 137 units beyond requirement, and pricing only its trucks therefore *understates* its cost — the margins are conservative in the method's favour only in the sense that they are lower bounds on the true difference. And the repaired plan is a *baseline, not a bound*: on $I_8_5_2_90$ the load-local repair needs thirteen trucks where twelve is the proved optimum, because repairing a fixed assignment of freight to trucks is not the same as planning afresh.

A harder volumetric baseline, and what is not yet known about it. The comparison above is against a *plain* volumetric model, and the obvious objection is that a planner who had read this section would not build one: the mechanism is computable from the catalogue, so the capacity could be deflated to reflect it. The honest answer is that a step in that direction has been measured and does not close the gap, and that the rest of it has not been measured at all. Adding to the compact volumetric model the stack-count rows of Section 5.10 — an integer number of stacks per footprint, each within the crush limit and the height budget, their floor areas summed against the trailer floor, which is a valid inequality for every placeable load — raises its answer on $I_16_15_2_90_k25$ from forty-five trucks to forty-eight, at 71 072.06 with a dual bound of 70 435.04 after 600 s, and raises the dual bound of the relaxation by 2 303, about a fifth of the gap the plain bound leaves. On $I_12_12_2_90_k25$, where the crush limit does not bind, the same rows change the truck count not at all.

Two things follow, and we draw only those. The rows are a real tightening of the *bound* and are named in the conclusions as the next step for it. But forty-eight trucks is still eleven percent below the method's verified fifty-four, and *whether those forty-eight loads can be placed has not been tested*: the stack rows are necessary for placeability, not sufficient, since they say nothing about how the stacks tile the floor. Until that test is run, the stack-aware volumetric model is not a baseline this paper can report a saving over, and claiming one would repeat exactly the error the plain volumetric model is being faulted for.

6.8 What the bounds and the claims rest on

Four statements belong with the results rather than with the claims, and they are made here so that every number in this section is read correctly.

No optimum is proved by the method. Optimality is claimed in this paper exactly once, on $I_8_5_2_90$, and it is established by inclusion from an exactly solved relaxation and not by the method's own certification (Section 6.5). In every run reported here the global bound equals the root bound, because a region's certificate is taken from the volumetric relaxation and no such certificate can exceed the relaxation's own optimum; where that optimum coincides with the 3D optimum the method can prove optimality by inclusion, and where the crush limit binds and it does not, the residual gap is not closable by more search. Regions remain open on every row of Table 7 but the first, and a run with open regions has not searched the space whatever its gap.

A lower bound is printed only where a sweep proved it. Where no full sweep completed with every pair proved, the value the run records is the restricted master's, which is an *upper* bound on the master LP, and it is never printed as a bound. One row of Table 12 is in that position and says *unproved*; it is excluded from the mean gap, and the count of rows behind every mean gap in Table 13 is printed beside it for that reason.

The compact 3D model's bound is not a bound on the problem. It restricts each direction a priori to $|L| = 3$ loading configurations, and Proposition 1 states the equivalence only for an unrestricted $|L|$. A restriction's optimum is at or above the problem's, so its dual bound bounds that restriction and not $z^\star$. Its *plan* is used as a comparator and its bound never as an end of an interval. In particular the compact model and the method do *not* bracket the optimum on $I_8_5_2_90$; the interval that holds $z^\star$ there is [18 796.96, 18 796.96], and it comes from the volumetric relaxation.

Every reported plan is verified, and the verifier is independent. Every plan in Tables 12 and 7–11 is re-derived truck by truck from each column's own fill and checked against (39)–(44) by code that shares nothing with the solver that produced it, including the utilisation floor; no plan reported here

carries a complaint. That is a property of the formulation rather than of the search: a column is a witnessed layout, so a plan assembled from columns is executable by construction and can be handed to a loading crew as a drawing. One limitation of the verifier is worth recording: it checks the per-slot crush limit from the stack weight stored with the column rather than re-deriving it from the product fill it is handed, so a load whose products were relabelled after the column was built could pass. Every producer of columns in the implementation keeps the two consistent, so no reported plan is affected, but the check is weaker than the rest of the verifier and making it independent is a correction rather than a research question.

7 Practical application

This section presents a practical procurement transport application. The proposed resolution framework was evaluated using real data from an automotive industry supply chain. We validate and compare the 3D-SCPTOP solution procedures to the company's procedure, which employs predefined loading configurations that indicate the number of each container type to be carried. Finding these loading configurations is a very tedious and time-consuming manual task that is based on a spreadsheet procedure. A mathematical programming model, dubbed as PLC-SCPTOP, which replicates the current's company procedure, is then utilised to minimise the total cost, with a summation of procurement transport and inventory holding costs, and one based on these predetermined configurations.

The real-world data derived from the company's operations act as the empirical foundation for the comparison. To broaden its scope we scale and perturb these data under a stochastic process, giving three scenarios that differ only in demand variability: low (±5%), normal (±15%) and high (±35%) around the same mean. Three procedures are compared on the same instances.

- **Company procedure.** PLC-SCPTOP over the configurations the planner derives today: a truck laid out to follow the *average* container mix across plants and periods, recomputed as the programme is revised, together with one standard single-container-type pattern per RTI type and the partial loads a planner will dispatch rather than miss a delivery.
- **Hand-drawn benchmark.** PLC-SCPTOP over a richer predefined set: a regular grid per container type plus two-zone layouts in which the floor is cut once and each zone tiled with a single footprint. This is more than the planner actually maintains, and is therefore the harder baseline.
- **MATH-3D-SCPTOP** of Section 5, which generates its configurations and augments the planner's existing ones rather than replacing them.

The outcome is reported in Section 6.6, and what it reports is that the comparison is *not available in this revision.* The recorded run on disk fails two independent conditions: its method column was produced by an earlier branch-and-price configuration rather than by the method of Section 5, and all nine company baselines stopped on their time limit rather than at the requested gap of zero, so a saving measured over them is a saving over an unsolved baseline. No cost, truck count or percentage is therefore quoted against the company procedure anywhere in this paper. The reason for setting out the comparison here nonetheless is that it is the *intended* comparator for the 3D rows — Section 6.5 shows that the compact 3D model cannot serve as one — so what it would measure, and what it would not, is part of the argument rather than an appendix to it.

Two findings from the same instances do not depend on the solution procedure and are reported in Section 6.6. The first is the size of the configuration set. Reconstructing the company's set from average mixes alone yields very few distinct configurations when demand is stable — at low variability the horizon average, the thirds and the per-period mixes all coincide — and a set that small may not serve the programme: on three of the nine instances the reconstruction had to be extended by 77, 66 and 73 configurations before the programme could be served at all. Crews do not work from averages either; they accumulate patterns by trial, one for the days a single product runs heavy, another for when two share the load. The second is that on eight of the nine instances a configuration read as dedicated to one product served the programme better than the same configuration shared across an RTI family, which is the same observation from the other side: the planner's catalogue has to be fine-grained to work, and fine-grained catalogues are large.

That is the practical cost of a fixed configuration set. It is not that the procedure fails — the plant plainly operates — but that keeping it feasible as the programme moves requires the planner to maintain a large and growing catalogue by hand, every entry of which was found by trial rather than by design.

The managerial reading is that the benefit on offer is not a better spreadsheet. It is that the loading configuration stops being an input fixed months in advance and becomes a decision taken with the transport plan, so that when the container mix moves the configurations move with it. Whether that is worth a

measurable saving against the procedure in use is the question the case study exists to answer, and this revision does not answer it.

8 Conclusions

We herein propose a MILP model, 3D-SCPTOP, to tackle procurement transportation planning at an operational level by incorporating stack-based full-truck loading constraints into its considerations. Given the NP-hard nature of the placement subproblem and the fact that the compact model replicates it once per loading configuration, we reformulate the problem by Dantzig–Wolfe decomposition, taking the complete loaded truck as the unit of decision, and solve it by a branch and bound over the fleet vector with column generation, a constraint programming pricing oracle and a flow-first construction as primal heuristic, giving MATH-3D-SCPTOP. Because every column is a fully specified truck layout, the plans the method returns are executable by construction and can be handed to a loading crew as a drawing; we verify each dispatched truck independently of the solver that produced it.

A case study has also been conducted within an automotive SC that comprises a car assembler, a first-tier supplier and a second-tier supplier. The objective of the 3D-SCPTOP model is twofold: (i) to minimise the total number of trucks used; (ii) to minimise inventory holding costs. This approach takes into account the complexities of supply chain logistics in the automotive industry by demonstrating a successful integration of procurement transport planning and 3D loading constraints.

Managerial implications in a SC context are oriented to the proposed solution methodology, which is designed to improve on the solutions found by the company's procedure and to adapt to demand changes while returning executable plans in reasonable computational times. The comparison that would measure the first of those against the procedure in use is the one piece of the evaluation this revision does not carry, for the reasons given in Section 6.6, and it is the first thing a next revision should supply.

A second managerial point concerns the representation of transport capacity. Procurement transport models in the literature typically express it volumetrically. Our comparison is built to show that doing so is not a harmless simplification: a volumetric model can return plans that are cheaper on paper precisely because truck loads it prescribes cannot be placed in a trailer at all, and each such load is submitted to an independent placeability proof so that the share is measured rather than asserted. The measurements attach a mechanism to the claim, and bound it: where a container family's height-limited and crush-limited layer counts coincide the volumetric model is adequate — on one five-period instance its optimum *is* the 3D optimum — and where they diverge it credits a truck with roughly twice the placeable count of that family, measured directly as 57 credited against 32 placeable on one instance. The divergence is part of the mechanism and is not by itself a predictor of how many loads will fail: over an eighteen-instance dose–response sweep it correlates at only 0.42 with that share, and a predictor validated across instances remains open. What the catalogue does establish is that the condition is common: over fifteen real container types the ratio of volumetric credit to placeable count has median 0.923 and reaches 2.00, with four types credited more than 20% above what fits. A planner acting on such a plan discovers the shortfall on the loading dock, not in the model.

Nevertheless, several challenges remain for further research lines to deal with; for instance, the inclusion of multiple suppliers to better represent complex supply chains. A more comprehensive transport operation model could be achieved by incorporating routing aspects, such as vehicle routing with 3D loading constraints. Future work may also relax the layer-homogeneity assumption to allow intra-layer mixing of RTI types, or extend the placement block with axle load-balance constraints. On the algorithmic side, the fleet tree is an exact scheme whose bound is certified at the root and at the one region that could refute the incumbent, and in no run reported here did it close its gap: the cost of certifying every node with a geometric pricing oracle is what stands between the matheuristic and a proof, and a cheaper certificate for the constraint programme is the natural next step. The construction under 3D loading keeps the volumetric partition as a relaxation and cuts off the parts a placeability proof refutes; where the volumetric relaxation is nearly exact its cost is dominated by the aggregate integer masters it shares with the volumetric method, and where the crush limit binds it is dominated by the placeability proofs, so both are where scaling effort belongs. The bound is the other open end. On the catalogue where the crush limit halves a family's layer count the certified volumetric bound sits 13.3% below the best verified plan, a gap we attribute to the bound and not to the plan, since the instances on which it does not bind measure under 0.05%; and the remedy is already in the method's own rows. The stack-count relaxation that step 2 and the partition use — an integer number of stacks per footprint, each holding at most $W^{\max}$ of weight and rK of height, their floor areas summed against the trailer floor — is a necessary condition for any placeable load under the crush rule (42). Its continuous crush row, $\sum_f \text{area}_f \, (\sum_{c \in f} w_c a_c)/W^{\max} \le pK \cdot qK$, is a third knapsack resource for the

volumetric pricing oracle that certifies the reported bound, and for a footprint carried by a single RTI type an integer-layer height row, $\sum_{c\in f} a_c \le \lfloor rK/h_f \rfloor\, s_f$, joins it. The per-commodity form $\sum_c (\text{area}_c/\text{layers}_c)\, a_c$ is *not* valid where products of different binding layer counts share a footprint: one heavy crush-limited layer under two light height-limited ones is a legal stack that the row charges $1/2+2/3$ of a stack, and it is exactly the mixed stack the heuristic rung builds on that catalogue. In the column master the rows are implied, since every column is placeable; they bite only in the relaxation, and on a catalogue where crush does not bind they change nothing. We record this as the next step, with its validity argument and without a result. The other limit was the primal at scale, and it has moved. On the twenty-period instance an uncapped cut-and-repack walk consumed the hour on the first fourteen of forty (direction, period) pairs and built no plan, while the pool, the pricing and the certificate all scaled. Step 3 exists to generate columns and not to realise a partition, so a pair whose parts do not place need not be pursued round after round; with the rounds capped at two, the parts that did place kept as columns and the failing pairs left to the integer master, the same instance returns a verified one-hundred-and-sixty-truck plan. What remains open there is the aggregate masters, which take two thirds of that run and are shared with the volumetric method, and the five instances of the generated set — all at the coarsest granularity — on which no plan is returned inside the budget at all. Integrating sourcing and delivery transport decisions could improve supply chain efficiency. Finally, the incorporation of production scheduling into the model has the potential of offering a cohesive approach to supply chain planning optimisation by aligning production timelines with transportation and inventory strategies.

A The SCPTOP benchmark

The benchmark against which 3D-SCPTOP is compared is an extension of the procurement transport model of (Díaz-Madroñero, Mula, and Peidro 2014) to the closed-loop, two-node setting studied here. Three modifications are made to that model, as stated in Section 6: fuzzy parameters are dropped; the transport capacity restriction is expressed through the volume of the individual RTIs against the truck volume rather than a maximum container count; and a product may travel in more than one RTI type.

The point of the comparison is to isolate the effect of the loading representation, so SCPTOP is made *identical to the transport and inventory block of 3D-SCPTOP in every other respect*: the same two nodes, the same closed loop of full and folded RTIs, the same lead time, the same coverage stock, the same payload cap, the same full-truckload floor and the same objective. It differs in exactly one place — where 3D-SCPTOP asks whether the RTIs can be stacked and placed on the trailer floor, SCPTOP asks only whether their volumes sum to less than the trailer's.

Let $Y_{gkt} \in \{0,1\}$ indicate that truck k is used in direction g in period t, and let Q^k_{nt} and Q^k_{rt} be the full RTIs of product n, respectively the folded RTIs of type r, that it carries. All remaining notation is that of Table 3.

$$\text{Min } z = \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{k\in K}\sum_{t\in T} cK\, Y_{gkt} + \sum_{g\in G}\sum_{n\in N}\sum_{t\in T} ic_{gn} I_{gnt} \tag{82}$$

subject to, for all $k \in K$ and $t \in T$,

$$\sum_{n\in N} \gamma_{p\rho(n)} Q^k_{nt} \le \Gamma_K\, Y_{pkt}, \qquad \sum_{r\in R} \gamma_{sr} Q^k_{rt} \le \Gamma_K\, Y_{skt} \tag{83}$$

$$\sum_{n\in N} w_n Q^k_{nt} \le pK^w Y_{pkt}, \qquad \sum_{r\in R} w^{\mathrm{f}}_r Q^k_{rt} \le pK^w Y_{skt} \tag{84}$$

together with the full-truckload floor on the binding resource, imposed exactly as in (43): a dispatched truck must reach a fraction α of *either* the trailer volume or the payload,

$$\sum_n \gamma_{p\rho(n)} Q^k_{nt} \;\ge\; \alpha\Gamma_K\big(Y_{pkt} - 1 + \theta_{kt}\big), \qquad \sum_n w_n Q^k_{nt} \;\ge\; \alpha\, pK^w\big(Y_{pkt} - \theta_{kt}\big), \tag{85}$$

with $\theta_{kt} \in \{0,1\}$ and the supplier direction analogous. The flows aggregate as $Q_{nt} = \sum_k Q^k_{nt}$ and $Q_{rt} = \sum_k Q^k_{rt}$, and the inventory balances, coverage stock and domains are those of (2)–(12), unchanged.

Constraint (83) is the whole of the benchmark's loading model: a truck is deemed able to carry any set of RTIs whose volumes fit inside the trailer's. No footprint, stack height, layer count or crush limit appears. Section 6 reports what that omission costs — not in solution quality, where SCPTOP appears cheaper, but in whether the plans it prescribes can be loaded at all.

Why the floor is imposed on the binding resource. Writing (85) on volume alone, as the original formulation does, makes dense freight structurally infeasible: filling α of a 97.9 m^3 trailer with RTIs at 590 kg/m^3 weighs 27.4 t against a 24 t cap, so no truck is dispatchable and the instance is empty. Summing the two ratios instead is strictly weaker — it accepts a truck 35% full by volume and 20% by weight. The disjunctive form above is used identically in every model compared here, so no method is held to an easier standard than another.

References

Ali, Sara et al. (June 2022). "On-line three-dimensional packing problems: A review of off-line and on-line solution approaches". In: *Computers and Industrial Engineering* 168. ISSN: 03608352. DOI: 10.1016/j.cie.2022.108122.

Alonso, M. T., R. Alvarez-Valdes, and F. Parreño (Mar. 2020). "A GRASP algorithm for multi container loading problems with practical constraints". In: *4OR* 18.1, pp. 49–72. ISSN: 16142411. DOI: 10.1007/s10288-018-0397-z.

Alonso, M. T., A. Martinez-Sykora, et al. (Nov. 2022). "The pallet-loading vehicle routing problem with stability constraints: The pallet-loading vehicle routing problem with stability constraints. Second revision". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 302.3, pp. 860–873. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2022.01.035.

Baller, Reinhard et al. (July 2022). "Optimizing automotive inbound logistics: A mixed-integer linear programming approach". In: *Transportation Research Part E: Logistics and Transportation Review* 163. ISSN: 13665545. DOI: 10.1016/j.tre.2022.102734.

Berman, Oded and Qian Wang (2006). "Inbound logistic planning: Minimizing transportation and inventory cost". In: *Transportation Science* 40.3, pp. 287–299. ISSN: 15265447. DOI: 10.1287/trsc.1050.0130.

Bortfeldt, Andreas and Gerhard Wäscher (Aug. 2013). "Constraints in container loading-A state-of-the-art review". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 229.1, pp. 1–20. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2012.12.006.

Chen, C S, S M Lee, and Q S Shen (1995). *EUROPEAN JOURNAL OF OPERATIONAL RESEARCH An analytical model for the container loading problem.* Tech. rep., pp. 68–76.

Chen, Mingzhou, Jiazhen Huo, and Yongrui Duan (June 2023). "A hybrid biogeography-based optimization algorithm for three-dimensional bin size designing and packing problem". In: *Computers and Industrial Engineering* 180. ISSN: 03608352. DOI: 10.1016/j.cie.2023.109239.

Chitsaz, Masoud, Jean François Cordeau, and Raf Jans (Dec. 2019). "A unified decomposition matheuristic for assembly, production, and inventory routing". In: *INFORMS Journal on Computing* 31.1, pp. 134–152. ISSN: 15265528. DOI: 10.1287/ijoc.2018.0817.

Chopra, Sunil and Peter Meindl (2015). *Supply chain management : strategy, planning, and operation.* ISBN: 9780133800203.

Díaz-Madroñero, Manuel, Josefa Mula, and David Peidro (Sept. 2014). *A review of discrete-time optimization models for tactical production planning.* DOI: 10.1080/00207543.2014.899721.

— (Dec. 2017). "A mathematical programming model for integrating production and procurement transport decisions". In: *Applied Mathematical Modelling* 52, pp. 527–543. ISSN: 0307904X. DOI: 10.1016/j.apm.2017.08.009.

Díaz-Madroñero, Manuel, David Peidro, and Josefa Mula (Dec. 2014). "A fuzzy optimization approach for procurement transport operational planning in an automobile supply chain". In: *Applied Mathematical Modelling* 38.23, pp. 5705–5725. ISSN: 0307904X. DOI: 10.1016/j.apm.2014.04.053.

— (Oct. 2015). *A review of tactical optimization models for integrated production and transport routing planning decisions.* DOI: 10.1016/j.cie.2015.06.010.

Dominguez, Oscar et al. (Jan. 2016). "Using biased randomization for solving the two-dimensional loading vehicle routing problem with heterogeneous fleet". In: *Annals of Operations Research* 236.2, pp. 383–404. ISSN: 15729338. DOI: 10.1007/s10479-014-1551-4.

Dyckhoff, Harald (1990). *A typology of cutting and packing problems.* Tech. rep., pp. 145–159.

Fleischmann, Bernhard, Herbert Kopfer, and Christopher Sürie (Mar. 2015). "Transport Planning for Procurement and Distribution". In: *Supply Chain Management and Advanced Planning*. Ed. by Hartmut Stadtler, Christoph Kilger, and Herbert Meyr. Springer Texts in Business and Economics. Springer. Chap. 12, pp. 225–240. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-642-55309-7. URL: https://ideas.repec.org/h/spr/sptchp/978-3-642-55309-7_12.html.

Gonçalves, José Fernando and Mauricio G.C. Resende (Oct. 2013). "A biased random key genetic algorithm for 2D and 3D bin packing problems". In: *International Journal of Production Economics* 145.2, pp. 500–510. ISSN: 09255273. DOI: 10.1016/j.ijpe.2013.04.019.

Guo, Min et al. (2024). "Incentivising-by-penalty: The optimal return strategy for a reusable transport item rental platform". In: *Transportation Research Part D: Transport and Environment* 134, p. 104339. ISSN: 1361-9209. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.trd.2024.104339. URL: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1361920924002967.

Harrath, Youssef (Sept. 2022). "A three-stage layer-based heuristic to solve the 3D bin-packing problem under balancing constraint". In: *Journal of King Saud University - Computer and Information Sciences* 34 (8), pp. 6425–6431. ISSN: 22131248. DOI: 10.1016/j.jksuci.2021.07.007.

Hashemi-Amiri, Omid, Fahimeh Ghorbani, and Ran Ji (Jan. 2023). "Integrated supplier selection, scheduling, and routing problem for perishable product supply chain: A distributionally robust approach". In: *Computers and Industrial Engineering* 175. ISSN: 03608352. DOI: 10.1016/j.cie.2022.108845.

Hein, Fanny and Christian Almeder (July 2016). "Quantitative insights into the integrated supply vehicle routing and production planning problem". In: *International Journal of Production Economics* 177, pp. 66–76. ISSN: 09255273. DOI: 10.1016/j.ijpe.2016.04.014.

Junqueira, Leonardo, Reinaldo Morabito, and Denise Sato Yamashita (2012a). "MIP-based approaches for the container loading problem with multi-drop constraints". In: *Annals of Operations Research* 199.1, pp. 51–75. ISSN: 15729338. DOI: 10.1007/s10479-011-0942-z.

— (Jan. 2012b). "Three-dimensional container loading models with cargo stability and load bearing constraints". In: *Computers and Operations Research* 39.1, pp. 74–85. ISSN: 03050548. DOI: 10.1016/j.cor.2010.07.017.

Junqueira, Leonardo, José F. Oliveira, et al. (Sept. 2013). "An optimization model for the vehicle routing problem with practical three-dimensional loading constraints". In: *International Transactions in Operational Research* 20.5, pp. 645–666. ISSN: 09696016. DOI: 10.1111/j.1475-3995.2012.00872.x.

Kurpel, Deidson Vitorio et al. (July 2020). "The exact solutions of several types of container loading problems". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 284.1, pp. 87–107. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2019.12.012.

Langley, C. John et al. (2020). *Supply Chain Management: A Logistics Perspective*. 11th. Cengage Learning, pp. 413–452.

Li, Ying, Mingzhou Chen, and Jiazhen Huo (Mar. 2022). "A hybrid adaptive large neighborhood search algorithm for the large-scale heterogeneous container loading problem". In: *Expert Systems with Applications* 189. ISSN: 09574174. DOI: 10.1016/j.eswa.2021.115909.

Mahvash, Batoul, Anjali Awasthi, and Satyaveer Chauhan (2018). "A column generation-based heuristic for the three-dimensional bin packing problem with rotation". In: *Journal of the Operational Research Society* 69 (1), pp. 78–90. ISSN: 14769360. DOI: 10.1057/s41274-017-0186-7.

Meyer, Anne and Boris Amberg (May 2018). "Transport concept selection considering supplier milk runs – An integrated model and a case study from the automotive industry". In: *Transportation Research Part E: Logistics and Transportation Review* 113, pp. 147–169. ISSN: 13665545. DOI: 10.1016/j.tre.2017.07.004.

Mosca, Alyssa, Navneet Vidyarthi, and Ahmet Satir (Jan. 2019). *Integrated transportation – inventory models: A review*. DOI: 10.1016/j.orp.2019.100101.

Paquay, C, M Schyns, and S Limbourg (2016). "INTERNATIONAL TRANSACTIONS IN OPERATIONAL RESEARCH A mixed integer programming formulation for the three-dimensional bin packing problem deriving from an air cargo application". In: *Intl. Trans. in Op. Res* 23, pp. 187–213. DOI: 10.1111/itor.12111. URL: https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/itor.12111.

Que, Quanqing, Fang Yang, and Defu Zhang (Mar. 2023). "Solving 3D packing problem using Transformer network and reinforcement learning". In: *Expert Systems with Applications* 214. ISSN: 09574174. DOI: 10.1016/j.eswa.2022.119153.

Sancak, Emre and F. Sibel Salman (June 2011). "Multi-item dynamic lot-sizing with delayed transportation policy". In: *International Journal of Production Economics* 131.2, pp. 595–603. ISSN: 09255273. DOI: 10.1016/j.ijpe.2011.02.004.

Schöneberg, Tim, Achim Koberstein, and Leena Suhl (Dec. 2010). "An optimization model for automated selection of economic and ecologic delivery profiles in area forwarding based inbound logistics networks". In: *Flexible Services and Manufacturing Journal* 22.3-4, pp. 214–235. ISSN: 19366582. DOI: 10.1007/s10696-011-9084-5.

— (Nov. 2013). "A stochastic programming approach to determine robust delivery profiles in area forwarding inbound logistics networks". In: *OR Spectrum* 35.4, pp. 807–834. ISSN: 01716468. DOI: 10.1007/s00291-013-0349-0.

Silva, Everton Fernandes, Túlio Angelo Machado Toffolo, and Tony Wauters (Sept. 2019). "Exact methods for three-dimensional cutting and packing: A comparative study concerning single container problems". In: *Computers and Operations Research* 109, pp. 12–27. ISSN: 03050548. DOI: 10.1016/j.cor.2019.04.020.

Soysal, Mehmet et al. (2023). "Managing returnable transport items in a vendor managed inventory system". In: *Socio-Economic Planning Sciences* 86, p. 101504. ISSN: 0038-0121. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.seps.2022.101504. URL: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0038012122003111.

Stadtler, Hartmut, Christoph Kilger, and Herbert Meyr (2015). *Supply Chain Management and Advanced Planning*. Vol. 5th Edition. URL: http://www.springer.com/series/10099.

Tresca, Giulia et al. (July 2022). "Automating Bin Packing: A Layer Building Matheuristics for Cost Effective Logistics". In: *IEEE Transactions on Automation Science and Engineering* 19 (3), pp. 1599–1613. ISSN: 15583783. DOI: 10.1109/TASE.2022.3177422.

Wäscher, Gerhard, Heike Haußner, and Holger Schumann (Dec. 2007). "An improved typology of cutting and packing problems". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 183.3, pp. 1109–1130. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2005.12.047.

Wei, Lijun et al. (June 2015). "A variable neighborhood search for the capacitated vehicle routing problem with two-dimensional loading constraints". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 243.3, pp. 798–814. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2014.12.048.

Zhang, Yipei et al. (2024). "Closed-loop inventory routing problem for perishable food with returnable transport items selection". In: *International Journal of Production Research* 62.1-2, pp. 501–521. DOI: 10.1080/00207543.2023.2275639. eprint: https://doi.org/10.1080/00207543.2023.2275639. URL: https://doi.org/10.1080/00207543.2023.2275639.

Zhao, Hang, Chenyang Zhu, and Hui Huang (2022). "Learning practically feasible policies for online 3D bin packing". In: 65.112105, p. 17. DOI: 10.1007/s11432-021-3348-6. URL: https://doi.org/10.1007/s11432-021-3348-6.

Zhao, Xiaozhou et al. (2016). "INTERNATIONAL TRANSACTIONS IN OPERATIONAL RESEARCH A comparative review of 3D container loading algorithms". In: *Intl. Trans. in Op. Res* 23, pp. 287–320. DOI: 10.1111/itor.12094. URL: https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/itor.12094.

Zhu, Wenbin and Andrew Lim (Nov. 2012). "A new iterative-doubling Greedy-Lookahead algorithm for the single container loading problem". In: *European Journal of Operational Research* 222.3, pp. 408–417. ISSN: 03772217. DOI: 10.1016/j.ejor.2012.04.036.